wreathed in an endless dawn

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wreathed in an endless dawn

by hybriade

Summary

Mydei is stuck in a strange state of existence. While most believe him an alpha due to his outward appearance and reputation as a fierce warrior, he has no secondary gender and a limited sense of smell.

Usually, he wouldn't care and even prefers not having to deal with heats and ruts, but lately, being around Phainon has him feeling off-center. There's a weird prickling sensation in his nape that won't go away, and his entire body heats up at even the slightest provocation.

Is he, somehow, growing allergic to Phainon? Is that what this is?

Alternatively, Mydei presents as an omega because of one very oblivious Deliverer and has to deal with the consequences.

Notes

phaidei omegaverse where everyone is happy and alive bc 3.3 wrecked me haha :D

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Do you yield?” Mydei asks, his knee pressed tightly against Phainon’s neck.

“I yield,” Phainon replies, breathless.

Even after getting his ass thoroughly kicked, Phainon remains energetic as ever, all wide smiles and brilliant blue eyes. Laid flat on the floor with his arms up and chest rapidly rising and falling, he watches Mydei with squinted eyes and a loopy grin.

Like a lush meadow during springtime, the air is sweet with notes of fragrant citrus and smooth vanilla, cut with freshly picked lavender. It’s cloyingly strong like a thick perfume and brings with it the beginnings of a headache. Mydei is half tempted to cover his nose, but he resists. There’s little use in doing so.

It’s been this way as of late—a new sensitivity to scents when only a month ago he failed to detect any.

Customary as he always does after winning a spar, Mydei pulls himself off Phainon and offers his hand to the alpha. Phainon takes it with grace, his scent softening as blue eyes glimmer.

Their palms connect. A snap of electricity rushes down Mydei’s spine and seizes his throat. He yanks his hand back, his heart drumming fast against his chest.

“Mydei?” Phainon questions.

What the…

His entire body tingles uncomfortably. That singular touch reverberates through his core and lights a flame he never knew existed. The world around him seems to blur in a swirl of muted color.

“Earth to Mydeimos.” Phainon waves a hand in front of Mydei’s face. “I didn’t punch you that hard, did I?”

“Fine,” Mydei manages to say. With a slightly shaky hand, he wipes at his brow. “I’m fine. Worry about yourself first, Deliverer.”

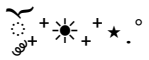
Phainon’s expression dips for a second, and his scent shifts, once bright now slightly charred, but thankfully, he doesn’t press on any further. Instead, he says, “Since you won, I guess I owe you a meal. There’s this new restaurant that opened recently that apparently serves the best stuffed grape leaves in all of Okhema. Are you good with that for dinner?”

“Sure,” Mydei responds. He doesn’t have much of an appetite, hasn’t for a few days now, but if Phainon’s footing the bill, then who is he to refuse?

Dust covers the crevices and dips of his clothing and his cape is a little torn from where it caught onto Phainon’s fist, all remnants of a friendly yet aggressive spar. He brushes himself off and places a hand to his nape where a strange sensation has taken afoot. It feels as if he’s being pricked by a thousand tiny needles all at once, chilling yet blistering hot all at once. He tries massaging the area but a wave of dizziness rushes over, like the high tide overtaking dry rock on a summer day.

“Mydei?” Phainon calls out, turning around. “You coming?”

He blinks. The sensation subsides. “Yes,” he says. “I’m coming.”



It only gets worse. Whenever he’s near Phainon, which is most of the time now that he thinks about it, the symptoms flare up. Where words and expressions fail to communicate, Phainon’s scent spills out unrestrained and Mydei, for reasons unknown, can detect even the most miniscule changes, how it brightens into floral notes when he sees chimeras chirping and bouncing around and the slight char when he realizes he bought yet another fake antique.

He finds himself watching Phainon’s every movement, a subconscious want in his chest to keep the alpha happy and content. When Phainon’s scent dips and flattens, it makes him feel deeply unsettled as if his heart is being squeezed and pulled. The desire to bring the smile back onto the alpha’s face becomes overwhelming, fiercely intense as if he’s staring right into Kephale’s never-ending dawn.

… Huh? He almost wants to hit himself.

What is wrong with him? Seriously, what the hell?

At night, he can barely sleep, tossing and turning as the burning in his nape ebbs and flows. His entire body feels *hot*, the heat blistering even against the chilled air of his bedroom. It’s a miracle he isn’t emitting steam because he feels like he’s being broiled in an oven. Shrugging off his red silk tunic, he pushes it to the side of his bed and lays there in only a pair of thin boxers.

His world is off-center. He doesn’t feel right anymore. There’s no pain, only a strange feeling of dizziness that punctuates his every movement and a weird aversion to the outside world. His head spins, vision a blurry mix of colors and shapes as his surroundings cave in on him, trapping and suffocating him as the walls close in. His sense of smell seems to have also sharpened, much to his dismay, and he can barely leave his room without being inundated with a new bout of dizziness and nausea.

Though he desperately tries to remain unaffected, it's rather obvious he's not alright. His fellow Kremnoans, particularly the soldiers he trains with, have begun to question his health, worry present in their voices as they speak to him. He waves them off as he always does.

For once in his life, he's glad that he's the crown prince. For better or worse, no one tries to question or argue against him.

Is this some sort of sickness? He ponders to himself but there's been no reports of such an ailment. It seems only he's affected. Maybe a visit to Hyacine is in order, but he's leaving for a rescue mission soon. For now, he feels okay enough. He shouldn't be so severely affected that he's unable to complete the mission. Years of physical and mental strain have given him the foresight to know his limits. He's been through far worse, and in comparison this is nothing. He should be fine. At least, that's what he tells himself, even as he rubs his arms to abate the chills.

He can't waste time. There are people who need to be rescued.

The destination is a day's travel away in a far and remote corner of the Amphoreus, assumed to have been abandoned long ago. For most who live in these treacherous lands, Okhema is a safe haven. Displaced out of their homes because of the Black Tide, many have been brought over as refugees, but there are a few villages and small cities dotted all over that refuse to bend down and leave their homes behind, abandoning their culture and history.

Moving over to Okhema means assimilation. Stubbornly clinging onto the last vestiges of their home, many resist until the very end, claimed by the Black Tide before there's any hope of rescue. This particular village has recently been recently overrun, their pleas for help reaching Aglaea who has requested his assistance.

In the calm of his bedroom, Mydei runs through his cabinets. There's not much to bring on this mission, but he still wants a few changes of clothing and some basic toiletries. Phainon sits at the edge of his bed, wiping away at his greatsword.

"When are you leaving?" Phainon asks.

"In a few hours," Mydei replies, distracted. He can't remember where he put his teleslate. He thought he had it on him, but it seems to have disappeared. It's not in his pocket or anywhere nearby.

Phainon regards him, doesn't say anything, only places his sword down and stands up. Mydei is acutely aware of the other moving closer but he doesn't expect Phainon to place his hand on his forehead. Meant only as a show of concern, it brings yet another shock of electricity, igniting the fire in his body. His breathing hitches and he finds he wants to nuzzle into that touch, wants to bare his neck and—

Mydei pulls away as if scalded.

Phainon stares in mute surprise, his gloved hand frozen in place. He brings it down and blows a stray strand of hair out of his face. "You know, I didn't want to mention it again but you've been acting really strange lately."

“Have I?” Mydei says flatly. His ears burn as another bout of dizziness makes its way over. Stubbornly, he blinks it away and steels himself, forcing away the vertigo with sheer will. It works a little, if he can ignore the way the reds and blacks of his bedroom seem to meld together.

Phainon laughs. “I’ve been winning more recently and it’s definitely not because I’m improving at such a fast rate, though it would be nice if that were the case…”

“You’re not one to speak like this,” Mydei notes. “Perhaps you should go see Hyacine.”

“I could say the same to you,” Phainon shoots back. “You look paler than usual and have none of the bravado you normally do.”

“Tch.”

Phainon shrugs. “Nothing to say to that, hm?”

“I’m fine.”

“Are you sure you’re up for that solo mission?” Phainon says. “It looks more like you should go rest. I can take it instead.”

“I will go on the mission.” He’s getting a little sick of being constantly asked if he’s alright, looked at as if he can’t take care of himself.

“You don’t seem—”

“Deliverer, I will throw you off my balcony right this moment if you do not stop with your incessant prodding,” Mydei hisses. “I. Am. Fine.”

Phainon puts his hands up. “Okay, okay. No need to get so defensive. I worry for you sometimes, y’know…”

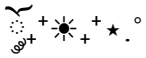
His scent shifts, dulled down. Immediately, Mydei wants to placate him, wants to tell him it’s okay and that he doesn’t mean it, but he shakes away the feeling. The silent wish stays nuzzled tightly against his chest, regardless of how much he tries to pull his thoughts away. He doesn’t even want to begin to think about why he feels like this.

The buzzing and the prickling in his neck worsens by the second, but, still, he wants Phainon here. This will be the last time they’ll see each other for a week or longer. Even a mission as routine as this one can be a cause for disaster.

Mydei lays down on his bed, enjoying the feeling of soft cotton against his bare back. “There’s no need to worry, Deliverer. If I can’t handle it, I will tell you or alert Aglaea before I leave.”

“If you say so…” Phainon says. His attention turns to the device left haphazardly on the nightstand. “Your teleslate is right there, by the way.”

Mydei turns over. “Hmph.”



It seems leaving Okhema is the best option to deal with the strange ailments that have been plaguing him. The further away he is from the hustle and bustle of the city, the better he feels. Or atleast, that's what he thinks at first.

The prickling sensation in the back of his neck subsides for the first few days only to exponentially worsen the longer he's away. Sometimes he even finds his thoughts flitting to Phainon, wondering what the other man is up to and if he's taking care of himself. He wonders if Phainon is eating properly and if he's gotten himself scammed once more. Against all rational thought, he also wonders if Phainon misses him the same way he misses Phainon.

He might be going crazy. This is insanity.

Yes, he does care for Phainon, but never have his thoughts wandered in such an inappropriate manner. And yes, he can begrudgingly admit he misses the other man's warm presence, his non-stop talking and overly bright smiles, but that doesn't mean all his thoughts have to center on him. Mr. Sunshine, Phainon's been called by many an Okheman, and Mydei can't argue against it because it's true. There's a sweetness in the way those brilliant blue eyes curve and crinkle at the edges, and Mydei finds himself wanting to hoard Phainon's smiles all for himself.

Damn it. He's slipping again. Shaking away the embarrassing thoughts, he continues to his destination.

Thankfully, the mission goes smoothly. Black Tide monsters eradicated, villagers rescued. No casualties though many buildings have been levelled and the area is almost unlivable with corruption crawling in every corner. The stench of destruction blankets the area, dust from scorched debris and the wailing pheromones emitting from the scraps of monsters etched out of metal and decay.

Mydei runs a hand through his hair as he silently watches the villagers debate about their future. His body feels hot, and his head aches constantly, a pressure behind his temples that doesn't abate no matter how much he rubs. His chest also aches, sore in a way that makes him feel empty yet full at the same time. The burning in his nape, once a thousand needles, now feels like fire ants crawling and biting all over. There's even a strange and unwelcome wetness between his thighs that he refuses to even consider. It's not sweat, that much he knows. Sweat is not that thick.

When they make it back to the city and the villagers are all settled, he meets with Aglaea in the privacy of the Hero's Bath and recounts the mission, going over any pertinent information and findings. There's nothing much to speak about aside from the Black Tide continuing to mutate with the corrupted titankin becoming a little stronger and faster than before.

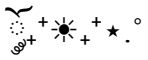
As she always does, Aglaea nods and regards him with those crystalline gold eyes, but somehow, this time it feels different. It's as if she's looking through him with the way she stares, unblinking as her expression takes one of deep contemplation.

Her scent remains a careful neutral, instead of overbearing and suffocating. Aglaea, the picture of grace and beauty, is an alpha yet she never presents herself as such, never one to intimidate through pheromones or signs of aggression. Instead, she remains calm and collected regardless of whether she's on the battlefield or speaking casually with a fellow heir.

"You should go rest," she tells him. "I recommend taking a bath in your own room and not at the communal bath house. If you wish, you can also bathe in the Chrysos Heir private bath."

Confused, Mydei asks, "Did something happen while I was away?" His muscles ache from exertion and a hot bath would do wonders to release the tension in his back and the burning in his nape. The public baths have always held a soft spot in his heart and brings back memories of when he first arrived in Okhema years ago.

"It's the more suitable option," she says. Her tone leaves little room for argument. "That is all."



The next few days are spent in complete recuperation. Mydei doesn't go outside at all and instead shuts himself in his room while he tries to figure out what's going on with his body. It feels like he's burning from the inside out, and he wakes up in cold sweat every couple of hours.

When he finally feels okay enough to brave the dawn, he finds himself at a complete loss. It doesn't happen often that he finds himself feeling such, but it's been a common occurrence as of late. Is he cursed? Did he inadvertently walk into a hex and didn't even notice?

That would explain the strange symptoms and bouts of bad luck, but never is the answer so simple.

As he strolls down Marmoreal Market for the first time since his return, he instantly knows something is wrong. All eyes are on him, watching, prying. It's as if a spotlight has been cast down, illuminating and bringing forth all attention.

Then comes the whispers. If they could even be called such. Far too loud and overly excited, almost like they're egging him on for a response. He does not take the bait.

"Haven't you heard? The crown prince of Castrum Kremnos has found an omega lover! Seems like it's true…" one woman says as she watches him walk by.

To which her friend giggles and responds, “Really now? First I’ve heard of that… Well, what are you waiting for?! Spill the details!”

“It’s said she’s a recent rescue from a nearby deserted village. No one has ever seen her face. Seems like the prince is intent on keeping her hidden, you know typical possessive alpha behavior…”

He has absolutely no clue where these baseless rumors originate from and why they seem to be so widespread. His stroll through Kephale Plaza also resulted in the same scrutiny. Yes, it’s true, he had recently been out on a mission and did indeed rescue some civilians trapped within the grasp of unstable titankin, but that’s the entirety of what happened.

Unfortunately, it seems whenever he walks by, no matter what part of the city, whether it's the markets or the baths or the residential areas, he sees groups of people huddling together, whispering and staring at him like he’s some kind of interesting specimen for them to gawk at.
The air is heavy with a plethora of scents, mixing together into a strange concoction that makes his throat itch. His symptoms have mostly abated, aside from the heaviness in his chest, but he finds he’s starting to regret leaving the safety of his bedroom.

He’s even had a few of his own countrymen approach him to congratulate him for finding a suitable mate. One soldier, a little drunk, even proclaims the royal lineage to be saved.

“About time, Lord Mydeimos! A beautiful omega she must be to be worthy to bear your pups,” the man says, face red from the alcohol sloshing in his glass. Some of it spills onto his already stained chiton. “The royal lineage is saved! Glory to Castrum Kremnos!”

Mydei has no clue how to react. What is he even supposed to say? All he does is stand there, watching as the man bows and hobbles off.

It seems like the best way to get over ideological and cultural differences is gossip. He’s never seen the people of Okhema so united, all over a frankly idiotic and unfounded rumor no less. Maybe it’s a good thing? He reminds himself to tell Aglaea about this new tactic, camaraderie through gossip, though she probably already knows.

“What do you think she looks like?”

“She must be a catch to strike the fancy of the crown prince.”

“Her scent is so sweet and inviting. Any alpha would fall on their knees—Hey! What was that for?!”

“Careful! You know how the Kremnoans are. You don’t want to earn his ire.”

It’s rather difficult trying to eat when the restaurant's patrons keep eyeing him. All he wants is some peace and quiet, but instead, he’s getting loud whispers, pointing fingers, and hushed giggles. Though mildly annoying, it’s still not enough to deter him from leaving the establishment. When he first arrived in Okhema, he and the rest of the Kremnoans weren't exactly met with the best reception, so he’s learned to ignore unwanted attention.

Doesn't mean he enjoys it though.

He can handle the cityfolk, but, of course, his tumultuous day wouldn't be complete without a visit from Phainon who waltzes in like he owns the place. Truly, a surefire coincidence for him to be at this specific restaurant at this specific hour.

"Mydei!" Phainon exclaims. "Fancy seeing you here! You've been ignoring my texts again."

"Deliverer," Mydei greets gruffly.

Phainon sits down beside him and calls for a menu. Like always, he's grinning widely, a blinding ray of sunshine, but there's a tightness at the corner of his lips that Mydei notices right away.

"I heard the news circulating," Phainon begins. "Seems like it's accurate."

Oh titans, not him too. This better not be what Mydei thinks its about.

"Your entire body is covered in her scent," Phainon laughs. "I heard you rescued her from some corrupted titankin. Must have been love at first sight!"

Mydei fights the urge to sigh. There it is. His worst fears are confirmed. For even Phainon to believe in such a dumb rumor… He only hopes the other heirs aren't daft enough to believe these baseless words.

And what does he mean by his entire body covered in omega scent? He doesn't smell anything. At least, nothing out of the ordinary.

Mydei takes a bite of his pomegranate honeycakes. The warm, cloudlike sweetness melts in his mouth eliciting a small quirk of his lips. He twirls his fork around as he indulges himself.

"So…" Phainon says as he places his menu down. "What is she like?"

Instead of responding, Mydei takes another piece of honeycake and ensures it's suitably doused in warm honey syrup, whipped cream, and pomegranate seeds to create the most ideal bite. He's still aware of all the pairs of eyes on him, but it's not that big of a deal. He does not, however, appreciate Phainon's brilliant blues burning a hole through his skull.

Said simply, Phainon is different from the rest of the curious crowd. Mydei almost wants to punch him for believing such rumors. He hasn't seen the other heir for nearly two weeks and this is his first greeting? Unbelievable.

Though he tries, it seems he can't hide the slight scrunch of his features. Under Phainon's watchful eye, nothing goes undetected.

"Mydei," he says, scooting closer.

"None of your business, Deliverer," Mydei settles on saying. Really, what is he to say? Especially with so many people around. Anything he says has the potential to set off a new chain of rumors. For now, he has to figure out exactly what caused this weird turn of events.

He comes up with nothing. After meeting with Aglaea, he returned to his residence and stayed there, delirious, until he finally collected enough wits to go outside. Where did these rumors even come from?

Lost in thought, he's unaware of the hand that reaches out to wipe the side of his lip.

Instinctively, Mydei jerks back.

Phainon smiles. His blinding blue eyes, at first glance, seem innocent, but Mydei can see the deception hiding within.

"You have some cream here," Phainon says like it's oh so simple. He shows the dollop on his finger. "See?"

The prickling sensation returns once more. Mydei already feels a headache building, just when he thinks he's feeling better. Great.

"It would be uncouth for the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos to walk around with cream smeared on his lip," Phainon continues, acting blissfully unaware of Mydei's inner turmoil. His tongue peaks out to taste the sweetness on his finger, whilst maintaining eye contact.

Brilliant blue clashes against molten amber. Mydei fights the urge to look away, unwilling to concede defeat. It's strange really. What has gotten into Phainon? Rather inappropriate behavior, if he has anything to say about it.

"Deliverer, you…" Mydei trails off. The stinging in his nape only increases with each passing second. Once more, a thousand burning needles repeatedly jab into his skin. His thighs also begin to ache, the beginnings of familiar wetness.

He's going crazy. This is some kind of weird fever dream. He's still asleep in his room, dealing with yet another bout of strange dreams. It has to be, because Phainon would never do something so uncouth and in public no less.

Shocked beyond belief, Mydei settles on what he knows best. He reaches out and yanks Phainon by the collar, pulling him across the table in a clatter of tableware. "Battle me. Now."

Immediately, the bustle of the restaurant quiets down. All watch with bated breath as the two Chrysos Heirs clash.

"Of course. It would be my pleasure," Phainon grins, all white teeth and bright eyes. His citrusy scent intensifies, and Mydei feels like he's about to choke.

The air in the restaurant is stale with little circulation. A cozy establishment with good ambience, but Phainon's scent suffocates him, wraps around his throat and floods his senses, and he can't handle it anymore. Mourning the loss of his delicious honey cakes, he throws money onto the table and storms out of the place with Phainon clamoring after him.

He has no clue where he's going, only a conviction to get as far away as possible as he can from all the nosy onlookers.

“Weapons or no weapons?” Phainon asks as he catches up.

“No weapons.”

Mydei throws the first hit. All the pent up energy and frustration he’s been feeling coalesces into brutal punches and kicks, leaving Phainon on the defensive as he blocks blow after blow.

His control begins to slip and the frustration grows. His attacks, once precise and aimed, become more and more uncoordinated, vicious and almost animalistic in the way he swipes and snarls. Phainon dodges with ease, his eyebrows raising as he watches Mydei slowly lose himself.

“Woah,” Phainon says, dodging a punch that would have landed him straight into Hyacine’s office had he been a millisecond slower. “Pent up, aren’t you?”

“Shut up,” Mydei hisses.

As the fight draws on and more curious cityfolk gather, hiding beneath the shade of the marble pillars, the more his body barely responds to his commands anymore. He swings wildly and without much purpose. The heat brews, and his mind grows hazy.

The battle ends with Mydei pinned flat onto the floor. His vision swims as sweat drips down his temple and stings his eyes.

“I win,” Phainon says, his face a mere centimeter away from Mydei’s. They both breathe heavily, sharing the same air. Each inhale brings a flood of bright citrus and the promise of spring, lush meadows and petals fluttering in the wind.

He’s acutely aware of Phainon on top of him. What is he doing…? Moonlight hair tickles his chin as Phainon presses down and sniffs him.

“All you smell like is her,” Phainon mutters. “Where is your scent?”

I don’t have a scent, Mydei wants to say, but he can’t. His body stays frozen in place, unable to move even as Phainon presses his face into the crook of his neck and *nuzzles* him.

At once, his face flushes hot red and his pupils constrict into pinpricks. Breaking out of his self-induced stupor, Mydei yanks Phainon by his hair and tugs his head up. “What the hell do you think you’re doing?” he hisses, eyes flitting to the onlookers who have begun to whisper and giggle.

“Nothing,” Phainon says, his blue eyes darkening. He pulls himself off and says, “It’s nothing.”

“Deliverer,” Mydei says, getting to his feet. “You won. I’ll treat you to dinner this time.”

Phainon’s back is turned to him. Like a burning meadow, the air grows thick with the smell of ash and burnt flora. He’s upset, that much rings true.

“No need,” Phainon says. He pauses then turns to regard Mydei with pursed lips and drawn eyebrows. “It’s getting late. I’ll be heading back home.”

Maybe he should say something, but the words are stuck in his throat. All he does is watch as Phainon stomps away. The whispering of the crowd only grows louder but he can’t bring himself to care, not when Phainon is upset with him.

When he returns back to his room, Mydei immediately slumps onto his bed. His neck itches where Phainon so inappropriately made contact and his scent sticks onto him like second skin. He quickly sheds his armor, leaving himself bare with only his undergarments on before shucking off his wet boxers and sliding a hand down his legs to the unbearable ache and the slick wetness pooling down *there* . The urge to shove his fingers inside to abate the emptiness grows almost unbearable, but he stops himself and buries his face in his pillows instead.

He has to go see Hyacine. This is getting to be too much. What the hell is going on with his body?

And he knows, dear titans help him, Phainon has something to do with this. As much as he wishes to deny it, he can’t. It’s obvious.

Chapter End Notes

thank you for reading! 💕

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> i want to thank everyone for a great first chapter! 💕 i was a lil nervous abt posting but now i'm super hyped up hehe

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Deep breath in, deep breath out, Phainon tells himself as he adjusts his grip on his box of honeycakes—an offering meant to appease. His palms feel gross, sticky with sweat regardless of how hard he's attempting (and failing) to keep cool.

He stands quietly outside the stairway to Mydei's private residence, a single-story white stone house bordered by a small but quaint courtyard. Embellished with gold trim in customary sharpened Kremnoan style, it gleams in the bright sunlight, and Phainon has to squint his eyes to abate the searing glare. In a neighborhood full of similar style buildings, Mydei's home seems more a normal residence than one housing the renowned crown prince.

He's been here a couple of times but never once alone. Mydei would always be by his side, leading him, striding through the neighborhood as if he owned it. In a way he did, this was his territory after all. As if he had been told a terrible joke, Phainon laughs miserably to himself.

Ripe pomegranate, cloyingly sweet, wafts through the air and sticks in his nose, settles on his skin. It lights a fire in his chest as his heart twists and turns in a blaze of contradiction.

It smells *good* . Amazing even, and oh, how he hates himself. There is *no* reason he should be feeling like this. He doesn't even want to admit it, how alluring the scent of the omega whom Mydei has chosen for himself.

And he shouldn't be here in this neighborhood where everyone stares at him with thinly veiled disdain. He shouldn't be intruding on the Kremnoans who pointedly dislike him, never hiding away their scorn or glares, for taking so much of their crown prince's precious attention.

He starts pacing around, debating whether or not he should give up and leave. It's rather obvious that Mydei is *busy,* but he's at wit's end. He has to do something about the situation or else it's going to continue to haunt him. There's no way he can continue to act naturally with the weight of Mydei's disdain pushing down on him.

Only once has Mydei ever been truly angry at him, back when they first clashed years ago, and he remembers how terrible that week had been. He does not, under any circumstances, want a repeat.

It's been over two days and twelve hours since he's had any sort of communication with the other alpha, not that he's counting or anything. Phainon sighs. There's been many a time where they've been separated for weeks, if not months, but Mydei always answers, even if his responses sometimes amount to nothing more than one or two words.

He hasn't even been left on read this time! That's the worst part! Mydei probably saw his notifs and ignored them. Ugh.

And Phainon knows. By titans, he knows shouldn't have lashed out, crossing the careful boundaries of their relationship without a single care for the ensuing consequences. Scenting another alpha without their consent is an outward act of aggression, and now he has Mydei avoiding him without so much a single response to his calls or even a look at his text messages.

Phainon continues to pace around, kicking around at random stones and pebbles. His fingers tightens on the box of honeycakes, indenting the poor cardboard, as the sweet pomegranate scent weighs him down and envelops him in its sweet, sultry embrace. He feels it bury into his body, lighting his nerves and sending a wave of haze through his mind.

Against his will, his cock stiffens and strains his already tight pants. The longer he stays here the worse it gets, and he rather not walk around nursing a huge boner that won't go down because he's, somehow, attracted to this omega without ever seeing her!

He doesn't even like omegas, finds their scents too cloyingly sweet if he's being honest, so why is he feeling this way?

But he's here. Went through the trouble of sneaking past a bunch of Kremnoans who might otherwise throw rocks at him or try to poke him with their spears. He might as well make the best use of his time and try to confront Mydei instead of moping around.

He thought his acting skills were decent but now he has the other heirs hot on his trail. Tribbie constantly pops in to visit him, concern sparkling in her wide eyes as she asks if he's okay. He tells her he's fine, but is he really? When all his waking thoughts are about Mydei with someone else? His Mydei. With some random omega. An omega with an alluring scent that threatens to suffocate him if he gets too close.

But Mydei isn't his. Never has been. Probably never will be. That's an important distinction that has to be made.

Phainon wants to scream. He yanks those thoughts away and stomps straight to the front door.

He rings the doorbell. Waits for a few moments. Nothing. Rings it again. When that results in no answer, he starts knocking and yelling, "Hey, Mydei! Mydeimos! Mydei!" He continues to yell as his restraint slips away. He even debates kicking the door down. Mydei will probably kill him, but it'll be worth it for the two minutes he has before he gets his face punched in.

Behind him, a gruff voice asks, "What do you think you're doing?"

Damn it.

Phainon turns and grins. “Hey, Krateros! Nice to see you!”

“His highness does not take visitors unannounced,” Krateros says, his dark eyes narrowed. “Leave.”

“I need to speak to him,” Phainon says. “It’ll be quick.”

“He does not have time for you,” Krateros snaps. “You are intruding.”

“I only need a second. There’s been a misunderstanding—”

It seems Krateros is in no mood to humor him. He brandishes his spear and says, “If you do not leave of your own accord right this moment, then I will make you. The crown prince may go easy on you, but I will not.”

Phainon raises his hands in surrender. The urge to release his pheromones beckons him but he resists, knowing it’ll only antagonize Krateros and potentially lure in the rest of the Kremnoan soldiers. Instead, he says, “Okay, okay, I’ll go.”

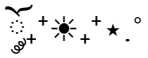
Right about now would be a good time for Mydei to appear and appease his old teacher, but alas, that’s only wishful thinking. The door remains tightly locked, and Krateros only grows more furious by the second.

So, this is confirmation that Mydei doesn’t want to see him. Great. Perfect. Amazing.

It feels as if his life is falling apart. A little dramatic maybe, but his desire to be by Mydei’s side overwhelms all reason.

With his normally jovial voice now uncharacteristically quiet, Phainon pleads, “If you see Mydei, can you tell him I was here? I wish to apologize for my behavior and nothing more.”

The only response he receives is an icy glare.



Phainon sighs into his hands as he leans against the stone railing.

He knows he’s wallowing in his guilt, idling on the roof of someone’s home and staring off into the distance. The dawn shines bright as it always does, endless sunlight streaming down and smacking him right in the face. He can’t help the way his face scrunches up as he gazes down at the passing cityfolk.

A few stare back at him. Some wave enthusiastically, while others give a quizzical expression when they find the lack of brilliant grin on his normally amiable features.

Behind him, a man whispers rather loudly, “We should leave.”

He hears rustling and hurried footsteps clacking down the stone stairs. With the couple gone, the last of the premises are vacated. It’s only him and the running prayer fountain now.

Phainon mutters, “Great…”

He’s going to get an earful from Aglaea about terrorizing the public with his pheromones, but that’s an issue to deal with later. It’s fine. Everything is fine.

Phainon sits on the edge of a nearby *kline* and opens his rather squashed box of honeycakes. He huffs to himself. If Mydei doesn’t want them, then he’ll eat them. They taste better fresh, and he rather not waste a perfectly good box.

The cakes are delightful, light and airy, with a mild syrupy sweetness that coats his tongue. It’s balanced with the crisp, fragrant tartness of the pomegranate arils sprinkled throughout. Pomegranate… Phainon buries his head in his hands.

He shouldn’t be feeling this way, but the tightness in his chest makes it difficult to breathe. Sometimes he feels adrift like he’s stranded in the middle of the sea, alone with only his rolling thoughts that threaten to submerge him if he stalls for too long. Even antique appraisal hasn’t brought the same joy it normally does. He has an aversion to *amphora* now, given he dropped one and had to pay for the damages after seeing the image of a man and woman intertwined in a lustful, primal endeavor.

Maybe he should go ask Aglaea for a mission. Preferably somewhere far away from Okhema so he can clear his mind. He’s in the mood to destroy a bunch of titankin right now, rip them into shreds and scatter their remains to abate the frustrations in his mind.

Phainon huffs. It’s really no wonder Mydei fell for her when she smells like *that* .

Mydei likes pomegranates, and Phainon likes pomegranates because he likes Mydei. It’s simple.

But never in a thousand years would he find himself at such odds, reacting to her scent in ways he never thought he ever would. Even the simple thought of the red fruit has his fangs elongating. He doesn’t even like omegas! What’s going on?!

Now, Phainon is no expert in Kremnoan customs, but he’s dallied a bit out of curiosity. At first he couldn’t bring himself to believe the rumors because they seemed rather outlandish until he saw Mydei for himself.

Kremnoan tradition dictates newly mated omegas be kept indoors and unseen by all until successful pregnancy or even thereafter as they are believed to be a distraction to the soldiers. Though Phainon doesn’t particularly agree with the custom, it makes sense given Mydei’s

circumstances. As the crown prince and general of the army, Mydei cannot afford to have his attention divided, not even by his mate.

But really, it's absurd. Is he spending that much time with her? Mydei returned from his mission only to stay out of sight for five whole days. When Phainon found him at the restaurant, he was doused from head to toe in her saccharine scent. How much sex are they even having for him to smell so strongly of omega in heat?

He doesn't want to think about it but his accursed mind supplies him with *images* . He sees Mydei in the throes of pleasure, his chiseled, sculpted body shining with a thin sheen of sweat and his jagged red markings glowing as he fucks into her.

The voice in the back of his head whispers, what kind of lover would Mydei be? Would he grind her into the bed while speaking filth into her ear or would he worship her and take his sweet time taking her apart piece by piece? Would his mind grow more and more primal, his fangs elongating as he drinks in her unrestrained moans?

No. Stop. *Stop.*

He's tempted to dunk his head into the nearby prayer fountain to stop the images ravaging his already disturbed mind. Blasphemous of him to even entertain the thought, but he rather face the wrath of Phagousa than see Mydei fucking some nameless omega.

Jealousy curls inside him, a bitter and astringent feeling that seeps out of his pores. He can hardly control his own pheromones, his hurt leaking through whenever he thinks about Mydei a little too long. Maybe he should visit Hyacine and ask her to prepare some suppressants for him if he can't get it under control. He laughs. As if they'd work.

Who even is the omega? And how did she manage to seduce Mydei of all people? Unfortunately, he won't have a clue until she's pregnant or even after. It seems Mydei takes the tradition seriously. Funny when Phainon believed him to be the type to forgo old custom.

Footsteps clatter from behind him and the familiar scent of fragrant lilies and poppy flowers drizzles through the afternoon air. Without turning, Phainon says, "Hey, Castorice."

"Lord Phainon," Castorice replies with a small bow. "How have you been?"

For her sake, he tries to reel in his scent. Deep breaths, in and out, in and out. He turns and smiles widely, "Great! Just enjoying some fresh, delicious honeycakes that I totally bought for myself. Do you want some? There's an extra fork in the bag." He pulls it out and hands it to her only to place it down on the *kline* across from him when she gestures that way.

Castorice seems a little taken aback but she joins him with a small nod. In her arms is a purple notebook, and she gently places it down beside her. She grabs a small portion of honeycake and pops it into her mouth. Her purple eyes glow a little brighter, a soft smile curving at the corner of her delicate lips. "Thank you," she says. "Delicious as always."

Phainon tilts his head, his eyes trained on her notebook. Unable to help himself, he asks, "What's that?"

“Ah, some s-stories I’ve been working on,” Castorice says as she lays a hand over as if protecting it from prying eyes.

“I didn’t know you wrote,” Phainon says. “May I see?”

She hesitates, a flush creeping on her pale features. Her grip tightens on her fork. It seems for a moment she’s about to say no, but she nods and places the notebook on the table between them.

Maybe he feels a little bad for cornering her, but the fleeting thought dissipates once he grabs the book and starts flipping through the pages. His blue eyes glow as he reads over her words. “Wow, Castorice…” he says. “This is amazing!”

Castorice smiles sweetly, only for her expression to fall when Phainon continues to flip, his eyes roaming the pages like a hungry man given an unlimited feast.

“Uh, may I have my notebook back?” she says, a hint of nervousness in her voice. Her scent spikes, a tinge of decay marring otherwise sweet wildflower nectar.

“Hm?” Phainon says as he turns yet another page. His eyes land on…

Oh. *Oh, no.*

A laugh bubbles in his throat. He tries to hold it in but it spills over unrestrained, sounding almost hysterical as he starts to cough wildly. He covers his mouth and holds it there until he’s sure he’ll no longer make a fool of himself.

Tears form in the corners of his eyes as he continues to hack, feeling as if he’s coughing out his lungs. His ears burn hot red, contrasting with the moonlight of his unruly locks.

Castorice stares horrified, and she starts to stammer, “Uh—well… Lord Phainon, I can explain—”

“We’re not…” Phainon manages to croak out. “We’re not like that at all…”

His chest strains. Oh, how badly he wants to say, *I wish we were the way you wrote. I wish Mydei liked me the way I like him. I wish I could freely show my affections without scorn or fear of destroying our relationship beyond repair. I wish I could be content with having him as my rival, fellow equal, and friend, but I want more than that and I don’t know how to stop these accursed feelings from taking root.*

Alpha alpha relationships are by no means uncommon in Amphoreus, but most alphas prefer the saccharine sweetness of omegas or even the calm neutrality of betas over the territorial aggression of other alphas. Before he had an inkling of hope that maybe their relationship could turn into something a little less friendly, if it could even be called that, and a little more romantic, but that’s only wishful, one-sided thinking on his end.

If only… If only he—

“Notebook, please,” Castorice says, yanking Phainon out of his ever spiralling thoughts.

Acting as nonchalant as possible, Phainon grins and says, “Yes, here you go.” He nearly drops the book as he fumbles to place it back on the table, but Castorice doesn’t seem to notice, too flustered herself to really pay attention to his suspicious lack of grace.

She tucks a straw strand behind her ear and looks at him through long dark lashes, her purple eyes shining with guilt. “My apologies for making you uncomfortable.”

Phainon shakes his head and laughs, “No, no! I’m not uncomfortable at all. I was only caught off guard. I really like your work and how lyrical your prose is, flowery but flows well and blends with the emotions on the page. You have a lot of talent, Castorice. Don’t let anyone tell you otherwise.”

If anything, his praise seems to make her more uncomfortable. She fidgets a little, plays with the butterfly on her sleeve and nearly crushes its delicate wings.

“Ahem, so what made you write such stories about Mydei and I? We’re enemies who wish to tear each other apart,” Phainon says as he takes another bite of honeycake. “What makes you think we’re… close like that?”

“Are you not?” Castorice asks. “You two spend so much time together, and I see how you look at him when you think he’s not looking.”

Phainon chokes on a pomegranate aril. It goes down the wrong pipe and lodges itself in his windpipe. Oh titans, this day only gets worse and worse.

“Lord Phainon!” Castorice calls out as she panics. She searches around for water or anything that could help but there’s nothing to drink unless the prayer fountain counts.

“I’m okay!” Phainon coughs. “Accident. Wrong tube. I’m fine.” He wipes at his lip and says shakily, “It doesn’t matter what I feel for him when he does not reciprocate in any manner.”

“How are you so sure?”

Phainon laughs. He intends it to be lighthearted, but it comes out rather wretched like a cry for help. “Have you heard the rumors lately?”

“I have,” Castorice slowly says before adding, “They seem rather improbable.”

“How so?” He coughs once more, tasting acid on his tongue. Damn that pomegranate. Seems like the fruit is the center of all his problems lately. Maybe he’ll go kick a pomegranate tree as revenge. Respectfully, of course.

Castorice hovers over him, but he waves her off with a pained smile. She settles back down and says, “Lord Mydei does not seem the type.”

“He didn’t deny it when I asked him. And you should have smelled her scent on him. It stuck onto him, almost like he owned it.”

Her scent was overwhelming, a given since Mydei himself has no visible scent. There are a bunch of floating theories as to why, but the alpha has never come out to deny or confirm

any.

Sometimes he wonders what Mydei's true scent is. He can guess, something smoky and musky, masculine and strong. Petrichor and cedarwood tinged with ash and spice. And Mydei, behind his outward demeanor, is kind and caring, almost to a fault, so Phainon can imagine a slight softness to his scent, maybe honey or molasses.

"I see… I have yet to see him. Perhaps I will ask myself." Her gaze flits from him to the cakes on the table, yet she doesn't make any move to take more.

"Do you want the rest?" Phainon asks for her. "I already ate lunch so I don't have much of an appetite. They taste better fresh so eat them while you can."

"But you purchased it…"

"Take it. It's all yours."

Castorice's scent sweetens, and she nods enthusiastically. She happily digs in while Phainon leans back on the *kline* with his hands behind his head. He closes his eyes and tries to relax. Keyword tries. His throat burns, and unfortunately, all he thinks about is Castorice's words on the page, flowery and lyrical yet rather inappropriate.

He can't help but ask, "Between Mydei and I, you think I top?"

Castorice chokes and slams her fork down on the table. She scrambles to her feet and exclaims, "Ah, it seems I have forgotten a very important meeting with Lady Aglaea—"

"Wait—"

"It's urgent, yes, I must go right away! See you later, Lord Phainon!" She takes off in a run, purple hair flowing behind her as her heels clack against the stone.

"At least take the honeycakes with you!" he yells.

The first thing Mydei does when he wakes up is seek out Hyacine. The wetness between his thighs is beyond abhorrent, and the buzzing in his head has grown to a constant onslaught with no signs of reprieve.

He waits some time after curtain-fall hour to sneak out of his private residence. Unfortunately, since he lives near the edge of the city, her office is a decent trek away. Thankfully, he's yet to see anyone outside. By now, most, if not all of Okhema should be asleep, though he knows Hyacine is still on duty, working tirelessly day in and out.

Dawn blares as it always does. When cloaked in such warm light, there's nowhere to hide. He scurries along the alleyways and avoids any large open areas. Hiding is not his strong suit, he realizes, not with how built his body is and the deep reds and blacks of his nighttime chiton.

He couldn't go through with putting on his armor. With how hot his body feels, he would probably suffocate under the weight of the metal.

Even without the extra ornaments, he loses balance a few times and nearly crashes onto the floor. The sunlight overwhelms as his head spins. He must look like a drunk with the way he can barely keep himself upright.

When he finally makes it to Hyacine's office, he finds her dozing off at her desk, pen in hand in the middle of writing yet another prescription. She's always working overtime. It's a difficult job, acting as the lead physician for the entirety of Okhema, he knows it to be.

Mydei reminds himself to bake something sweet for her when he has the time. Maybe a batch of rainbow cupcakes or a chocolate cream pie with lots of sprinkles. He has to remind her to not feed them to little Ica though, so maybe he'll make something for that plump unicorn too.

Hyacine jolts awake at the sound of him closing the door, his attempts to be silent foiled by the creaky hinges and his alarming lack of hand-eye coordination. Wiping away the sleep from her eyes, she yawns and congratulates him, her tone of voice light as she wrestles with her grogginess.

He's left even more confused, and it must show on his face because she pauses and says, "You have no clue what I'm talking about."

Out of reflex, he crosses his arms against his chest and nods.

"There's a sweet scent that sticks to your body. Do you have any clue about that? There's no shame in admitting you've taken a lover. It's the talk of the city! How exciting!"

Scent…? Phainon said that too, but he doesn't smell anything. Nothing out of the usual.

Hyacine pops in closer and takes a big whiff. She nods, "Yup, it's really strong and sweet. Smells like an omega in pre-heat, nearing heat."

This is absurd. His sense of smell has heightened recently, so he's sure he would know if there's a foreign scent clinging onto him, especially if it's as strong as everyone claims it is.

Is this some kind of a city-wide joke? Has Zagreus inflicted one of his tricks again?

"When did the rumors begin?" Mydei asks.

"Mmm, I would say the day you returned from your mission," Hyacine says. "Like nine or so days ago?"

Confused, Mydei responds, "I returned five days ago."

Hyacine shakes her head. “You returned nine days ago with the villagers in tow. I remember because I treated some for injuries.” She pulls out her teleslate and shows him the date clearly marked.

Oh titans. Unbelievable.

Somehow, he’s not even shocked that he’s been unconscious for four whole days. There’s definitely something wrong with him, far worse than only a simple sickness. He’s even forgotten his teleslate. Again. It’s probably dead from lack of charge.

Even now, he’s tired. Everything aches, he can feel it in his bones, and his mind is foggy. The room spins with every slight movement so he stands firmly planted in place.

“Is everything alright?” she asks, concern tinged in her sweet voice.

“My apologies. I must have gotten time mixed up.”

Hyacine doesn’t look like she believes him, but she doesn’t prod any further. Instead, she presses a finger to her lip and says, “I’ve heard it’s Kremnoan tradition for newly mated alphas to keep their omega mates hidden whilst parading their scent around… almost like a trophy? Excuse me if I’m being too frank, but is that correct?”

Mydei blinks.

Oh . Somehow that completely slipped his mind. That would, in some part, explain the rumors.

“Yes,” he says with a slight frown. “Though I don’t believe it’s commonplace anymore.”

Her next words come out careful and slow as her wide turquoise eyes scan over him, “Is your mate okay? Her pheromones are super strong and quite unstable. I understand if you don’t wish to bring her over, but I can always visit. I won’t tell anyone.”

Mydei uncrosses his arms and says, “The rumors are unfound. I don’t have a mate nor have I tussled with any omega recently.” *Or ever*, he should say.

Hyacine clicks her pen. She’s looking through him instead of at him, similar to how Aglaea did… Nothing good can come from this, he knows.

“Will you allow me to check your nape?” she asks.

Mydei nods. She inches closer and when her fingers make contact, the strange prickling sensation returns full force. He nearly jumps. If it weren’t for his years of self-restraint, he would have.

“I knew it,” she mutters, nodding to herself as she rubs her fingers together. “This makes far more sense.”

“What is it?” With the way she’s looking at him, he knows it’s not good news, but never, not in a thousand years, would he have expected her next words.

“You’re an omega, and you’re in pre-heat.”

His stomach twists, and his response is immediate, “I’m not an omega.”

“The scent is coming from you. Unless you’re dousing yourself in omega slick—I assume you’re not based on the look on your face—the only alternative is you’re an omega.”

He’s not dousing himself if it’s coming from himself. Wait—

Mydei coughs. “I shouldn’t be. If I was, I would have known years ago. It’s far too late to present.”

“But you’re not an alpha nor are you a beta,” she says, matter of fact.

For a moment, he’s taken aback. Though he has no visible scent and never needs time off to deal with ruts and the like, everyone in the city, save for Aglaea, believes him to be an alpha. Years of stagnancy have made secondary gender little more than a passing thought, a wisp in the wind. If everyone believes him an alpha, then so be it. He has no real reason to correct them.

He’s even heard whisperings about how he must be taking suppressants or scent blockers because it’s impossible for an alpha to have no scent. Some posit he’s similar to Aglaea with razor control over her pheromones, but no. Neither are correct. He simply never presented.

“I don’t know what I am,” he admits. “For the longest time, I believed myself a beta, but I don’t quite fit that category.”

Hyacine nods, her turquoise-dipped pink pigtails bouncing. “You are immortal, so I suppose there could be changes to your biology. Have you been feeling different as of late? You smell like you’re in pre-heat, so I’m assuming all of the normal pre-heat symptoms? You look flushed too.”

His symptoms mirror sickness, a fever or a particularly bad case of the flu. That’s what he believed it to be initially. “I do feel different… more dizzy, nauseous. Being near other people makes me feel worse and there’s…” He pauses, feeling a little self-conscious. The words stay lodged in his throat. Admitting that he gets wet from Phainon’s presence in the room is the worst thing he could possibly say out loud.

Thankfully, Hyacine seems to understand. “Do you want to go through with your heat?” she asks carefully as she files through her cabinets.

If this entire debacle is only pre-heat, he fears what an actual heat would do to him. He doesn’t know the exact mechanics, but he understands the general idea—an overwhelming desire to mate and a near total loss of inhibitions.

The idea of going into heat… it terrifies him. There’s little on this planet that can make him feel this way, there’s no word for “fear” in the Kremnoan language but the panic that seizes his breathing and empties his head is tangible. He’s never felt this strongly, and he knows,

there is no way he will go through with this heat. No matter what, he will resist. Even if the medications don't work, he will fight with all he has.

Still, he finds himself at a loss. It's almost funny in a terrible, ironic way. He's… actually an omega? He can hardly believe it. It almost seems like a joke, but Hyacine is not one to lie, and he trusts her judgement.

His parents were both alphas. How is he an omega?

"What exactly would that entail?" Mydei asks, ignoring the dread settling in his chest. It digs a little hole and makes its home.

"Hmm, well, you'll need at minimum a week off, and depending on the omega, heats can range from mild to almost debilitating. I cannot say for certain how your body will react, but it will not be a comfortable experience, especially if you decide to spend it alone."

"And if I continue to suppress it with the help of pills?" Mydei asks.

"I can't say for sure if the medications will work…" She frowns. "If they do, then you can take them, but eventually, you will need to have a heat. One every half a year secures the longevity of the medications."

Of course it wouldn't be that easy. He'd be a fool to believe he could hide forever.

Hyacine continues, "For the most part, it's better to allow your body a heat as a way to self-regulate, especially since you presented recently."

"I'll take my chances with the medication. If I start now, then I have half a year to prepare," Mydei says. "Is that correct?"

"Assuming they work, then yes." She continues to rummage through her cabinets until she produces two small bottles, one light blue and the other white. "Are you sure? I can prepare a room for you and ensure no one will know if you wish to go through with your heat."

"I prefer to take the pills," Mydei says, resolute. He does *not* want to go through with his heat. All he wants is to feel back to normal so he can get on with his life and duties instead of hiding himself in the cold of his bedroom. He's surprised no one has tried to break in while he was unconscious.

Hyacine nods, though she seems less enthusiastic. "Okay, got it. These are the best brands I have and the trial bottles will last enough for a week. Blue for scent blockers and white for suppressants. One of each pill daily after a meal." She hands them over and says, "Return in a day so I can check if they worked."

"Thank you."

"Of course! Best of luck!" Hyacine smiles. "By the way, I never had the chance to thank you for the sweets from last time."

“You’re welcome,” Mydei says as he pockets the bottles and turns to leave. Another forty minute trek back home assuming he doesn’t faint along the way. Great. Entry hour looms, and he knows if he stays any longer, he’ll definitely be caught by some random early riser. He knows quite a few people who like to start their day before entry hour even begins.

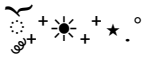
“Do you need me to walk you back?” Hyacine asks when she notices him swaying.

Mydei shakes his head. “I appreciate the offer, but I’ll be okay.”

She seems to deflate a little. Lips pursed, she says, “Okay. Take care, and let me know immediately if anything happens.” Right as he’s about to step out the door, she says, “One last thing… This might not be my place, but what will you do about the rumors?”

“I plan on leaving it be. It’ll die down soon as long as I don’t feed into it,” Mydei easily responds.

There’s nothing else he can plausibly do without accidentally causing an avalanche of whisperings and speculation. The best choice is to leave it be and let it slowly fizzle out as the cityfolk turn their attention to newer gossip. Though, he wonders, who started the rumors to begin with and why?



When his teleslate finally charges enough to turn back on, he sees a whole block of texts from Phainon. A bunch of apologies, ramblings about how he’s sorry and wants to talk complete with a plethora of crying chimera emojis and sad faces.

Mydei sighs, and types up a quick response asking to meet up for dinner, but his finger hesitates as he hovers over the send button.

No, not yet. He hasn’t even taken the medications yet, and there’s no telling if they’ll even work considering his altered biology. He deletes the original message and instead replies with a simple, “Busy. Will explain later when I’m free. Stay out of trouble.”

Hyacine texted him alerting that she spoke with Aglaea about his need for rest, promising she didn’t spill a single detail about his omega presentation. He’s almost certain the goldweaver already knows, but it’s still a nice gesture nonetheless.

He holds the two bottles in his hand, unassuming in appearance yet housing the very medications that dictate his future. He downs one of each pill with a glass of water then sits at the edge of his bed.

His windows are strewn shut and the lamps are turned off as he throws the covers over himself. He’s tired yet he can’t sleep, his mind a blur of images that coalesce into everything

yet nothing simultaneously. He feels like he's drowning, pulled under by monsters ten times his size. They grab him and submerge him over and over as he struggles and screams.

When he wakes up from the fitful sleep, he's groggy, but he feels much better. No longer does his skin prickle incessantly. He feels at peace without any annoying buzzing in his head or fogginess in his mind.

The pills seem to work. His symptoms have abated until almost nothing, and it's no longer overwhelming to step outside. He's no longer inundated with dizziness and his body feels looser than before, his muscles relaxed instead of tensed.

And thank the titans. Oh, how he could weep. The sticky wetness between his thighs is gone and so is the overwhelming desire to plug his fingers inside to abate the empty ache.

He visits Hyacine again, once more sneaking out during the middle of curtain-fall hour and spending about half an hour navigating through alleyways to avoid even the chance of being seen. He thinks he might go mad if he has to continue such a route and even debates moving closer.

The Chrysos Heir villa is right beside her office, and as far as Mydei knows, only Castorice resides there as a semi-permanent tenant. Maybe he'll move there, if only temporarily, and find himself a room at the very back of the villa.

With a thumbs up, Hyacine confirms he's in the clear, a bounce in her step as she regards him with a bright smile. His scent signature is gone, and he's back to how he was before.

In the calm of his kitchen, he sits at the dining table and stares out the window at the chirping birds and fluttering branches. The sweet tang of pomegranate juice coats his tongue as he takes slow sips. His appetite hasn't fully recovered, but he feels hungrier than he has in ages.

Everything is fine now. Issue solved. He can pretend to be how he was before.

His gauntleted hand tightens on his chalice. He never envisioned being an omega. Even now, a part of him still denies it. Him? An omega? It's preposterous.

But how else could he plausibly explain the scent, the wetness, the dizziness, the tingling in his neck? And most regrettably, the overwhelming desire to be plugged up and filled?

Not even for a moment can he allow himself to slip. He has his duty. The flame-chase journey comes first. Amphoreus comes first. His people come first.

Even if he has to hide his true self from view, he will gladly do it. There's no reason to reveal the truth, not when it'll complicate the already precarious circumstances. Besides, he's lived his entire life this way in this strange state of limbo. It'll be like nothing has changed.

It's for the best. No one will know. *Especially not Phainon.*

Chapter End Notes

the kremnoan marriage custom is very much referenced from ancient spartan marriage rituals.

thank you for reading! 💕

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The scents catch in his lungs, thick and overwhelming, a heavy, oppressive aura that weighs down the surroundings. Pheromones permeate the trapped air, blending with the sharp tang of sweat and the flame of heightened emotion. He can practically taste the aggression, the loud shouts and clashing of fists.

He almost wants to leave. Backtrack and never come back. The medications have dulled his sense of smell, but it's still leagues more sensitive than what it was before. His nose burns.

"Your highness," a soldier greets and the others follow. In an instant, all combat ceases and all eyes are on him. His countrymen straighten, standing at attention, waiting for his call. A customary sign of respect for the general and prince, he should be used to it, but instead, he's unsettled under such high focus.

It's risky to be here, he knows, surrounded, caged in by a legion of alphas who are all staring at him with intent. Though it's not predatory in nature, even if it feels like so, he can't help the chills that crawl down his spine. If Hyacine were beside him, she would no doubt admonish him for his impulsiveness and try her best to drag him away from here. He silently apologizes to her.

Unfortunately, there's no better place to test his theories than at the Kremnoan training hall.

Mydei clears his throat and announces, "You may proceed." Immediately, the soldiers relax and resume their activities.

Even if the medications hide the outward features, he's still an omega. Being near large groups of alphas, especially those entrenched in a frenzy of combat, is far from the brightest idea, but he rather rip off the bandages than let the wound fester beneath. Whether he wants the title of crown prince or not, he's the de facto leader of the Kremnoans. If he can't stand to be near his men, then how could he hope to lead his people?

If the medications pull their weight, then he should have no issues. Hyacine had told him that he could resume as he normally did but to keep an eye out for anything abnormal. Though the flood of scents in the air isn't pleasant, he'll get used to it. Probably.

Most embarrassingly, he has to see if he reacts to another alpha. It pains him to admit, but Phainon's pheromones caused this entire mess. If another alpha could somehow breach his defenses, break through the carefully constructed barrier of the medications, and cause a similar reaction, then Mydei thinks he might be screwed. He should find out now before later.

Krateros steadily roams the premises, arms behind his back as he surveys the trainees. He makes his way towards Mydei with forceful, yet calculated steps, customary of the

Kremnoan elite. With a stern nod of acknowledgement, he says, “Welcome back.”

Mydei returns the nod and responds, “Apologies for my absence, Krateros. How has training been?”

His old mentor looks him over, head to toe. “Well. They’ve been asking for you.”

Mydei’s gaze trails the expanse of the hall, the familiar metal domed structure housing hundreds of soldiers at once. New recruits, many of whom he’s never met before, work through structured training drills whilst veterans take training into their own hands either through sparring with one another or fighting enchanted training dummies and simulations of titankin.

Majority of the men here are alphas with only a sliver of beta. Krateros, firmly rooted in traditional values, only recruits those that fit within the narrow range. Female alphas are welcome to join as well, but there are few that go through the doors and stay. He’s tried to argue for the inclusion of all others, even those not Kremnoan, but Krateros holds his ideals steady. Absolutely no omegas and no outsiders.

It’s a danger, he’s been told repeatedly, to house omegas who may go into heat at any time, surrounded by so many hormonal alphas. How ironic.

As they stroll around the periphery, he’s brought back to memories of the time he’s spent here. He had overseen the building of this hall and practically used to live here and the surrounding courtyard. This was the space where he could let loose and fall into the familiar drum of combat without the need to think about the other issues plaguing him. Training consumed half of his life, the other battle. He would spar with his fellow soldiers, any of those who had the confidence to face the undefeated crown prince, though none could even hope to match his tenacity. Not even Krateros himself could land a singular blow.

Kremnoan men were born to be soldiers. Castrum Kremnos thrived off strife—a military city-state that stood only to conquer and expand. Glory in blood, to die in combat was the greatest honor. Thus, male omegas were the antithesis of everything Castrum Kremnos stood for. Men were soldiers, living and breathing the battlefield. Omegas were the homemakers, child bearers meant to create the new generation of fighters.

Incompatible, the idea of being a soldier and a child bearer. Secondary gender manifests late, and there’s little telling what a boy would become, but if the signs were there, then he would be seen as a disgrace. Many male omegas end up in brothels, living in servitude, used as playthings or stress relief by cruel patrons, other soldiers. Male omegas are far less desired, far less fertile than their female counterparts and have difficulty giving birth due to narrower hips and unpredictable heats.

Mydei is well aware of his rapidly declining reputation. If the truth were to come out about his omegan nature, it would only exacerbate tensions and slice through the already precarious peace until near unsalvageable. Half of his countrymen already find him a disgrace to traditional Kremnoan ideals. Even if they would never dare say it to his face, though many have come close, he’s heard the whisperings. He’s been called a slacker, living as a “dishonorable” Okheman, a prince that has betrayed his home.

They pass by a few veteran soldiers, men that he's fought with, bled with. The very same ones that followed him from Castrum Kremnos to Okhema. These alphas have families and are fathers to the first generation of Okheman-born Kremnoans. He's greeted with a few nods of acknowledgement, while others regard him with narrowed eyes.

"Your highness, welcome back. It's been awhile," one man says. Mydei recalls he married an Okheman, much to the dismay of his comrades, and has a daughter, a young female omega with bright eyes and a passion for the arts. The man's prowess on the battlefield is second to none, thus his reputation has taken far less of a hit than if he were a lesser warrior.

His words have Mydei pausing in his step. He hasn't been around, that much is true.

Most of his time is spent either lounging around or with Phainon. Or both. Lounging around with Phainon, enjoying each other's company. He has his fair share of missions, and he does train everyday in some form or another, mostly by attempting to punch the Deliverer's face in, but his life is far more peaceful. It's a good change.

"We have a group of new recruits over there," Krateros says, pointing to the group in the back corner of the hall. "There's one that insists on joining our ranks. He spent days begging outside even after being repeatedly turned away. I need you to decide whether or not we allow him to stay."

There's a teenage boy crumpled in the corner. The rest of his group have moved on without him, working on coordinating spear strikes while he trembles and attempts to catch his breath.

A softer, sweeter scent cuts through the dense fog. For a moment, Mydei thinks he's hallucinating. He turns to Krateros and finds the man watching him, his gaze steady. There's no betrayal of emotion in those eyes.

Is this a test?

"Your highness!" The boy looks up, his eyes wide as he tries to compose himself in front of the approaching prince. He's scrawny, soaked in sweat, and struggling to even keep himself upright.

"I apologize for my unruly appearance. Please forgive this lowly one," the boy scrambles to save. His cheeks burn red as he scrambles to get off the floor.

Mydei stops him and leans down. The boy trembles, but the fire in his eyes burns bright.

"You are new, yes?" Mydei asks. "What is your name?"

"T-This one is named Iavokos."

A young male omega. The only one amidst a group of alphas and betas. It's dangerous, yet…

"I ask of you, Iavokos, why are you here? Be warned, there is no glory in battle. Do not mistake violence for honor. If that is why you are here, then you best leave," Mydei says,

causing the boy to stare up at him with wide eyes and a complicated expression. He pushes down the urge to reach out and pat the boy on the head. This isn't the right place or time.

"I'm not here for glory," the boy says. He grapples with himself, pheromones waving wildly until it steadies. "I wish to grow stronger to provide for my little sister. It's not battle I yearn for, only a desire to make sure she is safe and happy."

Selfless. Children like him will get eaten alive in this type of cutthroat environment, but the stubbornness in the boy's gaze tells him there's not much he can do other than warn. He wants to support the boy, but the road ahead is treacherous.

"I cannot stop you from pursuing this if you so wish, but I want you to understand what dangers lie ahead. It is not an easy path to take."

The boy nods. "I understand, your highness. It won't be easy, but I will not give up."

"You are brave," Mydei murmurs. His golden eyes soften as he says, "Keep your chin up, child. Do not allow anyone to talk down on you."

Iavokos forces himself upright. There's a obvious stumble in his step, but this time, he manages to get to his feet and stay with little to no issue. With a deep bow, he exclaims, "Yes, of course, your highness! Thank you for your support!"

Krateros looms over, his arms crossed tight against his chest. "Very well. I will pay extra attention to this trainee." He turns to the boy and says, "The crown prince has given you his blessings. Do not disappoint."

As they walk a good distance away, Mydei narrows his eyes and says, "You accepted a male omega into the ranks. Why?"

"So I did," Krateros responds, his gravelly timbre taking a tone of deep contemplation as he strokes his beard. "The boy was relentless. I saw a spark in him I have not seen in years. Maybe it's time for a little change."

Mydei almost wants to argue. It sounds preposterous. For a man as steadfast as Krateros to change his mind, there must be a deeper reason, and with the manner Krateros stares at him, it almost feels like he's being pushed towards a certain response. The crawl of unease nestles itself in his chest.



Now that the sweet scent that covered his skin has dissipated, the rumors have shifted from the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos finding his mate and spending all his waking hours with her to abandoning her because she wasn't to his standards.

“Poor omega she must be! The prince is no longer enamored with her!”

“How unfortunate… She smelled so sweet. Surely, she’s a prize and will bear strong pups. If he doesn’t want her, I’ll take a gander and say she’s not lacking other choices.”

“Do you reckon he’s found another?”

His eye twitches. When surrounded by these loud and tactless gossipers, he knows he has another headache incoming. He’s to meet with Aglaea soon and yet, he has to deal with this. Stepping outside the confines of the Kremnoan neighborhood would inevitably subject him to this nonsense but he didn’t expect to have to hear it until he reached areas of high traffic like Kephale plaza. No, it's everywhere. He almost wishes he had asked to meet via online instead of in person.

Are they not bored? Do they not have other gossip? Can they talk about something else?

Calm down, he tells himself. There’s no use in lashing out. The omega scent that once permeated his body is gone and will not return for as long as he takes his suppressants and scent blockers. Now, all he has to do is weather the storm. They’ll grow bored eventually.

For all the cityfolk wish, they can believe him promiscuous alpha scum for breaking a young maiden’s fragile heart after using her body for days on end. He’s dealt with similar yet outlandish rumors in the past. As the crown prince of the city-state that many call “brutish”, he’s had his fair share of strange allegations. This is no real issue. He rather they believe in that story than find out the truth.

There are consequences to the truth.

And he knows it’s very much irrational. Castorice holds herself in such grace and has no care of her omegan nature whilst he’s hiding from it, attempting to act as if it doesn’t exist. But he’s also very much aware that her curse of death stops many from attempting to harm her. He’s heard passing alphas whispering about her, speaking of the things they would do to her if given the chance. On more than one occasion, he had been tempted to crack their heads against the sidewalk, but Aglaea would never approve.

Keep the peace, she would say. Okhema does not need more internal turmoil. The Council of Elders is watching, waiting for a chance to strike. He knows they are, even if they posture otherwise.

The whisperings only grow louder when he steps foot in the baths to the immediate attention of a large crowd of chattering Okhemans. The bulk of pheromones is muted by the medications, thankfully, but it exists, stronger here than in the rest of the city due to the greater exposure of skin, the lack of fresh air, and the lax mannerisms of the bathgoers. It vaguely registers that this is the first time he's set foot in the public baths since the end of his mission.

A group of omegas giggle at him as their gazes roam up and down. He ignores them and continues on, his boots clanging against the marble flooring with a little too much force in his step. Aglaea is awaiting his arrival. There's no time for *this.* Strolling through the long

hallways, he keeps his gaze trained steadily forward, each stride confident with no wavering to be had.

The curse of death protects Castorice from the touch of scummy alphas, but he doesn't have the same luxury. He can easily dominate in a fight so long as he's not bogged down by the fog of heat, but therein lies the issue. He can't predict his body.

Running from a battle is a coward's game, but this time, he's given up before it's even begun. It's for the best. An unmated omega, especially one of his age, is a prime target. Under no circumstances does he want to deal with an alpha getting close enough to bite him. He knows what mating bonds are and how difficult it is for a mated omega—whether willing or not—to fight against what's essentially a permanent brand of ownership.

A bite mark on his neck. He absentmindedly rubs at his nape. The skin there is smooth, untainted. It will stay that way.

When he finally arrives at the Hero's Bath, he finds Aglaea standing in front of the golden fountain, a deep look of contemplation paints her lovely features as she gazes calmly at the glimmering water.

"Mydei," Aglaea greets. "How have you been? You seem well."

He lands beside her and says, "Good. Feeling much better. My apologies if I've missed anything important these past few days."

"I trust you have the situation under control." She pauses for a few moments, her crystalline eyes looking into him instead of at him. She's picking him apart, wordlessly, in that serene manner she always does.

"I do indeed have some news to share," Aglaea continues. The gold laurel in her hair shines with each graceful, practiced movement. "The villagers you rescued have settled in quite nicely to their new lodgings, and as per your instruction, I have made the arrangements for the chief's daughter. She has since met with me to privately say her thanks and wishes to extend them to you as well."

"I hope she has found herself happy and free of obligation."

"Indeed, she has," Aglaea says, her eyes softening. "It is rather unfortunate for ones born in such circumstances to be held back from their potential. Secondary gender should not matter in assessing the worth of an individual."

Mydei wants to agree, but the words catch in his throat. If only it were that easy.

Aglaea stares at him with a knowing expression, patiently awaiting response. When she gets none, she turns back towards the streaming fountain and places her hand into the water, allowing the gold to fall between her fingers.

"I'm planning a get together, a reunion of the heirs," Aglaea says lightly. Her crystalline gold eyes seem to glow brighter and her expression takes a wistful note. Her voice sounds almost

reminiscent as she says, “Cifera will be visiting Okhema and has agreed to join.”

Cifera? He’s heard of her, her trickery and her stealth. And he knows she avoids Okhema for reasons unknown to him and most of the other heirs.

“The demigod of trickery,” Mydei replies.

Aglaea nods. “You two have not yet met. It will be a great time to introduce yourself.”

“Very well." The prospect of meeting the legendary cat thief does spark his attention. "Let me know of the plans when they’re finalized, and I’ll make sure to clear my schedule.”

“I will alert you therein.”

The rest of the conversation is lax, falling to recent developments in recovering the missing coreflames. Aglaea even asks about how his people are doing and if there's anything she can do for him. She's a born leader, and he appreciates her support. Had it not been for her, his people would have never thrived within these walls.

“Do take care,” Aglaea says as she slowly walks him down the steps, the clack of her heels rhythmic against the marble flooring. “And stay close in case of an emergency. If anything should happen, you can always speak with me. I am here for you as are all the other heirs.” She pauses in contemplation then adds, “Besides Anaxagoras.”

“Thank you, Aglaea. May the flamechase bear fruit.” He turns to leave only to be stopped by a gentle hand on his shoulder.

“It will do you good to speak with Phainon,” Aglaea says, her lips slightly pursed. “He has not been at his best recently.”

“I plan to,” Mydei responds. His heart twists in his chest. “There is much to discuss.”



Marmoreal Market is as bustling as he remembers to be with crowds of smiling cityfolk strolling around, vendors shouting their wares, and lively patrons enjoying Okheman cuisine whilst lounging around. The aroma of freshly cooked food fills the midday air.

There’s never a quiet day in Okhema.

A smile pulls at the corner of his lips, threatening to spill over only to dim when he once again feels the stares. Really, what did he expect?

He strides through the market, honing in on his destination and ignoring all else. As he makes his way up the stone steps, he spots a familiar shock of moonlight hair. As he had predicted,

Phainon is once again appraising antiques, a concentrated frown on his face as he repeatedly flips the object in his hand.

“It’s been awhile, Deliverer,” Mydei greets.

The very picture of grace, Phainon jerks and nearly drops the rusted mirror he’s holding. Eyes wide like he’s been caught red-handed, he turns and gives an awkward laugh, “Mydei! Didn’t think I would see you here.”

Mydei takes a peek at the artifact. It looks to be Kremnoan by the razor sharp designs, but the uncertainty in the carvings and the obviously flimsy, crumbling material gives its identity away as an obvious fake. Kremnoan craftsmen were renowned for their ability to forge. Never would they allow such poor quality to exist. “Don’t buy that.”

“Fake?” Phainon asks. When Mydei nods, he laughs again and places the mirror back. “Right, right. I knew that...”

“You’re not looking at the *amphora* ?” Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow. “There’s many this time, of all different colors too... Are they not your favorite? You’ve been stating you wish to increase your collection. Repeatedly, if I may add.”

Phainon turns red. He coughs and says, “Nah, I’m not too into those nowadays…” When Theodoros gives him a look of exasperation, he straightens and says, “Anyways, it’s been awhile. How have you been?”

“Fine.” *Terrible.*

The medications have done their job. He feels almost normal again if not for the newfound knowledge of his nature. He can pretend all he wants, outwardly act as if he’s still genderless and continue to posture as such, but he’ll never be able to erase the truth.

Phainon tries to act natural, unbothered. If Mydei didn’t know him so well, he would almost be fooled, but the strain of his muscles and his rapidly charring scent gives him away. What Mydei could barely detect before is obvious now.

“Good. That’s good… Love the one word answers. Truly. Glad to know that you’re still mad at me.” Phainon gestures towards the nearby corridors and says, “Let’s discuss somewhere with fewer people.” With a quick and quipped farewell to Theodoros, he stalks off.

“I’m not mad at you,” Mydei states as he follows behind Phainon. Normally, they would stride side-by-side, arms brushing against each other every few steps, but Mydei doesn’t think he can stand to see the expression darkening Phainon’s usually friendly features. And though he feels normal, he’s still apprehensive of steeping himself in Phainon’s scent. It’s better to stay a little distance away until he’s sure his body will no longer react, even if a small part of him wishes so dearly to grab onto Phainon and never let go.

“You ignored me,” Phainon says as they pass the Verax Leo. He leans against the stone railing overlooking the waterfall and says, “For four full days, might I add.”

Ah. “My teleslate died, and I didn’t have the chance to charge it,” Mydei explains as he tentatively settles by Phainon’s side. “I didn’t see your messages until the day I replied.”

Phainon pauses, his blue eyes narrow as he forces a grin, “Busy, huh?”

“I said I would explain when I saw you in person,” Mydei says. “I intend to do just that.”

“There’s not much to explain. Everyone knows what you were doing. Was a fun time, I’ll bet,” Phainon shrugs, attempting an air of nonchalance, but Mydei can easily see the pinch of his eyebrows and the strain in his voice.

And this entire time, Phainon’s scent has been devolving, a sweet spring meadow starting to dry out and burn beneath the sun’s unrelenting rays.

Oh, how badly Mydei wants to grab Phainon by his two unruly hair strands and chuck him across the room. His hand twitches, yet his restraint holds.

“I fell sick,” Mydei explains as he stares down at the crystalline water. Swirling patterns of purple and turquoise spot the clear surface. “I wasn’t feeling well.”

“Oh.” Phainon raises an eyebrow in obvious disbelief. “You… get sick? Aren’t you immortal?”

Mydei leans in and flicks him on the forehead. Hard. Better that than a punch to the gut.

“Ow?” Phainon responds, his eyes wide as he rubs at the rapidly reddening indent.

With a huff and a glare, Mydei says, “Yes, I indeed get sick. My body is stronger, but I’m still not immune. Are you daft?”

He felt like he was going to die during his pre-heat. Death is not a foreign concept to him. He’s lost count of how many times he’s fallen, yet, somehow, going through pre-heat is worse. Much worse. At least in death, he’s not drowning in a pool of his own slick.

“I’m not daft, only disbelieving,” Phainon says as he continues to absentmindedly rub at his forehead. “What kind of sickness would dispatch you for that long? You’re not talking about your rut, are you? That’s not sickness, my dear Mydeimos.”

For a moment, he debates saying it was rut. He’d get Phainon teasing him for mistaking it as sickness, but it would be far easier to explain. Only he finds posturing as an alpha to be sickening. He is not willing to overstep that boundary. Not now, not ever.

“It’s not rut,” Mydei says. *I wish it was rut. I’d much prefer that actually,* is what he wants to say.

At this moment, this singular perfect moment, a little boy scampers towards them, his eyes wide as he exclaims, “Your highness! Is it true? You’ve found yourself a princess?”

Phainon turns away.

The boy's mother runs in and grabs her child, pulling him behind her. She bows frantically, a little out of breath. "My apologies, Lord Mydeimos. Please excuse us." She pushes her child away as her footsteps clack down the corridor.

The air begins to thicken with burnt flora. Phainon continues to stare blankly at the waterfall, his eyebrows pinching. The urge to placate him is overbearing, and Mydei finds himself scrambling to say, "Don't believe everything you hear, Deliverer. Truly, the cityfolks' imaginations know no bounds."

"So there's no omega?" Phainon prods. He leans down to pick up a stray strone and tosses it haphazardly into the water. His eyes trail the alternating ripple patterns. "But you smelled like one and I visited you too. I could detect the scent even from outside. Strong, almost overwhelming. It gave me a headache."

Mydei freezes. "Why were you at my house?"

Phainon shrugs. "I wanted to speak to you in person. You've been ignoring me, and I wished to clear up any misconceptions before they festered. It seems only one of us is interested in that endeavor."

Once a small, controlled bushfire, now a destructive, blazing wildfire. He wants to scream at Phainon to control his pheromones, but instead, he yanks the alpha by his wrist and says, "We're going outside. There's little airflow here."

"Why are you so resistant?" Phainon asks as he allows himself to be pulled along. "Embarrassed?"

Mydei has to bite his lip from lashing out. Infuriating. Stubborn. Idiotic. He's not sure if he's talking about himself or Phainon. His palm burns from the contact.

"It's none of your business," Mydei says flatly.

They stride through Kephale Plaza. Mydei ignores the numerous pairs of prodding eyes that turn in their direction. He almost wants to yell at them to get back to business and to stop being nosy, but he knows he's already causing a scene by showing up whilst dragging along a bumbling idiot.

"Contrary, I think it is my business," Phainon shoots back.

"It is not. What I do in my spare time has *nothing* to do with you." *Liar.*

"You spend most of your spare time with me," Phainon says as he pulls up his fingers to count. "Like eighty percent."

Mydei's head spins in a whirl of contradiction. A little voice in the back of his head tells him to apologize to the alpha. It wants so badly to placate Phainon, wants to tell him, it's me, I'm the omega. Please don't be angry at me. But he shakes away those thoughts, slams them onto the ground and eviscerates them until they cease to exist, and allows the indignation to overtake the shame.

“I will not entertain this conversation any longer.” *Stop. Please. I can’t tell you the truth. Not now.*

His words have the opposite effect. Phainon shows off his sharp canines and says, “Are you ashamed of her? Is that why? Was this some sort of mistake? You don’t smell like her any longer. Did you toss her aside?”

The charred scent overwhelms him, and anger brews hot, spilling over in a tidal wave of hurt. He almost can’t handle it anymore, but he manages to stop himself from lashing out. He stills in his step only for Phainon to say, “You seem ashamed.”

The restraint Mydei so desperately holds onto snaps. With a frustrated growl, he yanks Phainon by the leather strap crossing his chest and roughly slams him against the nearest wall. His voice lowers, “ *Deliverer.* Cease this at once.”

Unfazed, Phainon smiles, devious and lopsided as if he’s entertained by Mydei’s outburst. He even has the audacity to laugh when Mydei pushes him further into the white stone. Their faces are mere centimeters apart, breaths intermingling, eyes locked in a heated battle.

Without missing a beat, Phainon leans closer and murmurs hot in his ear, “Mydeimos, there’s no need to be so defensive. I’m only asking honest questions here. Her *sickly sweet* scent once covered your entire body…” He wrinkles his nose, revisiting the unpleasant sensation. “And now, it's completely gone. What else am I supposed to think? Was she a fling? I didn’t think Kremnoans were the type, but I’ve seen the way your men look at and speak about omegas.”

Sickly sweet. Mydei’s grip trembles.

He thinks your scent is sickly sweet. He doesn’t like it. He said it gave him a headache. He will never—

Shut up. Shut up. Shut up.

The pangs in his chest grow unbearable, yet he claws away the upset and snarls, “Drop it.”

Phainon twirls blonde strands, lets it fall in between his fingers. His blue eyes shine glint in dark amusement as he says, “Why so defensive? Are you hiding something, hm?”

His heart skips a beat, yet he scoffs, “I have nothing to hide. Why are you so insistent? It’s bordering on inappropriate.”

“I’m only curious to see who could have caught the eye of the famous crown prince of Castrum Kremnos, that’s all,” Phainon replies airily. “Surely, she must have been something special, but I guess not if you’ve dropped her that easily.”

Mydei’s eyes darken, shadows cast over the gold by the curve of his eyelashes. “Deliverer, do you sincerely believe me as that sort? The type to toss those aside?”

Brilliant blue clashes with molten amber. A voice in the back of his head, once quiet and negligible, now screams at him to submit, to look away, that he shouldn’t be challenging his

alpha like this, that he should bow down and apologize—

But he holds on. His gauntlets claw into the leather. The world narrows.

It's only the two of them. All else melts away.

The first to turn away is Phainon. The fire dims, and his scent flattens. He looks lost, upset, a swirl of emotion darkening his vibrant blue eyes. His head bows down in defeat. "No, I don't. I… I misspoke." The tension leaves his shoulders, and he slumps in Mydei's grip, seeming much like a scolded puppy.

Mydei releases his hold. The anger melts into upset, and he turns away to hide the twisting of his features. "Let's agree to not discuss this further."

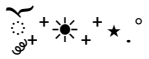
"I agree," Phainon says softly as he dusts himself off. "My apologies, Mydei. I let my emotions get the better of me."

Mydei surveys their surroundings, relieved to find there's no eavesdropping passersby. "Control your pheromones, Deliverer. I do believe Aglaea has told you already."

A sheepish laugh falls from Phainon's lips. He runs a shaky hand through his moonlight hair. "I'm trying. Aglaea has actually been giving me lessons! Not sure if they're working though.... I don't know what's wrong with me since I've never had this type of trouble before. Seems like it's only been this… past week…" He coughs. "Yeah… So, uh—"

"I still owe you dinner from our last spar," Mydei interrupts, sparing Phainon the embarrassment of rambling on and on. He turns to meet the other's gaze and says, "Shall we?"

Phainon nods and attempts a smile. It doesn't quite reach his eyes.



Dinner goes on well enough, far less awkward than he expects. Phainon acts as if their previous fight hadn't happened at all. No mention of anything related to scents or rumors.

He's glad for it. Truthfully, he doesn't think he can handle having Phainon angry at him. His own rage has long since dissipated, leaving only a forlorn emptiness that has him struggling with every breath he takes.

Lashing out was a mistake. Phainon didn't deserve it. After all, it's only natural for him to be curious. His responses were rather flimsy, but he doesn't have much else to lean on without revealing too much.

They grab some fresh gyros from a nearby stand, one that Phainon has pestered him to try for the past few months. It's good, he can admit. The meat is tender, bursting with savory flavor, and meshes well with the soft of the flatbread and the creaminess of the yogurt sauce. The two of them leisurely stroll around the city, snaking through narrow alleyways and taking the paths with the least amount of people.

Phainon chats away as he always does, gesturing rapidly as he speaks about what he's been up to these past few weeks. Mydei finds his lips quirking up on their own as he slowly closes the distance between their bodies.

With a sheepish laugh, Phainon tells Mydei how he wandered out of Okhema to kill some titankin only to step into some strange ruins that turned out to be enchanted on a loop. He spent hours walking around only to realize he had been stuck in the same place, the door bringing him back to his starting point.

Mydei nearly smacks him for that. Phainon waves him off with a pout, and says he's fine. No wounds, nothing. It was a good learning experience.

The cityfolk stare at them as they pass by. No doubt, many have heard about what had transpired in Kephale plaza only hours prior, but he pays them no mind.

Phainon wraps a tentative arm around his shoulder, and Mydei finds himself reacting immediately, pushing into the touch instead of pulling away. Maybe he shouldn't. The smartest choice would be to keep distance, but it feels nice, and he doesn't want to let go.

It's as if all is normal again, like everything that's happened in the past few weeks has only been a dream. Naturally friendly, Phainon has always been more on the touchy side, jumping at the chance for physical contact and never shying away. He's like this with everyone, and though Mydei shouldn't, he always indulges. The extra warmth is nice, and he's missed it dearly.

But there's that tinge of bitterness, the slight char in Phainon's scent that doesn't abate. He's still a little upset, even if it doesn't show on his face.

Mydei knows he shouldn't be so weak as to fall to his emotions that easily but anything regarding Phainon has him acting *off* . The medications are working as they should. His scent is gone. He no longer has any symptoms, no heat burning beneath his skin, no prickling in his nape, no wetness between his thighs, yet he still feels strange as if he isn't in full control of his body anymore.

"It's nearing curtain fall hour. I'll walk you back to your home," Phainon says. "I rather enjoy when the Kremnoans glare at me."

"They won't if I'm around."

"Nah, they do," Phainon laughs. "You just don't see it. For such straightforward people, they can be very sneaky."

Boots clack on stone. Kephale's dawn beams down, lighting Phainon in a brilliant halo. His smiles grow wide, brighter. It's almost blinding.

"Deliverer," Mydei says.

"Hm?"

"I'm sorry," he says, "for my previous behavior. It was uncouth. I shouldn't have lashed out."

Phainon's expression takes one of shock. He shakes his head fervently and says, "It's fine. Don't worry about it." His blue eyes soften. "I shouldn't have pushed you so hard. It's true, what you do is none of my business. I just…" He turns away. "I wanted to know who caught your attention. It's rare for you… I mean—I just thought, y'know, you weren't—uh… interested in dating? Though, you are a prince… and it's your duty to find your future queen, so maybe I'm wrong…"

"There's no one," Mydei says. "Believe me." He can't tell the truth, but he still wishes to reassure the other as best as he can. Desire blooms in his chest.

Phainon deflates, his eyes downcast. His voice comes out soft. "Alright, I trust you. Besides, I still never apologized for scenting you—"

"Scent me."

They both freeze.

Phainon chokes, wrestling with words. Mydei turns away, his cheeks beginning to burn.

"I'm only asking this once," Mydei says. The horror on his face is tangible. "I won't repeat myself."

He almost wants to say they're friends and friends scent each other to show camaraderie, but no, that singular term doesn't encapsulate the depth of their relationship. It feels almost a disservice to call them that. There's more weight to what they have than a simple friendship.

"I don't have a scent I can give you, but I'll gladly take yours," Mydei says. His heart thumps in his chest. "I'm not angry over you scenting me. It was unexpected, but not terrible..."

He shouldn't be doing this, playing with fire. Phainon scenting him had worsened his pre-heat to levels almost unbearable. He's walking on coals, yet he can't help but enjoy the burn. The thought of Phainon marking him… it sparks a storm in his chest.

A gesture of possession. That hungry part of him that has reared its head, and it won't leave until it's satisfied. It hasn't even been a few hours, yet he's already falling back to old habits.

Telling Phainon the truth flashes across his mind. It's tempting, but he knows if he does, their relationship will change. It's not that he doesn't trust Phainon, he does, but his desire to keep his status hidden is priority. Only Hyacine and Aglaea know, and he wants to keep it that way.

“I’m assuming you do indeed take scent blockers and suppressants,” Phainon finally says. He wrings his hands.

Mydei nods. “I do.”

“Why?” Phainon asks.

“Easier this way,” Mydei says. “For everyone.”

“Ah, yeah. An alpha like you would surely dominate the room. Leave some for the rest of us,” Phainon laughs only for it to fizzle out when he finds that Mydei hasn’t taken to the joke. “Ahem. You know, I’d love to know what you smell like.”

Mydei can spot the pink dusting his cheeks. His lips quirk up, “You will continue to wonder, Deliverer.”

Phainon pouts. “Okay, okay. It was worth a shot.”

His real scent is too sweet, sickly sweet as Phainon so nicely put it. The alpha practically admitted point blank that he doesn’t like it, and it makes Mydei feel unworthy. He shakes off the irrational feelings. Maybe when the time is right, he’ll find the courage to reveal the truth, but for now, he will lock that part of him and throw away the key.

Phainon is his equal on all fronts, but if he admits himself to be an omega, reveals the secrets hidden within, will they still be running on equal ground?

“Here?” Phainon whispers, leaning close. His eyes flick around. They’re currently passing down a side street, empty but still open to any passersby. They round the corner and enter a courtyard lined with lilies and wisteria.

“Might as well,” Mydei replies gruffly. “We’re soon to reach my neighborhood. Do you want to do it in front of my countrymen? I’m sure they’ll be pleased.”

“Do you wish for my demise?” Phainon says, the corner of his eyes crinkling. He presses his face into the side of Mydei’s neck as his fingers trace Mydei’s chin. His voice lowers into a breathy murmur, “My dear Mydei, you can be so cruel. Though, I can’t say I’m not tempted… Your people can no longer ignore my importance if I shamelessly scent their prince in front of them.”

“You overestimate yourself,” Mydei says as he wraps his arms around Phainon’s upper back. He feels Phainon’s nose and cheek drag around his neck. Warm lips press softly against rapidly flushing skin. It’s almost tortuous how slow Phainon is going, as if he’s purposefully drawing this out for a reaction. Mydei bites his lip to stop a moan from inadvertently slipping out.

Phainon hums. His arms, once wrapped around Mydei’s waist, have moved upwards to his nape. His fingers gently part the reddish strands. “You always let me get away with it.”

A breath catches in Mydei’s throat when Phainon’s wrists begin to rub slow circles into his untouched mating gland. For a moment, he panics at the prospect of having anything near his

nape, but the gentle motions are soothing, and he finds himself melting against Phainon's sweet touch. There's no prickling sensation, no thousand needles driving into his skin, only a soft, fuzzy warmth that has his features flushing in content.

This is nice. It feels good. Phainon's springtime scent is mellower now, sweeter and more crisp. No longer is it cloying and aggressive. He likes it.

Another soft press of warm lips as moonlight hair tickles the bottom of Mydei's chin. "Mine," Phainon mutters under his breath, long eyelashes fluttering as they press against feverish skin.

Mydei isn't quite sure he's heard correctly. His eyelids grow heavy as he slowly strokes Phainon's back, running his fingers down the smooth leather, as Phainon continues to mouth softly against his neck. He's missed Phainon. Missed this.

They'll go back to how they were before. Rivals. Equals. Fellow Chrysos Heirs. Nothing more, nothing less.

Chapter End Notes

me slapping a bunch more world-building into this chapter haha :'D

thank you for reading!! 💕

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

His relationship with Mydei returns to normal. Kind of. As normal as it can be given the circumstances. Even so, Phainon is relieved. After the disaster that had been the last week of his life, he's happy to put it all behind him, toss it in the dark recesses of his mind to never again revisit.

The near constant heartache that has pestered him everyday for the past week has resolved itself, and no longer does he have to deal with the incessant butterflies fluttering around in his stomach, leaving him breathless and gasping for air as his mind inevitably wanders off in directions he wouldn't broach with a ten foot pole. As a bonus, the people of Okhema have returned to kind greetings and smiles, no longer eyeing him with concern whenever they see him strolling down the streets alone.

Where Kephale's dawn once burned his skin and irritated his eyes, it's now warm and inviting, a comforting embrace instead of a searing squeeze. No longer does he have to hide in the shade, and his pheromones have steadied substantially, much to Aglaea's relief.

Once a week, he sits with Tribbie and Aglaea in the Garden of Life amidst blooming wisteria, multicolored anemone, and floating lily pads. There's no set meeting time, but it's been a habit for the past few years to show up every Saturday during the third quint of action hour. Towering willow trees cast speckled shadows as they lounge comfortably in the cool shaded grass.

"I'm happy for you, Snowy!" Tribbie exclaims, unbridled joy flashing in her wide blue eyes when he tells her that he's made up with Mydei.

In his lap, an orange chimera coos softly, content and fast asleep as it nuzzles against his thighs. He's glad this one doesn't have any horns because the last one left a nasty bruise that even had Hyacine startled. Hiding his concern behind a veil of disbelief, Mydei asked why he was limping only for Phainon to admit sheepishly that he couldn't ruse a sleeping chimera from its hearty slumber.

Soft hums leave his lips as he gently runs his fingers through the chimera's fluffy red collar, delighting in the feel of warm, fuzzy fur. Beside him, Tribbie bounces around, a white and blue chimera chirping in her arms.

"De is not the type to ignore," she continues on. "He's very straightforward!"

Aglaea, beautifully elegant as usual, sits across from Phainon while idly petting a golden chimera. Her lips quirk up, "I'm delighted the issue between the two of you is resolved. If such were to arise again—"

“It won’t,” Phainon rushes in to say. Normally he would never cut her off, but this time, he’s eager to clear his mistakes. “I jumped to conclusions too quickly, even when told repeatedly not to. I worried you both for nothing…”

“Awoo…?” The little chimera in his lap snores and rubs against his thighs. It reminds him so much of Mydei, only smaller and far less aggressive. Equally as adorable though, not that he’d ever admit that part out loud.

“No worries, Snowy! It happens to the best of us! As long as you learn from it,” Tribbie smiles, rosy-cheeked. She releases the chimera in her arms and watches as it squeaks a farewell and bounces off to meet its brethren. “Have you confessed to De yet?”

“Teacher,” Aglaea begins, a touch of concern in her melodious voice.

Phainon laughs a little too loudly. A few passing chimeras pause to stare at him, heads tilted in question, and the one in his lap scrunches its nose and gives a small huff.

He’s fixed with Tribbie’s all-knowing, patient gaze. The laughter surges only to fizzle out completely. “No, I haven’t. I can’t. Well, you’ve heard the rumors…”

“They are completely unfound,” Aglaea says firmly. “There is no truth in them.”

“But—”

“Agy is right!” Tribbie exclaims, crossing her arms in the same manner Mydei does. When she sees his conflicted expression, she pats him on the head and says gently, “Snowy, you should tell him. You’ve been holding onto these feelings for so long now... The heart’s desires cannot be ignored nor suppressed forever.”

A lone wisteria petal floats down and lands on his shoulder. He twirls it around, moonlight eyelashes casting shadows over his normally vibrant eyes. “It’s still too risky. I have to make sure he reciprocates before I do anything rash.” *I don’t want to lose him.* “When the time is right, I will confess, just not now…”

“Snowy…” Tribbie deflates.

“We shouldn’t rush him, teacher,” Aglaea says.

Regardless of the warm, pleasant weather, a chill runs down Phainon’s spine. Normally, Aglaea would agree with Tribbie and continue to nudge him towards confessing, yet this time…

As if in agreement, the chimera in Phainon’s lap mumbles out another, “Awoo…”

Much of his free time is once again spent with Mydei. They spar, hang out around the city, lounge in the baths. The sight of them together is commonplace as they take to idling around, enjoying each other's presence, and of course, trying to one up one another. All manner of normal.

Only now, Mydei allows Phainon to scent him. Publicly too, even if he does try to half-heartedly push back only to inevitably melt at the first press of Phainon's lips against his bare skin.

It's later in the day, nearing curtain-fall hour. Kephale's dawn shines bright as it always does, covering all in its neverending warmth. Many of the cityfolk have retired for the day, so in the broad daylight, Phainon corners Mydei and presses him against the temple wall. It's inlaid with a mural of Mnestia in all her glorious beauty, her arms raised up, lips curved into a sensual smile as if she's overlooking and blessing their union.

This might be blasphemy, but given her title as the titan of romance, maybe she'll let this slide. Or not. Doesn't matter either way. He's not about to stop.

Somehow, no one in the city has caught on yet, but the excitement, the potential of rampant whisperings has him all over Mydei. He can't get enough, intoxicated as he is by the sight of the other alpha, beautiful, all sharp edges and radiant features.

Mydei glances around, golden eyes flitting corner to corner as Phainon presses soft kisses to his bared neck. Oh how badly Phainon wants to move lower, wants to trail his lips down the crimson expanse of markings covering Mydei's tanned skin, commit the patterns to memory, but he restrains himself. For now, he's content with rubbing his scent, staking claim, reminding all that Mydei is his and only his.

No one else can get near Mydei. The Kremnoans can glare all they want. It won't change a thing. They can attack him all they want with sharp words and even sharper weapons, but he won't be deterred so long as Mydei allows him.

If he were to think about it for longer than a passing moment, Mydei's sudden and drastic change in behavior makes little to no sense. In the past, he used to slyly scent the prince, never able to scrounge the courage to bring up the topic and ask for overt permission. Mydei never said anything about it, never once stopping to ask why Phainon had been releasing more pheromones than usual during their spars or why he made every excuse to brush their bodies together. Almost like he was unaware.

But that can't be it.

"Are you trying to draw blood?" Mydei hisses when Phainon nips him with his canines. Sharp metal gauntlets dig into the meat of his arm. A warning to behave.

"My bad," Phainon smiles as his tongue peaks out to lick at the rapidly reddening mark. He ends with a soft brush of his lips, murmuring, "I didn't mean to."

"Be careful next time," Mydei says gruffly. Pink dusts his cheeks, and Phainon delights in it, delights in the reactions that only he can draw out.

Next time. Those two words reverberate in his head. Mydei wants a next time. And possibly a time after. And after. His brilliant blues shine as he slowly trails his hands down Mydei's muscled back, the tip of his fingers ghosting down the curve of his spine.

The prince tenses only to relax once more, almost like he's at war with himself, melting and freezing on repeat, but never once telling Phainon to stop.

Maybe he should know better than to continue steeping Mydei, a fellow alpha, in his scent, rubbing himself all over, covering his mating gland. He's surprised Mydei lets him, bares his neck out for him in an almost coy manner, and flutters his eyelashes as he tries to hold back small gasps.

What Phainon is doing is an obvious stake for claim, marking someone's mating gland in such a forthright manner, yet Mydei doesn't seem to mind or care.

Phainon pulls away first this time much to Mydei's confusion. Long eyelashes cast shadows over his eyes as he runs a hand through his moonlight locks. His thoughts always stray in this manner, but he can't help it. Not when he has Mydei in front of him, looking so vulnerable in ways Phainon never thought he would.

Are his affections returned? Does Mydei feel the same way?

No, he can't jump to conclusions yet. Truth to be told, he didn't think he would get this far. Never in his wildest dreams did he think Mydei would allow him this… this intimacy.

"I'll see you tomorrow?" he says, attempting nonchalance. "Same time, same place."

Mydei nods. He presses a tentative finger to the bruise on his neck, golden eyes glowing beneath the shadows cast by the temple's pillars. There's no scent on his body, and it bothers Phainon more than it should.

The stake for claim is one-sided. Mydei will not scent him. And even told him point blank that he will continue to stay scentless, on those medications. If Mydei were to scent him back, it would be confirmation that Mydei returned his affections. Then he could confess.

Why Mydei even takes those pills in the first place is lost on him. There's little to no reason, especially for a warrior meant to command attention on the battlefield. An alpha's pheromones are their greatest source of power, capable of controlling and silencing those lesser. The potential to subjugate is a tool many rulers have used to their advantage, and even common foot soldiers are trained to sharpen and hone their pheromones to use against their enemies. As far as he remembers, Kremnoans take it very seriously.

Well, whatever. He'll continue testing the waters before finding the correct time to plunge right in. Phainon isn't going to look a gift dromas in the mouth. The teeth might not be perfect, but who is he to complain?

The days go by in a blur. Okhema, for the most part, is peaceful. No attacks from invading titankin, no huge calamities, no calls for emergency missions or dispatching of the army.

By all means, Phainon should be relaxed, content. Especially today of all days. What he thought was another normal weekday.

Entry hour had been filled—no, flooded—with antique appraisal. A recent excavation had unearthed many never before seen artifacts, overloading Okhema with wares, and Phainon had the first pick due to his status as Chrysos Heir. Much to Aglaea and Mydei's exponentially increasing exasperation, his home is now stuffed with even more trinkets, glazed vases with curved handles, ceramic plates artfully decorated with mythical scenes, and even shimmering crystalline jewels, his favorite being an amber gem flecked with orange that reminds him of Mydei's eyes. Some of them might be fake, yes, and his wallet may be completely empty, relieved of its heavy financial burden, but he's felt more content than he has in a long while. An abuse of power on his end to take first pickings, but Theodoros offered, and he's not about to say no.

Afternoon had his customary spar with Mydei, this time with weapons. Mydei had chosen a sword, and of course, Phainon kept to his greatsword. The spar stayed even, lasting for hours, only to end with the tip of Mydei's sword tucked under his chin, both of them glowing beneath the dawn's rays, breathing heavily but grinning from ear to ear. All in all a good, worthwhile spar, even if Mydei won this time. He won't next time.

Phainon posits he only lost because Mydei had cheated, distracted him by bearing the purpling bite mark on his neck. For a few precious moments, his mind blanked and when he came to, he had been thrown onto his back with the other alpha asking him to yield. Definitely not fair. Why did Mydei always have to look so perfect? A divine being amongst a sea of normal men.

When he voices his complaints, Mydei scoffs and says, "Stop being a sore loser."

"Am not!" Phainon argues back. He has little to stand on aside from admitting that he had been staring a little too hard.

Now, they're relaxing, waiting for the final hours of the day to tick on by. Settled in one of the public courtyards, Mydei lounges beside him. They're seated comfortably on wooden chairs overlooking a pond full of lotus flowers and elegant luminescent fish, and the air smells softly floral with large stalks of wisteria swaying gently in the spring breeze. Gentle yet melodious chimes of wind bells fill the area.

Only there's one problem. One tiny, teensy small problem.

It's not a big deal, really. To think about it is to bring it into existence, so he will ignore it. Continue to play pretend even as he's surrounded on all sides, boxed in by a city that has an

untold favoritism towards a specific *fruit* . All around him are lush trees dotted with blooming red blossoms—a constant, never-ending reminder.

Relaxation be damned. The hustle and bustle had left him without time to think. Now that he's lounging around, he's hit full force.

By far the smartest option is to wipe away all memory of that… that accursed scent. There's no way he'll bring it up since he can't afford to anger Mydei again nor can he disappoint Tribbie and Aglaea with his lack of emotional control. It's a touchy subject for sure, and the regret from how he lashed out stays palpable, bitter. He acted akin to a heartbroken maiden who had been told her promised lover had left her on the altar for another woman. Only Mydei isn't his lover. Titans, he's pathetic.

The sticky omegan scent no longer clings onto Mydei's skin. Gone. No trace of her left. Disappeared as if it never existed to begin with. Aglaea and Tribbie have confirmed the rumors to be false, but he swears he didn't hallucinate that scent.

And the itch beneath Phainon's skin hasn't abated. No, if anything, it's gotten worse, the slow crawl, like static electricity, has become millions of red hot needles jabbing deep, drawing rivulets of golden blood. His mind wanders to *her* , who she is, what she looks like and sounds like, if her voice is as soft and sweet as the scent she exudes and if her body is as warm and inviting. He dare say her scent rivals ambrosia, nectar of the gods.

Maybe he could handle it, toss away all thoughts of honey and pomegranate in his mind, ignore the plethora of trees with their red blossoms soon to become fruit, only there's one gigantic issue—an issue he can't ignore in the shape of Mydeimos, fellow alpha, fellow Chrysos Heir, crown prince of Castrum Kremnos.

Phainon glances over and immediately regrets it because Mydei is leisurely swirling his crystal chalice around, taking slow sips from it every so often. The sweet, tart juice has tinted his lips a delicate red, and the small, content smile that softens his striking features only serves to heighten the contradiction blazing in Phainon's chest. He turns away before Mydei can give him the side eye.

The prince's love of pomegranates has made itself known—what once barely registered in Phainon's mind is now very much apparent. Yes, he knows Mydei likes pomegranates, has known since practically the first day they've met, but never has it bothered him until now.

Pomegranates. His second greatest enemy. One look at the round shape, the glistening red skin, and the crispy crimson arils has his mind wandering in strange and obscene directions. Even a singular whiff of its juice has his mind buzzing with hot desire, heat curling within his gut.

He's acting absurd. He knows. Mydei's eyes flit over to him every so often yet he doesn't say anything, only continues to bask in the stillness, not quite comfortable yet not quite stifling. They've sat here for the past fifteen minutes, resting after the particularly brutal spar that left both of them breathless and aching. While Mydei's immortal body is more resilient when it comes to taking hits, Phainon doesn't have that luxury. By tomorrow, he'll probably be nursing some heavy bruises on his abdomen, but the pain barely registers, not when Mydei is

seated beside him, sipping that accursed red drink made from that horrible fruit that seems to populate half of Okhema's crops.

Stop thinking about pomegranates. Stop it. Stop. Stop.

Silence blankets the surroundings save for the occasional footsteps of passing cityfolk. Phainon stares blankly at the gliding fish and continues to drink his water only to realize his jug is completely empty and has been for awhile now. He's been chugging away at air.

Mydei glances at him once more as he wipes away a layer of dust on the table and gently places his chalice down. From this angle, Phainon can see the red liquid, can smell its sweet, tantalizing aroma. It threatens to choke him, a shadow of a threat lurking beneath its murky surface. Regardless of all the water he's drank in the last few minutes, his mouth dries, parched like dried out crops in the sweltering heat of summer.

"Something the matter, Deliverer?" Mydei asks. Sharp golden eyes trace over his form, and Phainon resists the urge to shiver beneath the observant gaze. "The fish can't be that interesting."

"They are," he replies, resting his elbow on the table. With a lazy grin, he waves his hand around and continues, "I rather enjoy watching them swim around. Look at that one on the right, the one that's wiggling around, trying to bite at the lilypad. It looks more purple than the rest. Isn't that amazing?"

"Very," Mydei says dryly.

Phainon's gaze traces over the crystalline chalice as Mydei steadily strokes the glass, gauntleted fingers running down the body in slow, repeated motions. He holds his expression carefree, resisting the urge to frown and hiss at the crimson liquid. "No milk this time?"

"I ran out," Mydei replies.

Yeah. Of course. Okay, whatever. If it were pink, maybe it would be more manageable.

Control yourself, Aglaea's voice reverberates in his head. Deep breaths in and out.

"Did my juice do something to you?" Mydei asks, raising an eyebrow. He pushes his glass towards Phainon, the ornate gold stem glinting beneath the bright sunlight, "Do you want some?"

What part of my expression makes you think I want some? I don't. Get that away from me, Phainon wants to say—or scream—only his hand moves on its own, disconnected from his brain. Ok, fine. He's overreacting. Maybe taking a sip will solve all his problems. The crimson liquid looks a little too much like blood, thick like it too. He brings it up to face, taking care not to inhale, and takes a tentative sip. Sweet and tart, the juice coats his tongue and lands with a slightly bitter aftertaste, lingering in the moments after. It tastes good, complex in flavor, delicious and cold.

Phainon wrinkles his nose. The burning in his gut returns full force.

He shouldn’t have done that. Damn it.

Against his better judgement, Phainon asks, “Why do you like pomegranates so much?” He slides the chalice back to Mydei who catches it, gauntleted fingers curving gracefully around the stem.

With a huff, he rests his back against the stone wall, attempting to act nonchalant. Unbothered. If only that were true. If only his mind weren’t supplying him with a million thoughts at once, and his heart starts to squeeze, compress as if he’s being juiced. Ha. Haha…

He can’t take it anymore.

Before Mydei even has a chance to respond, Phainon starts rattling off transgressions as if the fruit had broken the law and he’s the purveyor of justice, a loyal follower of Talanton ready to pass judgement. “There’s nothing good about these stupid looking fruits! Nothing! First of all, they’re stupidly ugly and bulbous, far too round for absolutely no reason at all, and they’re a giant pain in the ass to peel! And don’t even get me started on the juice—oh titans, the juice—it stains clothing like no tomorrow!“

“…“

“It’s like the fruit knows if you’re wearing white and tries to mess you up on purpose—I can’t tell you how many times I’ve gotten it splattered on me, and I was being extra careful too! Taking extra time to ensure not a single drop got on me and next thing I knew, the entire front of my chiton was splotched red… I even stained some expensive tailored outfits Aglaea gave me and, ugh, let me tell you, she wasn’t happy with me—“

“Deliverer—“

“Don’t even get me started on the pith! It’s thick, way too thick for its own good, and hard to crack open for no reason at all, and then you have to make sure you don’t accidentally eat any of it because it’s super dry, astringent, gross with such a weird spongy, grainy texture that shouldn’t exist because it's an affront to mankind! You also have to pick out the membrane pieces too—which is annoying by the way—because eating that is like eating nasty, bitter wax paper, and there’s a giant seed in the middle of each aril which means you barely get any of the actual fruit and have to deal with spitting out—”

Mydei slams his chalice onto the dusty table. Hard. Gold rattles against aged wood.

Phainon jumps.

A vein ticks on Mydei’s forehead, his patience worn thin. The table cracks, wood splintering where the metal connected. “If you’re splattering juice all over then you’re not opening it correctly. That’s clumsiness on your part, Deliverer. Don’t blame the fruit for your ineptitude. You can swallow the seeds too, they’re edible and good for you.”

Phainon rolls his eyes and waves him off. “I still don’t like them. Grapes taste much better and are far less work for basically the same thing.” He sits back up and clasps his hands

together. “And you don’t have to peel them. Just pop 'em in your mouth, and you’re done. Though, I guess you can peel them if you really want to… My point still stands.”

“What?” Mydei questions, confusion evident in his voice. “I… Okay. No one is forcing you to like anything. Calm down.”

Being told to calm down does nothing to help his mood. His annoyance stews and stews until it boils over in a flood of molten anger, brought forth by Mydei’s irritatingly obvious lack of scent. Mydei is already difficult enough to read, able to keep his expression calm in even the most dire of situations. If only he could smell Mydei, bathe in his scent until his mind is far removed from any thought of pomegranate. He knows Mydei smells good, amazing, the sort of scent that permeates, grips one by the throat and doesn’t let go. After all, there’s no part of Mydei that isn’t perfect.

The red liquid taunts him, mocks him. He needs it gone. Now. Only then can he think straight.

Mydei barely takes another sip before Phainon reaches over, yanks the chalice out of his hands, and downs the rest in one go.

“Here,” Phainon says with a slight wince, wiping at his lip. “I was thirsty, thanks for offering. Make sure to add milk next time. Preferably lots of it.”

Mydei stares at him like he’s grown an extra head or three. Oh how he wishes he had another because maybe one of them would be a voice of reason.

Their fingers brush when Mydei hesitantly takes back his chalice, eyebrows furrowed as he regards Phainon with silent concern. That singular, momentary touch brings shockwaves down his spine, and he’s flooded with the desperate desire to slot their hands together, hold on and never let go.

Tartness covers his tongue and coats his throat in its unrelenting embrace. The itch beneath his skin returns full force, ripping the breath from his lungs. Hot flame burns and burns, his nerves lit ablaze. Desperation grows, and Phainon scrambles to gasp out, “I need water.” His eyes flick over to the fish. “You think the pond water is clean enough to drink?”

The only response he receives is an exasperated grunt. The wisteria flowers cast a shadow over Mydei’s features as he turns his head to the side, away from Phainon’s view.

A short burst of laughter clears through the haze. A brief moment of clarity.

Phainon whines, “Don’t laugh. It’s not funny. It’s not…” He watches as Mydei covers his face in his hands, a slight tremor overtaking his figure.

“I didn’t know you had such a vendetta,” Mydei manages to say, long eyelashes quivering. “Remind me to never bring pomegranate juice in your vicinity ever again.”

Phainon perks up. “Is that a promise? Do you swear on the River of Souls?” He pulls himself off his chair and jumps in front of Mydei, looming over the other alpha.

“Is it that serious, Deliverer? You had no problem before.” When Mydei receives sparkling blue eyes and an overly enthusiastic nod as answer, he sighs and relents, “I swear on the River of Souls, I will not drink pomegranate juice in your presence lest you decide to continue acting like a spoiled, bratty princess.”

There’s a fondness in Mydei’s expression, a shine in his sharp eyes and a soft curve to his lips, that drags the breath out of Phainon’s lungs.

Distracted, Phainon responds, “Good, good…” Only to pause when his brain finally processes Mydei’s words. Indignant, he squawks, “I—What? Seriously? You did not just call me that.”

Mydei stands so they’re nearly pressed chest to chest. He tilts his head, eyes narrowing in amusement as he murmurs, “*Princess.* ”

Close. They’re so close. He can feel the heat radiating off Mydei’s body. Phainon’s head spins, the taste and smell of pomegranate long forgotten. Before he even realizes, he blurts out, “If I’m the princess, then are you my prince?”

Mydei’s confident expression stalls.

Flustered, Phainon cracks a shaky grin. He even tries to laugh, only it comes out like he’s attempting not to choke and failing miserably.

Oh titans. He did not just say *that* . Couldn’t he have thought up a better comeback?! Only he didn’t think. Not at all. Not with how close Mydei is, sharing the same air, their body heats mixing.

This close, he can see all of Mydei’s individual lashes, the soft curve of his cheek, and the red flame marking beneath his right eye. The purple bruise on his neck. He’s tempted to take a step back, almost does, but his instinct screams to stay put in place. To step back is to give in.

Though this isn't the first time nor the last, he still acts dangerously off-balance.

Blue eyes flick down to Mydei’s parted lips then back up only to fly back down once more. Oh how badly he wants to kiss Mydei right now. He could. It’d be as easy as leaning in and taking what’s rightfully his. Mydei might fight him, and their relationship might be ruined before it even begins, but the desire clouds his mind. He wonders if Mydei’s lips are as soft as they look.

It’s tempting to fall, to plunge past the point of no return, to claim Mydei’s lips with his... He reaches out and cradles Mydei’s cheek, stroking downwards before settling on his chin.

Mydei freezes. His golden eyes grow wider with each passing moment, pupils constricting as he stares blankly at Phainon, unable to move an inch. There’s little resistance when Phainon gently tilts his chin up.

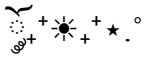
Slowly, Phainon trails his fingers over Mydei's parted lips, tenderly tracing the curve with the pad of his thumb. Soft and warm beneath his touch and stained lightly red. Desire burns, and he leans closer.

"You have some juice here," Phainon mutters as he thumbs at the middle. He's lying. It's a stupid excuse if Mydei were to call him out on it. There's nothing there. He hopes the tremor in his voice doesn't betray him.

Golden eyes flick down to Phainon's lips. Phainon continues to close the distance until they're almost forehead to forehead, white and blonde strands dancing as they brush against each other.

Mydei isn't pushing him away, and not a single word leaves him. It'd be so easy for Phainon to close the final distance. Only he doesn't. He can't. Not now.

He pulls himself away, shattering their shared space. His arm falls slack at his sides, mourning the loss of warmth. "It's gone now," he says. "Be more careful next time, my dear prince."



In the dimness of his bedroom, Phainon tosses and turns. All the curtains have been drawn in preparation for the night yet he can't get even a wink of sleep. For the past few hours, he's tried every fathomable way to fall asleep including counting chimeras, clearing his mind of all thought—easier said than done, and even playing some boring lecture videos that he saved all those years ago. His time at the Grove may be over, but he knew those videos could come in handy eventually.

Regardless of the stillness in his room, his mind is loud. His heart has thumped erratically for titans know how long. He doesn't have to grab his teleslate to know it's nearing the third quint of curtain-fall hour.

Without Mydei around—they parted ways hours ago—his every waking thought is consumed by *her* . That faceless omega and her stupidly addicting scent. The more he tries not to think about it, the worse it gets. Even his dreams aren't safe, haunted by the ghost of someone he doesn't know, has never met or seen or spoken to.

There's something twisted with how he's feeling, and he knows the only way to kick away these horrible feelings is to find out who she is. If he sees her, his attraction will abate, he knows it will. All he has to do is speak with her once and realize she's not Mydei. Simple. Easy.

He only has eyes for Mydei. From the moment he laid eyes on the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos all those years ago, he's known. It took a lot of time to work through his feelings, a

boatload of denial even as he oogled the other alpha to the concern of literally everyone around him. He's sure half of Okhema is aware of his crush, most of the heirs too.

Mydei said there was no one, but all of Okhema did not hallucinate that scent. *He* did not hallucinate that scent.

Even with Aglaea and Tribbie confirming that the rumors are false, that scent was very much real, tangible. He could taste it on his tongue as it burned his nose.

She exists out there. Mydei knows who she is but will not tell. He wonders what she did to upset him or if it was only a fling, nothing serious. His heart squeezes uncomfortably.

Never did he think he would find himself victim to his own instincts. Some scents land better than others. Omega scents tend towards saccharine sweet, not his favorite, yet…

Phainon groans and turns to his side. He throws off his covers and flips over his pillow.

Compatibility has never been a worry for him. His pheromones are softer than the traditional alpha, sweet like a floral spring breeze with fragrant petals afloat. Bright citrusy notes with lavender and vanilla. Apparently, he smells like the sun, though he's not really sure what that means because a ball of light has no smell. The tattoo on his neck seems to agree, and he reaches out to absentmindedly rub at it.

If he were to desire an alpha, his pheromones wouldn't clash, wouldn't cause the other alpha to turn aggressive. Omegas desire dominant scents and his, regardless of its floral character, is dominant in its own right. There's little wonder why Aglaea repeatedly tells him to control his pheromones.

When he's in rut, that's a whole other story that he doesn't wish to get into. Outside of not wanting anyone else but Mydei, there's a reason why he's never taken a rut partner.

Even with the air conditioning turned on to the highest setting, his room stays blistering hot. Wildly, he grabs at the mug on his nightstand and downs the water in one go. It parches the dryness in his throat, but does nothing to stop the incessant, burning itch.

His attraction to Mydei can't stop his desire for her. He hates it. This shouldn't be the case at all, and ignoring isn't an option anymore. He will find her and under no circumstances will Mydei find out. As long as he can see the omega, speak with her, then all of this will resolve.

It has to.

Mydei lounges on his living room couch, an arm covering his eyes. Beside him is a chalice of pomegranate juice, untouched, filled to the brim, and taunting him to take a sip. He had poured himself another glass only to push it to the side with a sigh. The thought of drinking it makes his throat close, his mind wandering to Phainon's disgruntled expression and obvious disgust. He almost wants to dump it in the sink.

It's irrational to feel this way, but he'll get over it. It might take a day or two, but he should be fine afterwards.

He can't sleep. Not at all. Not with the incessant buzzing in his head and the heaviness in his limbs. Absent-mindedly, he runs his tongue over his bottom lip in an attempt to stop the constant tingling, Phainon's lingering gift.

Given how many years he's known the other, he should be used to his antics, wild and unrestrained as they are. But Phainon's behavior today had been overly erratic in a manner that was outside his normal, variable as it was.

One moment, Phainon seemed fine. The day started fine. Their spar went great and ended well, but that was when Mydei noticed the beginning of the shift, but ignored it. They went about their business strolling through the city, content to be in each other's company.

Only his scent began to waver, flipping back and forth. Unstable then stable then unstable once more. A sweet spring meadow lit ablaze into the burning char of desiccated wheat only to fizzle out and stabilize to relative calm only to return once more to a blaze of destruction.

Mydei couldn't relax. He couldn't even enjoy his juice without being hyper aware of the way Phainon's scent continued to switch and shift, even as the other tried to act normal and unbothered.

It might be a curse. Before, he had been confident in his ability to read the other, but now he's slammed in the face by the obvious. He doesn't like it when Phainon is upset, because obviously, he cares for the other, but now…

He thought Phainon liked pomegranates. Never had the other given any hint or indication that he disliked the fruit. They've shared plenty of pomegranate honey cakes in the past, and he's even seen Phainon ordering pomegranate smoothies at the local juicery many times.

It almost felt personal. Did a pomegranate fall off a tree and hit him upside the head or something? Is that why he's holding a grudge?

And when faced with Phainon's piercing blue eyes, he froze, his body ignoring his commands. All he could do was watch as Phainon leaned closer, as the scent of spring overwhelmed and clouded his senses.

It almost seemed like… Phainon wanted to kiss him?

No, that can't be it. He's seeing things that don't exist.

These instincts won't leave, rearing their ugly heads at the worst times possible. Where he was once able to challenge Phainon with no issue, there's now a twisting in his chest and loud whisperings begging him to submit. He feels like he can't breathe.

Each time Phainon closes in, touches him, the desire to bare his neck and offer himself on a silver platter burns hot. He's walking a fine line, and he's a fool to think he wouldn't fall.

Fortunately, he's held in his reactions well enough. At the very least, Phainon hasn't noticed the change, hasn't called him out for any changes in behavior.

Mydei sighs, frustrated.

This is idiotic. He shouldn't be wasting his time like this.

Maybe it's time to visit Hyacine once more. He grabs his teleslate and quickly texts her asking if she's available for an impromptu visit. Might as well make use of his restlessness to get a prescription refill, and besides, he could use some fresh air.

Chapter End Notes

hehe this chap was fun to write. phainon pov is always my favorite bc he's the king of crash outs. next chapter will return to mostly mydei pov.

thank you for reading!! 💕

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> Back with another chapter! 3.4 cooked me so bad lmaooo. That piano music haunts me and ughh I keep thinking about cycle 0 Mydei and Phainon. They're so doomed orz. I literally couldn't sleep after reading 3.4
>
> Also went to AX last weekend so this chapter ended up coming out later than I wanted :'D had a great time tho, rip my wallet
>
> That Phainon animated trailer has me going crazy. I screamed when he exploded out of his shirt adksksk. He's literally so alpha
>
> cw. masturbation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As usual, Hyacine greets him with twinkling turquoise eyes and a wide smile, cotton candy pigtails swaying as she bounces over to say her hellos. Only this time, she pauses in her step, her normally jovial expression wiped off her sweet features. She stands frozen, the cogs in her brain seemingly halted.

Mydei stares at her in wait.

"Uh..." Hyacine says, dumbfounded. Her gaze slowly trails down to the bruise on his neck.

The need to explain grows with each passing moment. "Phainon scented me recently. He also bit me by accident."

Hyacine blinks. Little Ica squeaks softly in concern.

"Ah!" she exclaims, a little too loudly. Her lips curve into yet another wide smile, though this time, it shakes at the corners. "Yes, okay, well. That's great! Are you two together?"

"Together?" Mydei frowns. "We do spend a lot of time with one another."

He's not daft. He knows what she means to say, but he's not about to open that line of thought.

"Never mind," Hyacine laughs with a wave of her hands. "Let me grab your prescription. Stay right here." She bounces off to scour her cabinets.

Mydei watches as she rummages through all sorts of medications, concentration on her features as she hones in on the familiar blue and white bottles. Inevitably, his mind wanders

off, following the path it knows best—Phainon. Seems like he's all Mydei thinks about nowadays. It shouldn't be the case but it is.

Luckily, Hyacine is quick, grabbing the medications and bouncing in front of him to hand them over. "Here you go! These are another month's supply."

"Thank you."

"My pleasure!" she smiles, peppy as always. Little Ica squeaks excitedly beside her, flying around in a flurry of rainbow sparkles. Mydei reaches out to pet the little plump unicorn, smiling as it squeaks again and nuzzles against his hand.

"Hyacine, are there any medications to stop…" he trails off, unable to finish. Hyacine is his doctor and he trusts her, but admitting his unusual fixation towards Phainon is worse than pulling teeth. "Never mind."

Hyacine tilts her head.

"What do I smell like?" Mydei asks instead. It's been stuck on his mind for a while now. The rumors always repeated sweet and fertile, far too vague to make any sort of sense. Being told he smells fertile brings chills rolling down his spine.

"Huh?" Turquoise eyes widen.

"I don't think it's possible to scent myself," Mydei says with a small frown. "The rumors never specified, and asking is out of the question."

"Got it!" Hyacine nods. "I would say… " She strokes her chin, a pensive look on her delicate features. "A blend of ripe pomegranates and honey."

Her words register. *Pomegranate.*

Oh.

That… That explains everything. His heart squeezes, the breath punched out of his lungs. Phainon hates his natural scent. The dislike for the fruit didn't appear out of nowhere. He's the reason why.

"Keep in mind that's how you smell in pre-heat. Your scent intensifies, becomes sweeter in an attempt to attract a mate. I haven't had a chance to gauge your usual scent, but it'd probably still smell of pomegranate, only not nearly as strong."

"I smell like pomegranate," Mydei states back. His expression falls. "I see…"

"Is something the matter, Lord Mydei?" Hyacine asks. "Are you alright?"

"I'm fine," he says.

This is idiotic. He shouldn't care. It doesn't matter if Phainon doesn't like his scent. Everyone has their own preferences. It's not Phainon's fault he dislikes pomegranates.

Observant like always, Hyacine sees his discomfort, her eyebrows pinching. Mydei quickly stuffs his pill bottles into his pockets before he crushes them in his grip.

“Your scent is quite nice,” she reassures and reaches out to pat him gently on the shoulder.

He appreciates the gesture but it does nothing to abate the crawl of hurt brewing in his chest. Years of experience have allowed him to keep his expression level. “Thank you.”

Hyacine’s office is always lively, a far cry from the rundown tents he used to be patched up in. Cutesy rainbow decor covers the walls and her desk is filled with lots of small trinkets, plush dolls of pink cotton candy chimeras and crocheted flowers.

Even dealing with all the casualties and taking the brunt of responsibility as head physician of Okhema, she remains carefree, all brilliant smiles and twinkling eyes. He admires her resilience in the face of these trying times.

With a soft sigh, Hyacine scoots over to her desk and takes a seat. The next moments are silent in contemplation. Her hands clasp tightly together.

Finally, Hyacine says, “Lord Mydei.”

“Yes?”

She purses her lips. “My apologies if I’m assuming, but I have to say this as your physician. Please be careful about letting Lord Phainon scent you. It’s one thing to be around him and other alphas, but letting them scent you can mess with the efficacy of the medications. His scent on you is very strong, and it seems to me, he’s rubbed against your mating gland. For now, you’re stable with no signs of degradation, but I'm obligated to let you know the risks.”

Mydei braces himself for her next words. He knows what’s coming.

“Beneath the medications, you are still an omega.” Her expression softens. “I do not mean this in a derogatory way, Lord Mydei.”

You cannot hide from your instincts. The meaning is clear, even if she tries to let him down easy.

“I understand… I will be more careful.”



Mydei comes to the realization when he’s yet again traversing across the city to return home.

He passes through the fifth marble corridor of the night before he’s had enough. It’s nearing the fourth quint of curtain fall hour, and he wants nothing more than to go back to sleep and

try to scrounge as much rest as he can before the day begins. Luckily he doesn't have much planned so he can afford to relax a little and maybe work on some new chimera animations.

It pains him to admit, but realistically, if he's spending this much time zipping back and forth, he might as well move closer. That way he wouldn't have to deal with the treacherous walk and having to wake up in the middle of the night, scurrying around the city corridors and alleyways like some jumpy nocturnal creature, easily spooked by moving shadows and sudden noises.

There's no word in the Kremnoan language for "I'm tired of having to spend an hour walking across the city for a doctor's visit", but he's about to pen one and stick it in the dictionary.

He rounds the corner only to nearly crash into a warm body.

Who in their right mind is up during this hour? Though it's not their fault, he almost wants to snarl at them for breaking the peace and quiet.

"Woah, watch out!" said person cries out. "Eh? M-Mydei?"

The familiar scent of spring fills his nose, stronger than usual, bright citrus roasting beneath the sun.

Phainon stands in front of him, dressed lightly in a soft white chiton that both reveals and accentuates his toned chest muscles. Mydei recalls buying it for him after witnessing the atrocity that was his favored bright yellow shirt and deep purple pants. Phainon had pouted and attempted in earnest to defend himself and his eyesore of a getup only to quietly acquiesce when Aglaea passed by and lightly frowned at him.

The black leather choker remains tightly strapped around his throat, digging into his pale skin and covering the etching of the brilliant sun. Crossing his arms against his chest with a little too much force, Mydei tears his gaze away and asks, "Why are you awake at this hour?"

The last person he wishes to see right now is Phainon, but luck isn't on his side.

"I could say the same to you," Phainon laughs only to sober up immediately, his expression listless as he says, "Couldn't sleep… needed some fresh air."

"Hmph."

"You look good," Phainon says. A pink tongue peaks out to lick over dry lips.

"And you look terrible," Mydei lies.

"Thanks." Phainon rubs at his eyes. "Nice to know…"

"Go back home, Deliverer," Mydei says as he turns to leave. He doesn't have time for this, not when the weight of the pills in his pockets reminds him of his inadequacies.

But Phainon catches his wrist, urgency in his voice, as he says, "Can I sleep with you?"

Caught off guard, Mydei jerks back. “...What?”

Phainon waves his arms around wildly, as if trying to distract. With a stilted laugh, he tries again, “Sorry, tired—Ah, I meant… Can I go home with you?”

“I have pomegranates on my kitchen counter,” Mydei says flatly. “Wouldn’t want you to be uncomfortable. I know how much *I* disgust you.” He can’t stop the venom that leaches into his voice nor the slipup. Fuck. He only hopes Phainon doesn’t notice.

Phainon expression darkens, lashes casting deep shadows over his eyes. His voice lowers, “Look, I’m sorry about earlier today. I don’t know what came over me. I’m normally not like this…”

“Yes, you are,” Mydei retorts. “Let go of my wrist.”

“Okay, not this bad though,” Phainon says, releasing his hold. In an instant, his tired expression warms and he stares at Mydei with wide, glimmering blue eyes and his bottom lip jutted out, trembling ever so slightly. “Please?” He inches closer. “Mydei… Please?”

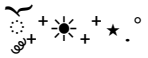
He doesn’t have time for this. Already, he’s threatened by a headache, a faint pulse in his temples. Kephale’s dawn is too bright for this deep in the day. He almost wishes for the evernight.

Tell Phainon no. Tell him to go back home and leave him alone. He has no desire to be near the alpha. Not right now. Not when he knows Phainon can’t stand who he really is, hidden beneath the layers of medication.

But one look at those sparkling eyes has his resolve wavering, the stone walls he’s built crumbling beneath the heat of the burning sun.

“Fine,” Mydei bites out. “Only for tonight.”

The grin that Phainon gives is blinding. Mydei feels nothing but regret.



This isn’t the first time they’ve shared a bed, far from it. They’ve been through their fair share of missions that resulted in sleeping in a small, cramped tent or even sharing a dingy inn room with only one bed that was for sure not meant for two grown men.

Phainon tosses and turns in his sleep. He also likes to starfish and cling onto the nearest object, whether it be a pillow, a pile of blankets, or a person, hoarding all warmth for himself.

Thankfully, Mydei's bed is large enough where the two of them wouldn't have to struggle for space. Split down the center, there's ample room with no need to encroach on the other.

He bids Phainon quiet good night only to receive a mumble as answer. Since arriving, Phainon has stayed quiet, staring blankly at random corners of Mydei's home when previously he was a chatterbox, trying to fill the uncomfortable silence on their walk back. The latest victim of his staring is Mydei's red bed sheets, and each breath he takes is ragged, unstable.

Weird, but okay. Mydei is far too tired to care. He can barely keep his eyes open, and even with Phainon practically thrashing beside him, he manages to dip into the space between consciousness and unconsciousness only to be crudely dragged out by a weight draped over his shoulders, a firm chest against his back.

Somehow, though not surprising, Phainon had broken into his side of the bed to cling onto him in his sleep, refusing to let go, clamping on tighter when Mydei tries to yank himself free. It's these moments where Mydei is reminded of how strong Phainon is, sculpted muscles of a trained, disciplined warrior hidden beneath thick layers of armor.

A stray thought floats through his head. He could punch Phainon in the face and force himself free, only… he would rather not deal with a pouty Phainon and the very idea of hurting the other has chills shooting down his spine. That's out of the question.

… For now.

Because Phainon is *hard.* Rock hard.

Mydei can't breathe, not with Phainon pressed firmly against his ass, his leg snaking in between his thighs. He grits his teeth. Caged in like this, surrounded by the scent of spring with their bodies slotted together like a puzzle, his body naturally begins to react. He's growing hard at an alarming rate, and the beginnings of wetness form between his thighs. Fuck. He bites his lip and screws his eyes shut, attempting to calm himself.

It's not like he hasn't felt Phainon before—they've had their fair share of accidental touches. It's only natural given their close relationship and how often they bathe together. He's seen Phainon naked far too often, almost too many times to count by this point. The alpha has a nasty habit of dragging him to the baths whenever possible, even forcing him out of a peaceful nap to accompany him.

It's only a normal bodily response , Mydei repeats in his head. He's overthinking it. Only Phainon keeps nuzzling closer, nose brushing softly against his feverish nape. The movement feels hesitant, but deliberate rather than sloppy and accidental.

"Deliverer," Mydei bites out. "I know you're not asleep."

"Mmm…" Phainon mumbles, eyebrows furrowed. His hands come to rest on Mydei's chest, giving a gentle squeeze. "Trying…"

" *Haikas* … Let go of me. I'm not your pillow."

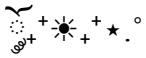
“Don’t wanna…”

“Your dick is pressing against my ass,” Mydei hisses.

“Ah… sorry. My bad…” Phainon mutters, but makes no effort to move or let go.

Another twenty minutes of suffocating silence. Mydei sincerely debates the pros and cons of punching him. He’s about to when Phainon finally pulls away, lips twisted into a frown as he wildly grabs at his clothing, roughly pulling off the chiton and tossing it half-way across the room. The blistering heat of their once intertwined bodies retreats, and for reasons he rather not think about, Mydei finds himself mourning the loss.

“Hot… Why is it so damn hot?” Phainon grumbles, frustration leaking into every word. His scent intensifies, the sun casting its rays, deepening the soft scent of spring into smoky notes. Not charred, not burning ash. *Different.*



Allowing Phainon to spend the night was a mistake. An oversight on Mydei’s part, brought about by his inability to tell Phainon no.

Not only did he get the worst sleep of his life, Phainon’s scent also lingers on the bed sheets, seeping deep into his furniture and saturating every crevice. His entire home is covered in Phainon, and Hyacine’s words come rushing back into his head. He only hopes the medications continue to hold, especially since Phainon had rubbed against him in his sleep.

Morning had the alpha scrambling to say his goodbyes. Mydei originally planned for them to eat a nice home cooked breakfast together and maybe take a brief morning stroll, but it seemed Phainon had other ideas.

“Thanks for letting me stay the night,” Phainon had grinned, his face flushed oddly red. “See you later, Mydei!” Then he flung open the front door and fled as if he had seen a ghost.

Okay, whatever.

A few hours later, Mydei receives a text from Phainon stating that his rut has started early and that he won’t be available for their usual spar.

Early? That doesn’t sound good. He can’t recall Phainon ever having an early rut, especially one strong enough to take him out of commission. A part of him is tempted to visit to see if Phainon is okay, maybe bring over some snacks and water. He brings it up with Hyacine only for her to stare at him like he had grown two extra heads.

“No!” Hyacine had yelled, waving her arms around. “That’s even more risky than him scenting you!”

Given the changes in circumstances, he should have expected such an answer. He’s seen other alphas in rut before, witnessed the destruction they could cause on the battlefield. Alphas in rut make the most daring and violent soldiers, and Kremnoan alphas have no trouble touting their secondary gender. All things considered, Phainon is pretty subdued, as are the rest of Okheman alphas.

Outside of having to break up a couple of fights, ruts never registered as an issue. At the time, he didn’t understand the sudden spike in aggression, soldiers who were normally on friendly terms attempting to rip out each other's throats. Now, much to his dismay, he can smell everything.

In his haste to leave, Phainon had forgotten to retrieve his discarded clothing. He practically ran out of Mydei’s home naked, decked in only a pair of thin grey trousers with the rest of his body out on display. The heap of moonlight fabric lays in the corner of his bedroom, beckoning him over.

This is wrong. So very wrong. He doesn’t know what’s come over him.

Mydei picks up the cloth. Trembling, he slowly brings it to his nose and inhales.

A deep rumble leaves his throat. It’s automatic, uncontrollable. Warmth builds in his chest, and his lips curve up on their own.

It’s only later he realizes he had been *purring*.



Kremnoans enjoy their privacy. They carved out their own subsection in Okhema, near the far end of the city, much to the dismay of many and the backlash from the Council of Elders. Assimilation had been the idea, the swallowing of the small to fit with the larger whole. Many rescues from nearby city-states and villages have meshed with the Okheman population, but millennia of strife and constant battle have left Okhema and Castrum Kremnos at odds.

Tensions have lessened substantially compared to the early years, smoothed out by Aglaea and his joint efforts, but the living situation hasn’t changed.

It's for the best if he moves to the shared Chrysos Heir villa. He can’t continue sneaking out to visit Hyacine nor can he deal with the whisperings of the cityfolk and the incessant prodding of his countrymen. A few of the older, more traditional alphas keep asking him

where the omega has gone then some mutterings about how sweet her scent was and how she would have birthed strong, healthy pups.

The omega wouldn't have been fit to be queen, but she could have been consort. Since the founding of Castrum Kremnos all those millennia ago, Kremnoan kings and queens have been alphas. Omegas are not fit to rule.

A lump builds in his throat. He ignores it.

Either way, he's made up his mind, gathered his belongings, a few pairs of clothing, some toiletries and other necessities, namely his pills. Already, he's sent Krateros notice that he's moving with no response as of yet.

Phainon's scent had been the final straw. Mydei stares at the crumpled clothing laying haphazardly on his bed and quickly stuffs it into his bag, ignoring the urge to take another whiff. He'll wash it and give it back to Phainon the next time he sees him, pushing down the shame that prickles his skin at the memory of what he had done prior.

The villa is grand, covering a large expanse of land on a hillside behind Marmoreal Palace. He's been here a few times before whenever Aglaea wished for the heirs to gather, but never more than that. She still hasn't told him when Cipher will be returning, but he's sure it'll be sooner rather than later.

Enchanted with a barrier that only allows heirs inside, he slips into the yard and up the polished marble steps, his boots clacking with each step. Okheman design at its finest with white marbled pillars and curved floral engravings carved in blue. Where Kremnoans preferred sharp and pointed, Okhemans enjoyed softer and rounded. Intimidating versus elegant. Deep crimson red versus steady ocean blue.

Mydei finds his way to the back entrance, and chooses the room at the very tail end of the villa, vacated, never before used, but fully furnished. A few of the other heirs have claimed theirs, scattered throughout the main hallway, tossed in a few belongings and even decorated. The furnishings within the untouched room reflect the overall design of the villa, white and blue with the crest of Okhema strung on the wall. It's also gigantic, fit for a king with its own private bathroom, and the furnishings are clean and crisp, not a single speck of dust in sight.

Once he drops his belongings, he wanders the hallways, making himself a mental map. It's late in night, his footsteps soft against the marble flooring. Castorice, whom he's heard lives as a permanent tenant, must be asleep, and he doesn't wish to wake up.

He passes the communal kitchen only to pause when he finds Castorice sitting at the table. In front of her is a crocheting hook and bundles of yarn in all various colors of the rainbow. She taps her feet in rhythm, humming to herself, as she waits for the kettle to boil.

They briefly lock eyes, and she nearly jumps out of her seat.

"Lord Mydei," Castorice greets, her eyes wide, blinking owlishly as if she can't believe he's actually in front of her. She pulls herself off her chair and bows, delicate hands clasped together in a show of respect.

“Castorice,” Mydei greets back. “My apologies if I alarmed you.”

She shakes her head. “No, no, that’s not it… I hadn’t expected anyone else.”

“I’ll be residing here from now on,” Mydei tells her.

Her lips form a silent o. Though he doesn’t know her too well, he’s aware of how she wears her heart on her sleeve, subdued as it is. She isn’t the greatest at hiding her emotions.

Polite in her usual reserved fashion, she asks, “I’m preparing some herbal mountain tea. Would you like a cup?”

“That would be great, thank you.”

She tries a smile only for it to fade as quickly as it begins. Her eyebrows furrow, the grooves on her delicate face growing deeper, as she stares at him. Pink cheeks continue to flush increasingly red as the moments pass, and her purple eyes are honed in on his neck, the dark bruise left by a specific someone.

The urge to slap a hand over his neck is overwhelming. Somehow, he’s forgotten about it. Again. Strange how it hasn’t disappeared yet. “May I take a seat?” he asks.

“Oh, yes, yes!” she says as she scoots over and scurries to move the items scattered across the table only to end up knocking some onto the floor.

Helping her pick up the dropped yarn, he asks, “Am I bothering you?”

An instant shake of her head, purple bangs swishing from side to side. “Ah… no. It’s… not that…” Her face burns redder, now even rivaling the crimson markings adorning his body. Frazzled, she squeaks out, “Nothing. It’s nothing.... How have you been, Lord Mydei?”

“I’ve been fine,” Mydei says evenly. “And you?”

“Great,” Castorice says as her eyes flit around. The flush on her cheeks only continues to grow until she’s practically steaming at the ears. She struggles to respond, voice coming out uncertain, shaky. “It’s been, uhm, nice lately…”

Normally, she’s not this flustered. In all his years at Okhema, he doesn’t think he’s ever seen her like this.

Silence blankets the kitchen. There’s only the whistling of the kettle. Castorice stares down at her hands as she waits for the water to boil. In the meantime, she busies herself by pulling out two glass mugs from the cupboard, her back turned.

He can’t deal with this. The discomfort is palpable, and the last he wants is for her to feel uncomfortable in her own home. He can change tactics. It’s no big deal. Living in the Chrysos Heir villa is by far the easiest option, readily available, but he doesn’t wish to intrude on Castorice’s peace and quiet.

Mydei watches as she slowly prepares the tea and sits back down, a shake to every step. His expression grows grave. Apologetic and a little self-conscious, he says, “If my presence makes you uncomfortable, I can leave. It’s no problem.”

“No!” Castorice exclaims, slamming her hands hard onto the wooden table, sending over loud reverberations and startling Mydei with her loud tenacity. “It’s just… Ah, excuse me, but… Uhm... Why—Why do you smell like Lord Phainon?”

Oh.

“I let him scent me,” Mydei explains as he grabs his mug and blows at the steam. He’s not about to bring up that Phainon had clung to him all night, rubbed against his neck, and refused to let go. It’ll be the last time he allows for such action.

“Ah,” Castorice says, her brows furrowing as she stares into her cup of tea as if it’s the most fascinating object in existence. Her eyes glaze the surface, her grip tightening on the handle, fingers turning pale from how hard she’s holding on. “I see…” She takes a slow, hesitant sip, spending far too long with the steaming cup in her face, almost as if she’s trying to hide away from view.

He doesn’t understand her reaction. Concerned, Mydei asks, “Isn’t that what companions do? Scent each other?”

Castorice spits out her tea. A good portion splashes straight onto Mydei’s face while the rest lands on the table and the marble flooring below. Luckily, it’s not unbearably hot, but the lemon stings his eyes and drenches his bangs.

He stares back at her, frozen in shock. First with Phainon, now with Castorice. It seems he can’t catch a break.

The panic is instant and apparent. “Sorry! Sorry… Oh, no—” Castorice scrambles to her feet only to immediately slip, a stumble in her step as she wildly tries to grab at the air, her purple pigtails swaying wildly behind her.

Without thinking, Mydei reaches out and places steadying hands on her thin shoulders. The contact brings a sudden rush of dizziness, a sleepiness that pulls at him, unraveling and threatening to submerge. For a moment, he’s once again standing in the river of souls, ready to fulfill the journey he’s undergone thousands of times, yet a singular blink and the soothing scent of wildflower nectar brings him back to the kitchen.

“Lord Mydei?” Castorice gasps, staring up at him with pure terror in her eyes. With far more strength than he expects, she yanks herself out of his grip and jumps four steps away, keeping careful, calculated distance.

His head gradually clears as the aura retreats. Shaking away the grogginess, Mydei takes a deep breath and tells her, “I’m okay. No harm done.”

“I didn’t kill you this time,” she whispers, voice barely above a whisper. “Last time, I did…”

He remembers that. An arm wrestling match whereby Castorice reigned champion because he had been transported to the River of Souls for a few moments.

“I didn’t die,” he reaffirms, unable to formulate a suitable response.

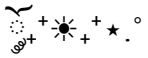
Hesitantly, she takes three steps closer. Already, Mydei can feel the slow lull of death, reaching out, pulling at his skin, his hair, whispering sweet nothings into his ear, but once again, her scent cuts through the haze, gentle and comforting.

Even with the haunting aura of decay, her scent grounds him. It’s a strange contradiction. Omegas can calm other omegas, he recalls.

Slowly, hesitation cloaks her every movement as she reaches out towards him. Their palms touch. The waves of death are weaker now.

“You can touch me,” she says in awe.

He wants to tell her why, but the words don’t leave his throat. All he can do is nod, watching as her expression lights up with the purest of joy.



He eats breakfast with Castorice every morning thereafter. A little custom they’ve established since they’re both early risers. It’s nice to have company early in the day.

They take turns cooking breakfast and sometimes dinner if they're both home. Castorice has a whole list of recipes she’s been wishing to try out, while Mydei enjoys experimenting with technique and temperature. It’s soothing to dice up ingredients and listen to the sizzle as they hit the fire.

Today is Castorice’s turn, and she made olive oil cakes glazed with caramelized sugar. Together, they munch on the sweet cakes, light and fluffy, and sip freshly squeezed pomegranate juice. Unfortunately, every time he takes a drink of the tart, crimson liquid, he has to quiet his mind to the incessant whisperings that remind him of what he can't control. He only hopes it goes away soon.

Caught up in the whirlwind of recent events, he hasn’t had the time to cook until now. The change of surroundings is nice and he can enjoy the bountiful villa courtyard without the watchful gaze of his countrymen.

With Phainon out of commission, he doesn’t have much to do. He supposes he could go outside and train with his fellow soldiers, but he prefers to lounge around with Castorice. She sits beside him on the living room couch, scrolling through her teleslate, showing him cute

videos ever so often, while he works on his latest animation project. She's less closed off as compared to when he first moved in, and he's glad for it.

"Does Lord Phainon know you're living here?" Castorice asks as she pops a grape into her mouth.

Mydei shakes his head. "No. I haven't told him."

"He hasn't been around lately. Is he alright?"

With a small frown, Mydei answers, "He's in rut."

"Oh." Castorice grabs another grape, twirling it around in her fingers. "I see."

Thinking about Phainon in rut makes him feel strange. He rather not.

"May I ask for your opinion?" He pushes his laptop in her direction, showing her a brief clip of a white chimera chirping and chasing after an exasperated orange chimera.

"Of course," she says, only to pause, purple eyes blowing wide. "You're Fig Stew?!" she gasps.

Mydei nods.

"Your videos are so cute! I love them," Castorice beams. "I thought the two chimeras looked familiar…" She places a finger to her lip in thought. "Are they you and Lord Phainon?"

"Yes."

"Why does Lord Phainon have horns?"

"Because he's a devious fiend," Mydei answers. "Do not fall for his innocent persona."

Castorice giggles. "Lord Phainon is energetic but harmless. Fig Stew looks so terrified. Oh my…"

Revitalized, Castorice scurries to her room and brings out her purple notebook to show him her stories. She blushes heavily as she watches him read over her works, but he has nothing but praise for her creativity even if the content is a little wild. All things considered, it's not that inappropriate considering he's probably done worse with Phainon. Sleeping together in the same bed and feeling Phainon's arousal against his ass has to count for something.

"You're not upset?" Castorice asks, shocked.

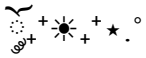
Mydei shakes his head as he gently places her notebook on the table. "No, why would I be?"

"I showed Lord Phainon, and he started laughing uncontrollably."

"Do you want me to hit him? I can punch his head in for you," Mydei offers.

Castorice quickly shakes her head. “No, no. Nothing of that sort. He meant it harmlessly. I believe I caught him off guard.”

“He has no tact sometimes,” Mydei sighs. “I almost wish to apologize for him.”



Phainon groans.

Fingernails dig into bed sheets as he braces himself for yet another round. He bites down on his already bruised lip, sharp fangs digging into soft flesh, drawing crimson blood. An attempt to stop himself from screaming in frustration. It works. Barely. The scream comes out as a pained hiss.

His free hand works his cock. The touch burns, and he screws his eyes shut as he slumps onto his bed, knees trembling from exertion.

“Fuck,” Phainon growls, voice hoarse. “Damn it.”

This is by far the *worst* rut he’s ever experienced in his entire life.

He can’t even leave the confines of his room, unable to scrounge the littlest bit of energy to eat. He’s sure if he were to try to brave the outside, he’d probably attack someone on sight.

Sweaty bangs stick uncomfortably to his forehead. His entire body aches, the blaze of wildfire burning through his nerves. It consumes all in his wake, insatiable, destructive. He’s lost count of how many times has climaxed, yet it’s not enough. Never enough. His knot pops in and out. With no omega here, he can’t form one to completion, stuck in this constant, unceasing cycle.

Normally, it would never be an issue but this time… It's different.

By Kephale, he desperately needs someone to knock him out until the hormones that drive this madness fizzle out. The hours blend together. He flows in and out of the tides of consciousness. Never quite asleep, never quite awake. His vision, no longer clear, sways, his head plugged, thoughts a jumble. The muted colors of his room mix together, his curtains drawn tight with the lamps turned off.

Within the darkness, his sun tattoo glows bright as does the gold marking that drops below his clavicle. In a drunken haze, he had ripped off his leather choker and tossed it haphazardly onto the floor. Strapped on like second skin, it suffocated him, as if someone had wrapped their hands around his neck and began to squeeze.

Sweat drips down his temple as he thrusts into his closed fists. Gasps and grunts spill from his lips as he chases release. It builds and builds, his movements growing more and more erratic. Frenzied and forceful, the fire consumes.

His head spins. Images of Mydei flow through his mind.

Mydei with his face flushed lovely pink, plush lips wrapped taut around his cock as he struggles to swallow. Mydei naked with legs spread and neck bared, begging to be claimed, marked for all to see. Mydei pressing his ass against Phainon's cock as he gives Phainon that *look* , asking to be fucked and filled until he's a babbling mess of come.

"Mydei," Phainon chants. "Mydei, Mydei, Mydei…"

Oh, yeah. He'd fuck Mydei all night, drive him deep into the mattress until he's screaming and sobbing, tear his fangs into that unmarked neck until he draws rivulets of golden blood, knot the other alpha until—

His teleslate pings. Frustrated, he grabs it only to see a message from the object of his desires.

Mydei's text reads: "I haven't heard from you in days. Are you okay, Deliverer?"

A laugh rips from his throat. Maybe he'd be fine if Mydei were here, bouncing and making a mess of himself on cock. He tosses his teleslate to the side and continues fucking into his hand, this time with rougher, chasing the high that had been so rudely interrupted.

He wants so badly to ask Mydei to come over, but that's not how any of this works.

Mistakes were made, a lapse in judgement. He had begged to go home with Mydei and sleep in his bed only to be drowned in that accursed scent that covered those neat bed sheets and blankets.

He tried to ignore it. Tried to go to sleep only his body had reacted on its own. Each shift of Mydei's body on their shared space had brought shockwaves, electricity coursing through his body.

With Mydei right beside him, he couldn't help but close the distance. Like a viper waiting to strike, his rut had hit him without even a moment to prepare. His cock burned beneath the tight confines of his pants, begging to be released. With every fiber of his being, he had to hold himself back from grinding against Mydei's ass like a mindless beast. The heat had rushed through his body and clinging onto Mydei had proven to be overbearingly hot, scalding with each touch.

His fangs ache, and his eyes sting. Each breath he inhales comes out ragged and broken. The scent of sweet pomegranate, of omega in heat, meshes with the images of Mydei.

"Alpha," Mydei purrs, voice low and sultry. Long eyelashes flutter as sweet slick drips out and makes a mess of his bare thighs.

Phainon watches with bated breath as Mydei falls to his knees and presents himself for Phainon's taking. Fingers reach behind to rub in slow circles, drenching them in glistening slick. His pink hole contracts as he dips in and out, sweet moans leaving his lips, golden eyes half-lidded. "Fuck me, alpha… Make me yours…"

Pomegranate fills the air, wrapping him in its sweet embrace. Mydei smells so good, so sweet and fertile, begging to be bred. All his for the taking.

Without a second thought, Phainon lines himself up and plunges into the wet warmth, delighting in the arch of Mydei's back as slim fingers scramble to grasp the bedsheets. With cheeks flushed lovely pink and hazy golden eyes rimmed red, Mydei resembles a bullied maiden.

Phainon is unbelievably turned on. Only he can have Mydei looking like this.

"Deeper," Mydei gasps, impatiently pushing his round ass against Phainon's cock, grinding down as he moans, "I want you all the way…"

The heat is blistering. Mydei feels so good wrapped around him.

"You take me so well," Phainon groans. "Look at you—"

His teleslate rings.

Like fragile glass, the fantasy shatters. He's thrown back to the dark of his bedroom, alone with only his hand as company. His overstimulated cock, still rock hard, continues to leak pearls of precum, and the images of his desire materialize only to fade from each shrill ring. Shakily, he grabs his teleslate only to see Mydei in capital letters bright on the screen.

Don't answer. Don't.

He answers.

"Deliverer," Mydei's deep voice rumbles. Phainon's cock jerks. He has to clamp down on his lip to stop an embarrassing keen from escaping.

"M-Mydei…" Phainon coughs. "How's it going?"

"You read my text but didn't reply," Mydei says. "Your voice sounds scratchy. Have you been drinking enough water?"

Close. He's so close. His hand clamps down on his cock as he rocks slowly back and forth.

"Mm… I'm fine. Tired, just woke up." A shaky breath. "Y-You lonely? Is that why you're calling me?" He tries to tease but it comes out weak, short of breath.

"I wanted to check up on you."

He sounds so genuine. Phainon nearly chokes. His treacherous cock twitches. Fuck.

“W-What... What are you up to right now?” Phainon asks, licking his dry lips.

“Out shopping for groceries. Castorice says her hellos. Did you want anything? I can bring it over.”

Castorice. Though irrational, something unpleasant curls inside him.

“Fine. I’m fine... N-Need to go,” Phainon bites out.

“Wait—“

“Bye.”

Frantically, he ends the call only to slump back onto his mattress. He screws his eyes shut and shakily strokes himself until completion, the side of his cheek pressed into the bed. An orgasm rips out of him, painfully unsatisfying, and his chest heaves for breath. His cock hurts, overstimulated from hours of nonstop use, yet it rises once more with not a moment of reprieve.

Phainon slams his fists down and yells.

Chapter End Notes

phaichan pls stop being so embarrassing :(

thanks for reading! 💕

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Before Mydei can even finish his sentence, Phainon ends the call. He's left staring blankly at his home screen, fingers twitching over Phainon's number. With a small sigh, he pockets the device and steps beneath the shade of the canopy.

"Is something the matter, Lord Mydei?" Castorice asks. She picks up a ripe peach and carefully inspects it for any imperfections. Satisfied, she drops it into her basket before moving to pick out a few more, a hop to her step.

The day flourishes. Cityfolk crowd around prayer fountains, offering their wishes to their titans of choice. The smell of savory spiced meats and freshly baked bread wafts through the open air, vendors shouting their wares and offering samples to passersby.

They've taken to Demetria's bustling stall, shopping around for fresh, hand-picked fruit. There's a two for one deal on peaches, catching Castorice's attention. Yesterday, Mydei had whipped up a large batch of lemon custard ice cream due to an abundance of ripe lemons falling from the trees in the front yard, and Castorice had the brilliant idea of baking some puffed peach tarts to pair with it.

"He hung up on me," Mydei says as he hands Castorice a perfectly round peach. Worry bleeds in his voice. "He's never done that before."

A soft but reassuring smile sweetens her features as she plucks the peach out of his hand. "Lord Phainon is not in the best state right now. Don't take it to heart."

He knows that, but he can't help the unease that makes its home in his chest. Ruts are normal, human, but Phainon didn't sound okay at all. His voice had been hoarse, words shaky, wavering with each syllable. Even in the worst of sickness, he's never sounded like that. It's as if Phainon had swallowed a mouthful of gravel, a weak croak instead of his usual bright timbre.

From the years gone by, Mydei is well aware of how Phainon acts, how he has an infuriating penchant for overworking himself until he's barely able to function. Even with eyes glassy and unfocused, gait unsteady and on the verge of collapse, Phainon continues onwards with little complaint. There's been many times where Mydei had to put his foot down and intervene.

His teleslate weighs down his pockets. He wants to call Phainon again. Knowing that the alpha isn't doing alright has him on edge, the hairs the back of his neck standing up. He wants to provide for Phainon, make sure that's well-taken care of, and—

It's these idiotic instincts talking again. Or rather, he's always felt this way, only now, it's amped up tenfold. Regardless, he wants to see Phainon sooner rather than later.

“Should I visit him?” Mydei asks Castorice. “He doesn’t sound okay. I know him. He’s probably not taking care of himself the way that he should.”

The peach in Castorice’s hand bruises beneath her grip, dripping sugary juice down her arm. She stares blankly at him, lips parted in shock as Mydei continues to speak.

“We should prepare some necessities. Maybe grab some nutritious food and water.” His voice lowers into a contemplative murmur. “I can also make some herbal chicken soup for him… I’m sure he’s not feeding himself properly… Maybe something sweet as well to balance out the savory…”

“Lord Phainon is in rut, yes?” Castorice gently says, a pinch to her delicate eyebrows. “We shouldn’t intrude.” She shakes her head, clearing her thoughts. “It’s better to keep our distance.”

Her discomfort is palpable, but her words have Mydei’s immediate interest. He’s heard in passing that Phainon’s ruts are intense, soft whisperings from Hyacine to Aglaea when they thought he wasn’t listening. Every few months, the alpha retreats for a week, unable to brave the dawn until the last of the symptoms fizzle out. Either that or he’s sent off on a solo titankin clearing mission.

“He doesn’t take care of himself. It’ll spell disaster if the Deliverer gets sick.”

Castorice’s expression flickers, alternating confused and conflicted. Her eyes flit down to the poor peach in her hand, more pulp than fruit. With an apologetic bow, she tells Demetria that she’ll pay for it and clean up the juice, which had already dripped onto the stone flooring and onto the stall itself. Demetria tells her to not worry about it.

Alarm bells blare, and Hyacine’s warning of “don’t you dare go near an alpha in rut” repeats in his head. His desire to see Phainon drowns her out. If Castorice doesn’t want to go, then he’ll go alone.

“Okay, we’ll visit. I worry for him too,” Castorice relents as she picks out some apples and grapes for Phainon. She turns to grab a few ripe pomegranates only for Mydei to stop her with a shake of his head. Her woven basket strains from the weight of the fruit as she turns to Demetria to pay, apologizing once more for the trouble.

As they leave the fruit stall and stroll around the market, Castorice says, “Lord Phainon has a penchant for not taking care of himself…” She takes a deep breath. “But interrupting an alpha in rut has its risks, as I’m sure you know well, Lord Mydei. Are you sure this is a good idea?”

“If he attacks me, I can take care of it,” Mydei says as he takes the basket from her. “His rut hit early this time.”

With a nod of thanks, she stretches out her back and arms. “Early? Oh, dear. Did someone trigger it?”

“I don’t know. Last I remember…”

Memories flash of Phainon holding onto him as they slept, how flushed his face had been the morning after. How he rushed to leave as if he had been caught red-handed. Something *burns* in his chest. He stomps out the fire.

“Nevermind,” Mydei quickly says.

Along with the fruit, they pick up a large jug of water, some packets of herbal tea, and chicken soup. Mydei would have liked to make a slow cooked soup for Phainon, but his teleslate had pinged with a text from Krateros asking when he would return. The pre-made chicken soup would have to do, even if a part of him screams out that home-made is better. He knows Phainon’s tastes like the back of his hand, which is why it’s so easy to meddle with his food when he’s feeling trivial.

On the way out of Marmoreal Market, they pass by a popular dessert shop, and Mydei stops to purchase some jars of Phainon’s favorite *rizogalo* , cinnamon rice pudding. It’s light and airy, yet decadent and silky. Perfect as a small but nutritious treat.

“How are you going to get in?” Castorice asks as they make their way up the stone steps that lead to Phainon’s modest home, a gift from Aglaea. She pauses, glancing down at the doormat before giving a small giggle.

Embroidered on the navy blue doormat is a drawing of a fluffy white dog with its paws up, a giant welcome stamped above it in bold white letters. Mydei sighs, a small but exasperated smile gracing his lips. The old doormat, perfectly plain beige, had been stained with golden blood one too many times and had to be replaced. Of course Phainon would choose something like this.

Scattered around the porch is an assortment of antiques, all fakes that Mydei and others had so helpfully pointed out after Phainon had spent a fortune on them. They make decent decorations, Mydei supposes, and customary as always, he reaches into the red vase with the webbed cracks and pulls out a key. It’s definitely not the smartest place to hide it, and already, he’s told Phainon many times to store it someplace else, but to no avail. He supposes this saves him the trouble of having to look around.

All he has to do now is drop off the basket of goods and leave. That’s all. He knows what a rut is and what it can look like, thanks to his years of stopping his soldiers from ripping each other’s throats out. The last thing he wants is to aggravate Phainon when he’s in such a vulnerable, high emotion state.

Castorice stands outside, waiting below the stone steps. Her refusal to step inside doesn’t shock him. It’s far riskier for her than it is for him. Besides, he’s grateful she agreed to come in the first place.

Unfortunately, there are no boundaries when it comes to his relationship with Phainon.

He fights the urge to groan miserably when he flips the door open and is immediately greeted with the sight of countless antiques strewn about the house, covering the floor. All brand new. He’s never seen any of these before, not the giant ornate plates depicting what looks to be

Nikador and Kephale engaged in a rather inappropriate tryst, the gaudy mosaic glass sculpture shaped like a chimera, or the rotund vases that looks more sphere than vase.

It hasn't been that long since he's last visited Phainon's house. Probably only a month? How did his already immense collection triple?!

But that's the least of Mydei's worries because the smell of alpha is *overwhelming* . It nearly has his knees buckling. He winces, holding his nose from the onslaught of burnt flora mixing with the heady scent of what he recognizes now as arousal. It's unmistakable, smoky and spiced, cloying to his newfound senses.

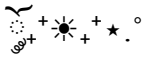
A spark is lit in his chest. Maybe this wasn't such a good idea after all. Hyacine's words blare in his head, and he can imagine her exasperation if she were to learn that he had ignored her advice. With a small huff and a slight scrunch of his nose, he steadies himself against the wall, easing the tremble of his thighs.

Mydei doesn't dare breathe, holding his breath as he darts around the flood of antiques. He's going to have to get on Phainon about his hoarding habits given the rather insane amount of clutter. There's barely any floor! He almost slams into a stone statue, the urge to snarl rolling at his lips. Somehow, he manages to make his way into the kitchen without toppling anything and drops the basket of goods onto the counter before making his careful way back out.

Fresh air flows into his lungs. The fire begins to fizzle with each breath he takes, slowly fading as his mind clears. A drop of sweat drips down his brow. Phainon's house had been *hot* , overwhelmingly hot, with all the windows strewn shut. The back of his nape tingles for a moment, only to dissipate. He's not quite sure if it happened or if it's only his imagination.

"Is everything alright, Lord Mydei?" Castorice asks when he meets her gaze. He gives a tight nod before pulling out his teleslate to text Phainon, alerting him of the goods left on his table.

It's midday already. He parts ways with Castorice, promising to be back before dinner so they could bake the peach tarts together. There's much of the day to go, but already, he feels like taking a nap.



The day passes as quickly as it starts. He's spent the past week lounging around the villa with Castorice, cooking, relaxing, and enjoying each other's calm company. It's been peaceful, the type of lifestyle that he wouldn't mind having had it not been for the flame chase and the expectations of his people. Add Phainon into the equation, his bright smiles and cheeky attitude, and Mydei would be content to live in this dream forever.

It’s only when Krateros sends over a text asking when he would return to boost morale that he decides to return to his countrymen for the day. Without Phainon to spar and train with, he figures he might as well spend some hours training with his fellow Kremnoans, especially because it’s been a long while since the soldiers have had the chance to spar with the crown prince. Even Krateros himself asks to join.

A crowd gathers. In the corner of his eye, he can see the young omega recruit, but he’s standing in the back, drowned out by the clamor of the other much taller alphas. Something twists in Mydei’s chest, and he beckons the omega to the front, giving the young soldier a reassuring nod.

Alpha pheromones saturate the air, heavy and thick. He defeats each of the challengers with ease, deflecting blows and finding openings, all the while shouting out advice. The newer recruits fight based on instinct, fangs bared as their subsequent attacks grow in desperation, frustrated growls emitting deep from their throats.

The veteran soldiers fight with an eerie calm. Each strike is calculated, precise. They know when to release their pheromones, when to reel it in. Gone is the wildness and reckless abandon, replaced with coordinated strikes and iron clad focus.

As each challenger falls, Mydei comes to the fortunate—or unfortunate, he’s not too sure—conclusion that only Phainon’s pheromones have an effect on him. The smell of this many alphas packed tightly together isn’t pleasant, he can easily admit. His nose scrunches up on its own when another alpha gets too close. Only Phainon’s scent smells good to him, even if it does devolve into burning ash when the alpha is upset. The acrid scent reminds him of the ruins of a battlefield, the desecration of life and of desperation to survive. His treacherous heart skips a beat.

Soaked in sweat, his hair sticks in clumps against his forehead and his crimson markings gleam beneath the bright lights of the training hall. He bids his goodbyes and takes a quick detour to the baths to clean up.

His return to the villa is met with Castorice’s gentle smile, and he starts to prepare a simple dinner of flaky fish and creamy tomato orzo while Castorice slices the peaches. Her first attempt results in success—the tarts are perfectly sweet and caramelized, balanced with the flaky, crispy dough. Tomorrow, they’ll bring some over for Hyacine and little Ica to try.

Satisfied by the day’s events, Mydei had been preparing for bed, removing his armor and retrieving his favorite silken night robes. As he slides on the robes, delighting in the feel of the soft airy fabric, a light but rhythmic knock arrives at his bedroom door.

“It’s not locked,” Mydei calls out. He sits at the edge of his bed, teleslate in hand as he scrolls through his messages. Aglaea had texted the group chat that Cipher would be returning in two weeks with the subsequent gathering happening two days after. Even through simple text, Mydei can glean her excitement. For one, she’s not texting with perfect grammar.

The door cracks open to reveal Castorice, also donning her night robes, her hair pulled into a high ponytail. “Lord Mydei, may I come in?”

“Go ahead.”

Castorice steps in, gently closing the door behind her. “I hope I’m not being too forthright.” She plays with stray purple strands, twirling them around as her eyes flit from corner to corner. “I… I wished to speak to you regarding my cycles.”

Mydei clicks his teleslate shut and begins taking off his gold-plated necklace. The gold shimmers in the light, heavy against his hand. He sets it on his nightstand with a soft clang.

A soft, uncertain sigh leaves her lips. “There are precautions that must be taken when an unmated alpha and unmated omega live under the same roof. May I sit down beside you?”

Silently, Mydei scoots over. The bed dips with the weight of another.

“You must be aware of the dangers. My heats are irregular and intense. I cannot predict them,” Castorice swallows, taking a deep breath as she wrings her hands together. “Should I go into heat, it may negatively affect you and even drag you into sudden rut.” Her words are gentle but her gaze has sharpened substantially, and Mydei can tell she’s looking for a reaction out of him. Never has he seen Castorice like this, uncomfortable and wary, yet attempting to not so subtly pry information out of him.

He should have expected this kind of conversation to be brought up eventually. Somehow, it slipped his mind. His heart skips a beat, and he subconsciously bunches the fabric covering his thighs.

“You don’t have to worry. I won’t react,” he replies. He’s not the type to dress up his answers in pretty little outfits, tied up with a neat bow made of white lies.

Her expression dips, lips pursed. “I heard about the rumors,” she starts. “I thought they were strange. Very unlike you. I didn’t want to ask, but I admit, I was rather curious.”

Everyone has, but he doesn’t voice it. Thus far, Castorice has been nothing but kind and understanding. Regardless, the crawl of unease nestles in his chest.

“At first, I thought I was imagining things.” Castorice lowers her gaze. “Your…” she frowns, trying to grasp for the right word, “aura… it feels different.”

“Different?” Mydei repeats.

“We’ve been on missions together in the past,” Castorice says. “And have spent much time in close proximity.”

Indeed, they have. Most of his missions are either solo or with Phainon if the situation is dire enough, but the few times he’s worked together with Castorice have been enjoyable. Never is she quick to anger, unlike a certain someone who’s first instinct is to jump into battle.

“When I touch you, you no longer fall to the River of Souls as you have before… This sudden change had me thinking about the cause. Lord Mydei, I do not mean to pry,” She closes her eyes only to open them once more, determination in her gaze. “Forgive me, but you’re an omega, aren’t you?”

His heartbeat stills. The bright light of his bedroom burns his eyes. A thousand whirling thoughts soar through his mind, all sorts of reasons and excuses, but there's little use in denying. Castorice already knows.

"I am," Mydei relents.

A sigh of relief falls from Castorice's lips. She shifts around, crossing and uncrossing her legs. "I probably should have started with this. My apologies, Lord Mydei. I wasn't sure."

"It's no big deal. I understand your hesitancy." She's made no mention of his scent, so he should be safe in that regard, but for her to see through him so easily… That makes yet another heir who knows.

"You must have presented recently. A late bloomer, perhaps?"

Mydei unfurls his braid, fingers tangling in his messy locks. "It happened sometime during my most recent mission."

Castorice blinks. "Ah. I see. So, that's why…"

"I wasn't aware of it at the time. Looking back on it, it was rather obvious."

"You never struck me as an alpha, Lord Mydei. I never thought of you as one," Castorice says, gently placing a warm hand over his. "Omega suits you more."

"..." Mydei glances at himself in the mirror. He doesn't look like an omega, not by any means.

His body is all hard ridges and planes with none of that characteristic omega softness so prized. He looks like an alpha, is built like one too, and his voice isn't melodic in quality or sweet like sugar. Instead, it's deep and breathy, referred to as intimidating by many—the low, rumbly growl of a commanding alpha. It's really no wonder everyone believes him to be one even if he never proclaimed himself as such.

"Ah!" Castorice gasps as she covers her mouth. "I didn't mean to offend… Please forget I said that."

"No offense taken," Mydei responds. "I've never had anyone tell me that." He pauses and looks down at his lap as a small smile settles on his lips. "Thank you."

Castorice smiles back, purple eyes glittering like the brightest amethysts. The initial discomfort has disappeared, leaving her floral scent sweet and light.

Mydei enters his bathroom to grab a comb and begins working through his strawberry blonde locks, while Castorice's gaze roams around his room. Given he's only been here for about a week, he hasn't had any time to decorate or rearrange. The setup looks as it had when he first moved in.

"You seem relieved," Mydei can't help but say, wincing as he works through a particularly thick knot.

She nods, tucking a stray strand behind her ear. “Since we’re both omegas, there should be no need for further accommodation. Given your lack of scent, I assume you take suppressants and scent blockers?” When Mydei nods, she asks, “Have you been in heat before?”

“No.” And he hopes he never will. Going through a pre-heat had already sent him to his limit. Even thinking about heat has his chest squeezing uncomfortably, irrational as it might be to fear a natural, normal cycle.

“I see…” Castorice stands up. She momentarily glances at the clump of moonlight fabric lying beside Mydei’s pillow, before frantically turning away. Mydei takes the chance to quickly throw it into the closet.

“Lord Mydei… I must warn you, for your own sake. I don’t mean to scare you, but don’t depend on those medications to work. If Hyacine gives you instructions for them, follow what she says.” Her expression falls, revisiting unpleasant memories of the past. “They do not work for me anymore. My heat cycles have been damaged because of overuse.”



A few days later, Castorice drags him out of the villa, this time to purchase new beddings and decor for his barren room.

Originally, he didn’t mind living with the base decor, but she insisted he would be more comfortable if he were to purchase new blankets and an assortment of pillows. Omegas enjoy nests, she told him. He asked her what a nest was. Isn’t that what birds make?

She showed him around her room with its lush lavender blankets and plethora of fluffy pillows interspersed with cute creature plushies of varying sizes. She then opened her closet, revealing even more blankets and pillows, stating that she likes to rearrange every so often—especially during pre-heat and heat. She had him lay in her bed, watching in satisfaction as he practically melted into the mattress upon contact.

“Okay, I understand now,” Mydei had murmured, eyes fluttering shut. He had woken up revitalized, the best nap he’s had in ages, only to realize he had been asleep for nearly an entire day.

A cool breeze blows through, setting afloat pollen particles in the crisp morning air. Beautiful as Okhema may be in this time of year, it’s this season where he has the most trouble. This specific part of Okhema, known as the flower district, is, as its name suggests, lush with blooming flora. All around are bushels of blooming hydrangeas, lush stalks of fluttering lilies, and gardens full of multicolored anemone. Honeysuckle and wisteria vines crawl up marble pillars and hang off the walls of the towering limestone buildings. Pollen is in every nook and crevice, saturated with floral fragrance.

His nose begins to itch as a familiar pressure builds behind his temple. His attempts to hold it in are futile. He sneezes, a high-pitched squeaking noise falling from his lips.

Castorice gapes at him.

“What?” Mydei asks, wiping at his nose only to immediately sneeze again. This time it sounds more like a chimera chirp than a human sneeze.

“Bless you…” She giggles into her hand. Her long pigtails sway gently in the wind, purple eyes twinkling in amusement. “Allergies?”

“Let’s find the shop quickly,” he says, striding onwards.

In the distance, he spots a familiar tall figure. Castorice waves and calls out, “Lord Phainon!”

“Castorice! Mydei!” Phainon waves back. He jogs over, blue and gold cape billowing behind him. “Nice to see you both here!”

“Deliverer,” Mydei greets.

Castorice bows. “How have you been?”

Phainon grins, all brilliant teeth and crinkled eyes. Only the pallor of his skin is striking, blending with his moonlight hair and contrasting with the dark eyebags beneath his normally radiant blue eyes, now dulled like an uncut sapphire. His movements are less fluid as if he has little control over his limbs. Gone is the elegance, the intentional and balanced movements of a trained warrior.

“Great!” Phainon exclaims. An obvious lie with the way his fingers twitch. “How have you been, Castorice? Mydei?” His gaze doesn’t meet Mydei’s eyes. Instead, he directs all attention to the omega beside him.

Something inside Mydei wilts. He pushes the feeling down.

“I wanted to thank you both for dropping the stuff off,” Phainon says with a sheepish laugh. “I needed it. I wasn't expecting my rut to happen so early. Not really sure what happened there…” His expression falls only to return to bright and cheery. If Mydei had blinked, he would have missed it.

“Why did you hang up on me?” Mydei asks.

Phainon jerks his head. His expression flickers as his gaze flits between him and Castorice, as if debating if he should continue ignoring Mydei’s presence. Another bright grin and a rambunctious laugh. “You woke me up from a nice nap, Mydei! I was feeling a little vindictive. Can you blame me when you claw at me for waking you up during your naps? I still bear the scars from last time.”

“Deserved,” Mydei huffs, crossing his arms. His nose burns, vision blurring as his eyes grow teary. His allergies weren’t nearly this bad before. What’s going on?

Phainon pauses to stare, eyebrows furrowing as he picks up Mydei's rapid change in expression. "Mydei—"

He sneezes once more. This time it's extra high pitched. His cheeks burn.

"Eh?" Phainon says, dumbfounded. Castorice slaps a hand over her mouth to mute her giggles.

"Stop staring, *haikas*," Mydei bites out, blinking the tears out of his eyes.

"Uh…" Phainon forces his gaze away and says, "So… Erm, you and Castorice..." The words still in his throat, almost like they're stuck.

"Get on with it," Mydei says gruffly.

"Are spending quite some time together, I've heard," Phainon finishes.

Castorice's eyebrows slowly creep up her forehead.

"We live together," Mydei helpfully supplies as he brushes his bangs away from his eyes.

"You two live together," Phainon echoes, nodding along. He freezes, eyes blown wide. "Huh? Wait, what?!"

It's strange. Normally, this close, Mydei would be inundated with Phainon's scent. But there's barely anything, leaving only traces of what had been so prevalent before.

"The shared villa," Castorice pipes up.

"It's more convenient," Mydei explains. "Closer to the main areas of the city. The baths," he adds, watching in satisfaction as Phainon inevitably perks up at the mention.

"You don't have an excuse now," Phainon sing-songs as he slings an arm around Mydei's shoulder. He puts three fingers up. "Now, we can go to the baths three times a day instead of two!"

"For what reason do you have to go three times a day? Two is already excessive," Mydei huffs.

Phainon's scent has lessened substantially. Even this close, Mydei can barely detect it. He's almost tempted to take a deep breath to make sure. His familiar scent of lush meadow is gone, much like the barren fields in the dead of a winter snowstorm.

Blue eyes glint beneath the shade. "Oh, how wound me! It's quality bonding time, my dear Mydeimos. In the steam of the warm bath, side by side, our camaraderie burgeons like blooming perennials in the height of spring!"

Castorice coughs multiple times.

"Would you like to join us?" Mydei asks her. "We always ask for a private room."

He means it as a joke. Phainon pouts, lips jutted out. His hold tightens on Mydei's shoulders, squeezing until almost painful.

"Ah…" Castorice laughs, the beginnings of a flush on her cheeks. She glances over at Phainon who's rapidly shaking his head before saying, "As much as I would love to, I would have to decline. Please let me know if your, uhm, camaraderie improves. Or not. Actually, I don't want to know. Or do I? Uh, never mind. Maybe it's better if I don't know… Please enjoy each other..."

"Enjoy each other?" Phainon asks, raising an eyebrow.

"Each other's company!" Castorice stammers.

"Right..."

"We're shopping for blankets," Mydei interrupts. "Do you want to join us, Deliverer?"

The store is only a five minutes walk away from where they're at. Mydei continues to sneeze, and Phainon not so subtly stares at him, awestruck like Mydei's an alien that he's seeing for the first time.

Castorice walks a few steps behind them, keeping a careful distance away instead of staying close. He almost wants to ask her why she's staying so far, but he can't, not when his vision blurs and sneezes continue to wrack his body.

Entering the store is a reprieve. He can finally breathe again.

His gaze roams around to the plethora of decorative bedding sets lining the walls and the assortment of quilted blankets folded neatly in the corner. Pillows, in all shapes and sizes, are scattered about the store, sorted into different categories based on material. There's even a section dedicated to fragrance diffusers and candles.

It's a small but cozy establishment specializing in bedroom decor, meant for omegas looking to build a comfortable nest, but also open to the wider population. Even alphas enjoy the comfort of a warm, soft bed. The store clerk, a middle-aged beta woman, greets them with a kindly smile.

Though he's never shown it, Mydei has always been partial towards thick blankets and soft pillows. Most of his life has consisted of sleeping on dirty floors or in the untamed wilderness. His first few years, he had been surrounded by water, floating aimlessly. Then came the terribly scratchy straw beds of the training barracks. Only recently has he been able to enjoy an actual bed.

Phainon picks up a pillow plush in the shape of a fluffy white dog and presses it to his cheek. "I want this one," he states to which Castorice agrees enthusiastically.

Every so often, Castorice hands him a pillow she thinks he would like. They spend a good amount of time browsing through the store, running their hands across soft wool blankets.

His gaze falls to a basket of chimera plushies. He grabs a grey one with horns that reminds him of Beagle Coconut and tosses it into the cart without as much as a second thought.

There's been many times where he's passed by toy stores selling the softest and cutest handmade chimera plushies, always pausing to take a quick look. He even remembers seeing rotund plushies of little Ica. The shop keeper had told him it was all the craze with the children of Okhema, so he bought one for Hyacine. He wishes he had kept one for himself.

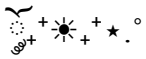
"Why do you need this many pillows and blankets?" Phainon asks as he drags the cart around, placed on cart duty while Mydei scours around the store. "Isn't this rather excessive?"

"I could say the same to the antiques littering your floor."

"Hey!" Phainon cries out, indignant. "That's not the same. I'll have you know, those antiques are one of a kind. Never before seen in Okhema. I had to get them." A whimper falls from his lips. "Mydei, you don't understand…"

"That's what you say about all of them," Mydei says, fluffing up a silken crimson pillow embroidered with gold trim. He quite likes this one.

Phainon sticks his tongue out and immediately gets the pillow thrown at his face.



It seems Phainon wasn't lying about having him go to the baths multiple times a day. Now that he has no excuse to say no or refuse, he's dragged out twice as often. Phainon has unlimited access to the shared villa. No longer does he have to knock on Mydei's front door, begging to be let in.

He used to allow Phainon unlimited access to his home, but he snagged the key back after the fifth time finding Phainon lounging on his living room couch, eating all his snacks. Some of those treats Mydei had been saving for later. A little petty maybe, but he stands on his decision.

Though, if Phainon had pouted and begged a little bit more, he probably would have relented. It's a good thing he didn't because if Phainon had the key, he would have found Mydei unconscious, knocked out due to an intense pre-heat. He's not sure how Phainon would have reacted.

His scent is unpleasant to the alpha, and he rather not be reminded of the slickness of his thighs and the burning in his nape.

The public baths have their benefits and their very obvious drawbacks. It's times like these where Mydei would have much preferred to go to the Chrysos Heirs private bath instead.

The urge to snarl crosses his lips. With his arms crossed tightly against his chest, he stares around at the magnificent domed walls of Marmoreal Palace, the shelves lined with extra thick towels, the abundance of multi-colored seals bobbing about in the water. His gaze follows the expanse of bustling hallways, anywhere but beside him.

Because Okhema's golden boy, the Deliverer, *Phainon* is chatting enthusiastically with a bathhouse worker, a petite omega with long dark hair and forest green eyes. Her breasts are large and her hips shapely even beneath the simple bathhouse uniform. It seems they've known each other for awhile now, but Mydei has never seen her before.

He can smell her sweet scent of nectarines, can see the sparkle in her eyes as she inches closer to Phainon, who remains oblivious as ever. She bats her eyelashes and giggles at a joke, one that the alpha has said over a million times by now. It works for those uninitiated, while Mydei automatically rolls his eyes. He can even see the moment where she decides to change tactics by pretending to slip on a puddle of water, dramatically flailing her arms around.

Of course, Phainon catches her, wraps his strong arms around her waist as he steadies her and asks if she's okay. A blush brightens her features as she turns her head to the side, baring her neck. A shy apology falls from her rosy lips. He can even see her slyly rub against him, but Phainon is Phainon, unable to get a hint.

It's rather obvious as an outsider to this entire situation. A dark feeling burns inside him, the desire to tell her to leave and never get near Phainon ever again grows like wildfire. It's insipid of him to feel this way.

After all, Phainon's appearance is striking, radiant. Moonlight hair artfully tousled and wide blue eyes framed by thick lashes. Trained body of a warrior, strong beyond mortal comprehension.

Mydei learned the hard way when Phainon easily hoisted him up with one arm, a wide grin on his face as Mydei scrambled to steady himself.

Phainon is Okhema's proud jewel. Everyone loves him. A rare alpha that naturally commands attention when he walks into the room.

Mydei has always known that. He's had to bear witness to the many people that have either confessed or attempted to confess to Phainon. And at the baths, with Phainon's body out on display, it's always a free for all for the bathgoers and workers on who can get his attention first. Thankfully, he's fully clothed right now, so the attention is less, but still very much present.

Disgruntled, Mydei steps aside to lounge on a nearby *kline* . The omega didn't seem too keen on speaking with him, only offered him a polite look before honing her attention on her target. It's better to wait for them to finish.

It’s not a big deal. Many Okhemans still have their prejudices against Kremnoans. Though tensions are lesser nowadays, they’re still very much present. His reputation has shot down given the rumors, though he hasn’t heard much whisperings lately.

He rests his head against the pillow and closes his eyes, scrounging a moment's rest and blocking out all noise. Never has it bothered him this much until now. He almost wishes he had refused Phainon’s request to bathe together. They always request a private room, even in the public baths.

“Mydei!” Phainon jogs up to him, the clack of his leather boots against tile. “Don’t fall asleep on me again.”

He cracks open an eye to see Phainon looming over him, looking much like an excited puppy. If he had a tail, it’d be wagging. Though the omega is gone, he can smell her on him. He doesn’t like it. Something burns inside him. A desire to claim.

“She’s interested in you,” Mydei says, sitting up and watching as the woman gives Phainon one last wistful glance before hurrying off to do her worker duties.

Phainon tilts his head. “Who?”

“The omega you were speaking to,” Mydei says, pushing himself off the *kline* . He stretches out his back muscles before swinging his towel over his shoulders.

“Oh. She’s a friend. I met her a few weeks ago when you were on your mission. Had to come to the bathhouse alone.”

“Hmph.”

“Why?” Phainon presses. His voice grows tight, though his expression remains light. “Are you interested in her? You’ve been eyeing her. Found more prey to sink your fangs into?”

“Why would I be interested in her?” Mydei stares at Phainon with obvious disbelief. “She rubbed against you, and you let her.”

“Oh? Hm…” Phainon tilts his head, banging falling over his eyes. He pauses, in deep contemplation, before he’s leaning forwards, lips curving into a wide grin as he effortlessly invades Mydei’s personal space. His face is only millimeters away from Mydei’s. “Are you jealous?” he jests, blue eyes glinting.

“I’m not,” Mydei scoffs. He grabs Phainon’s wrist and pulls him towards the changing room. “Let’s go.”

“No way!” Phainon laughs. “Mydei, my dearest, you know I only have eyes for you.” He says it a bit too loud, unabashed in his tone. Almost as if he wants others to hear.

A few heads turn their way. Mydei even hears a gasp in the background and the clattering of a fruit plate onto the floor, plump grapes rolling away in all different directions.

“Stop talking,” Mydei hisses. Already, his ears begin to burn red, and Phainon, observant as always, notices right away. Blue eyes glimmer, crinkling at the edges, a wide smile decorating handsome features. Any wider, and it’s sure to fall off.

Phainon looks far too pleased. It makes Mydei turn away and focus on their destination. They make it through the doorway into the changing rooms. Without another word, Mydei starts pulling off his clothing and stuffing it into an open locker, ignoring Phainon whose gaze is burning a hole in his back. He wraps a towel around his hips as he shrugs off his pants.

“I like alphas, you know,” Phainon says, his hand moving to wrap around Mydei’s bare waist, stroking away at the tanned skin. “Can’t see myself with an omega. I thought you knew that.”

“I know now,” Mydei says, pulling himself away. The touch burns. Bitterness floods his mouth. “Shut up and take your clothes off. ”

“Not going to buy me dinner first?” Phainon pouts as he pulls off his high-collared compression shirt, sculpted muscles flexing. His pectorals are firm, pure muscle, complete with carved washboard abs. No matter how often he’s seen Phainon shirtless, he still can’t get used to the sight.

He sounds a little like a teenage girl. Castorice would be delighted if she could hear his internal dialogue.

“What’s that on your neck?” Mydei asks, staring at what looks to be a square piece of gauze covering Phainon’s nape. He even has matching ones on both his wrists. “Have you been injured?”

Phainon slaps his hand over the patch on his nape and raises an eyebrow. He searches Mydei’s expression for any signs of a joke. “It’s a scent patch.”

Oh . A scent patch. That makes infinitely more sense. He’s heard of those. Many Okhemans run around with gauze on their necks and wrists, and it always struck him as odd.

Okhemans treat secondary gender differently it seems. Kremnoans parade their scents around, wearing it as a badge of honor. Scent patches don’t exist where he’s from because it’s seen as a disgrace to hide one’s scent, almost on par with refusing to battle.

Closing the mahogany doors, they slide into the warm water. Their own private bath, away from the loud crowds and curious eyes. Steam blankets the room, giving it a hazy, euphoric feeling. With a soft groan, Mydei melts into the water, eyes fluttering shut. Phainon lounges beside him.

Now that the patch is gone, Phainon’s familiar scent begins to fill the space, overpowering the soft scents of chamomile and sandalwood from the scented bath oils. The hairs on Mydei’s neck stick up, and he breathes deeply. He’s missed the scent more than he’d like to admit, but it’s tinged with the omega from earlier. Their scents mesh together, and he’s unable to tell where Phainon starts and where she ends.

Mydei bites his lip. He can't relax, not like this. His eyes snap open, and he crawls onto Phainon's lap, burying his face into the crook of Phainon's neck. He breathes in the familiar citrus scent while rubbing his cheek against the bare skin, desperately trying to get rid of the other scent that sticks onto the alpha. His bare ass rubs against the wet towel tied tightly around Phainon's waist.

Maybe he should drag Phainon underwater to wash away her scent. He won't be too happy about it, but Mydei will take his chances.

He pauses, breath fanning over pale skin.

No. Probably not worth it.

"Mydei…" Phainon shifts beneath him. His voice comes out rough, almost ragged, "What do you think you're doing?"

He pulls away and presses a finger to Phainon's lips. "Shush."

If only he could scent Phainon too… then he could get rid of her scent on his body. He tries again and again, but he has no scent. The haziness of the steamy room mixes with the haziness of his mind. He nearly cries out in frustration.

It's good that Phainon can't smell him. He's sure the alpha would pull away and not allow any of this had Mydei outed himself as an omega. Some alphas and omegas aren't compatible. While he likes Phainon's scent, Phainon doesn't like his.

"What's going on with you?" Phainon murmurs as wraps his arms around Mydei's waist to stabilize him. Fingers thread into his hair as Mydei clings onto Phainon's broad shoulders.

A soft knock on the door. An attendant slides in to bring new towels and refresh the soaps and fragrant oils. It's the same girl as before. Of course it is. Seasoned bathhouse workers know better than to go into their private room unannounced.

Phainon's back is turned to her. Mydei runs his hands up his spine, eliciting a shiver from the alpha while he gives the omega the darkest glare he can muster. A warning to leave. A warning that she's not welcome here, that Phainon isn't hers for the taking.

The message is clear.

She squeaks out an apology, dropping the towels and bottles on the bench before bowing and making her way out.

Chapter End Notes

jealous mydei!! hehe

big fan of mydei's gap moe. this fic is just me trying to stuff his gap moe down everyone's throats

next chapter will be entirely phainon's pov
so get ready. crash out king is back in business

thanks for reading!

adorable fanart by Tsuuchinoko!!

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

back with another update. this time phainon's pov!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the thick steam of the private bath, time slows to a halt.

Warm, silken water flows rhythmically into the ensuing pool, and the air flourishes with the fragrance of sweet scented oils. Phainon is sent into a hazy respite. He thinks he might have heard the door open, but he's not too sure.

It's hard to focus. He's a little distracted because Mydei is *nestled* on his lap. Rubbing against him. Trying to scent him.

Is this real? Or is he simply in the throes of another rut-driven fantasy? His head spins. He can't make sense of what's going on.

Only two thin towels separate Phainon's cock from Mydei's ass, and as Mydei continues to rub against him, his towel begins to unravel.

Fuck. It's game over if it does.

One arm wraps around Mydei's back, fingers tracing the ridges of hard muscle, the line of his back, the curve of his waist. The other stays deeply threaded in damp blonde locks. Mydei whines softly, face pressed against the crook of Phainon's neck.

Phainon's cock hardens. His mind continues its rapid descent into the abyss. By now, his fangs have fully elongated. Drool pools in his mouth, and he swallows down the urge to buck his hips upwards.

Each shift, each stuttering of Mydei's hips has Phainon *wanting* . By titans, he only has so much restraint. The nose brushing against his neck. The eyelashes fluttering against his feverish skin. The arms gripping his back.

Pressed chest to chest, Phainon can hear the thrum of Mydei's heartbeat, the quickening of his breath. He can feel every tremble and shake of Mydei's body, slotted so perfectly against his. It's too much, but not enough at the same time.

He can't help but bite out a desperate plea, a low prayer. "Mydei, please… I need…"

Oh, how badly he wants to grind his cock against Mydei's firm yet perky ass. It's taking all his willpower to keep still, his hips trembling with desire.

The words fall on deaf ears. Mydei is distracted like a kitten who's discovered catnip for the first time and can't get enough. He continues rubbing himself all over Phainon's body without a care in the world that they're practically in public with only a door separating them from the other bathgoers. There's only one thing on Mydei's mind, and his normally clear golden eyes are glassy and unfocused, pupils blown wide.

Phainon digs his fangs into his mouth and the taste of iron floods his senses—an attempt to stop any embarrassing noises from spilling out. It works, until Mydei becomes more fervent, frenzied almost, in how he keeps rubbing himself against every possible area of Phainon's bare body. The poor towel wrapped low on his hips is holding on for dear life.

His restraint is in shambles. There's nothing he wants more than to fuck Mydei until he's sobbing and whining on his knot. His hands find themselves beneath Mydei's towel, crawling inside until his fingers trail the curve of Mydei's firm ass. He feels something thick, warm, and wet.

The shift is instant. It's like a cord has snapped.

The trance shatters, and Mydei is shoved back to reality, golden eyes widening as he takes in their current position. He pulls himself back, splashing water all over as he practically jumps off of Phainon's lap.

"Did you have a good time?" Phainon croaks out.

Mydei blinks, looks down at Phainon's obvious arousal and then to his own. He wraps his arms tightly around himself before turning away and cursing under his breath.

"We can't do this," Mydei mutters, more to himself than to Phainon. His face is flushed, flaming red. "No. This isn't…" His breathing quickens, chest heaving, as he stares at Phainon with wide, shaky eyes. Never in all their years together has Mydei ever looked so *scared* . "Deliverer..."

"Yes?" Phainon asks, pulling himself out of the water. He takes a cautious step towards Mydei only for Mydei to recoil and take a hasty step back. It feels a little like he's cornering an injured animal.

"Today never happened," Mydei says, voice trembling. "*This* never happened."



The days pass by. They don't talk about what transpired at the baths. Mydei doesn't bring it up, and Phainon, regardless of how much he wants to, doesn't either.

There's a marked shift in their relationship. Mydei acts distant and when Phainon tries his hand at scenting him like he has for the past few weeks, Mydei refuses him.

"We can't do this anymore, Deliverer," Mydei says as he yanks himself away from Phainon's embrace. His expression darkens, golden eyes narrowing as he turns away. "There will be no more scenting."

Even Phainon's classic puppy-eyed, trembling pout has no sway anymore.

Okay. If that's how Mydei wants to play, then Phainon has no choice other than retreat and lick his wounds. It's a strange turn of events, especially since Mydei was the one who initiated that entire public scenting ordeal. Can't really fault him for being a little confused. It definitely puts a wrench in his plans.

He won't confess. Not yet. Not until he gets a clearer picture of what's going on.

Regardless of the itch in his throat and the pressure in his chest, he carries on. Smiles and laughs. Acts as if he's okay. Mydei is cautious of him now, and he doesn't know how to close that distance.

Phainon peels off the scent patches on his nape and wrists and tosses them into the trash. He sighs, frustrated, as he rubs slow circles in the inflamed area on his neck. The corners of the patch had dug incessantly into his skin, leaving it red and irritated. He doesn't miss this feeling. Rather, he wishes he didn't have to deal with this at all.

With a scornful smile, he yanks open the cabinet where he usually stores his scent patches, expecting to find his stash. Only there's nothing in there. It's empty.

"What? I thought I had more…" Phainon mutters to himself, confused.

He checks his closet. Nothing. His bathroom. Nothing. Maybe he left some in his living room? Also nothing. He swore he had more, but it's also been years since he's had to use them. Is his memory growing hazy?

Once again, he checks the cabinet. Opens it then slams it close only to open it once more as if the patches would magically appear if he repeated it enough times.

Phainon groans as he stares into his trash, eyeing the wrinkled remnants of the last three patches he had so haphazardly thrown away. Should he fish them out and reuse them? Objectively it's gross and he rather not, but he's sort of in a pinch.

Damn it. If he wants more that means he has to visit Hyacine.

It's times like these where he realizes how little it takes to push the needle. Years he spent stable and in control only to fall back to old patterns, unable to regulate his scent even with Aglaea's teachings branded into him. None of her lessons work as they used to.

Frustrated, Phainon flops onto his bed, wincing at the sting where his chafed skin hits the rumpled mattress. He turns to his side and stares blankly at himself in the mirror.

He hates wearing those accursed patches. The amount of upkeep and the constant paranoia of them falling off makes them a less than stellar option at keeping pheromones at bay. Not to mention, he also has to pair them with thick, scent-neutralizing lotions that suffocate his pores. There's no other choice. Not when his body rejects the medications meant for this very purpose.

Since the end of his rut, he hasn't been able to properly control his pheromones. It's as if he had been transported to when he first arrived in Okhema, back when he was in a constant state of wild, unmanageable pre-rut.

He remembers those days. Whispers everywhere he went. A bad omen foretold. The Chrysos Heir who arrived in Okhema smelling of decay and destruction. The young alpha, the sole survivor of the black masked spectre that destroyed a small farming village. He had been young then, barely a child past fifteen.

Phainon pulls out his teleslate to check the time. It's the third quint of parting hour—not too late in the day. He could go for a quick run to the nearby store and purchase some over the counter. It'd save him a trip to Hyacine's, but then he remembers how terrible those cheap ones are and how little they work for someone like him.

On second note, it's probably not worth it. The ones Hyacine gives him are reinforced, made to subdue even the strongest of pheromones. The ones sold at the store barely function, not meant for Chrysos Heirs who have different inner workings due to golden blood.

Instead, he decides to take a quick shower to scrub off the remnants of lotion coating his scent glands. Dressed in only a pair of boxers, he sits at the edge of his bed while he towels his moonlight hair dry. He debates his options, few as they are.

Maybe he can try meditation—a simple yet effective tactic that has helped him much in the past. He closes his eyes and tries to focus, hone in on his senses. Aglaea taught him to clear his mind and release the tension coiled deep inside.

Only the moment he closes his eyes, he's met with memories of sweet pomegranate and honey. The beginnings of nausea pull at the pit of his stomach. He wants to hurl. That omegan scent haunts him. He can't escape it. Even his attraction to Mydei can't lessen the desire he has for that omega. It's insane to be thinking of another when his heart has always been for Mydei.

Even if Mydei doesn't return his feelings, Phainon will continue to hold on. No matter how much it hurts.

There is no way he will ever be with an omega. Even if he did like her— *he doesn't* —and she liked him back, he can't be with her. A damaged alpha like him can't be with an omega.

He's the captain steering a sinking ship. There's nowhere to go but down.

As Phainon steps up the winding steps into the lush greenery surrounding Hyacine's clinic, he can't help but feel a strange sense of deja vu. In front of him is the familiar sight of large, yellow sunflowers that border the periphery of the clinic. Spiralling green vines wrap around the aged stone walls, contrasting with the cutesy handwritten sign that reads 'Hyacine's Office Here!! ♡'.

He rarely visits Hyacine. The last time he came here, he had been forcefully dragged over by an angry Mydei who demanded he get that purpling bruise on his ribs checked out. Sure, it hurt when he breathed and maybe he couldn't walk as upright as he used to, but it was no big deal. It would heal with enough time, and he could still fight even if it hurt to hold his greatsword. There was no reason to waste Hyacine's precious time or resources.

She's already dealt with him in the past, spending hours upon hours, sacrificing precious sleep and resources, in an attempt to help him adjust to Okhema. He rather not revisit that era of his life.

Her space is as he remembers. Cozy and warm. Very much lived in, covered in pastel colors, cutesy designs, and many soft plushies. Little Ica hangs out on a waiting chair in the corner of the room, chomping away at a tower of bright red apples.

"Lord Phainon!" Hyacine exclaims, spinning around in her plush pink office chair to face him, her fluffy pigtails bouncing. If her wide eyes are any indication, she's caught off guard by his sudden and unannounced appearance. "What brings you here?"

"Hey, Hyacine," Phainon greets, giving her his signature wide grin. "My apologies for coming up unannounced."

"No worries!" Hyacine places her pen down. She had been in the middle of penning prescriptions, a deep look of concentration on her sweet features before he so rudely broke her out of her trance. He feels bad for wasting her time like this. She has better things to deal with than him, but he's desperate. Without those patches, he can't leave the confines of his room without terrorizing the public with what he can no longer control.

"Do you have more of those reinforced scent patches?" he casually asks her. Or tries. He can't help the slight pause of his words or the small hitch of his breath. His heart thunders in his chest, bracing for the next question to leave his lips. "Also… uhm, can I get some suppressants and scent blockers?"

Hyacine pauses as she takes in his request. Hesitant, she asks, "You're using the patches again?"

"For now," Phainon responds, rubbing at his naked nape. His fingers come back gross and oily from the plethora of lotion he had slapped on earlier. "I sort of ran out."

In an instant, she's off her chair and beside him. Turquoise eyes scan his face, and she carefully sniffs the air before placing a gentle hand on his nape. Her expression pinches as she murmurs, "Your scent is stronger than usual, even with the scent neutralization. It seems unstable too…" She looks up at him with abject concern, causing a chill to run down Phainon's spine. "Oh, dear. What caused this?"

"My rut came earlier than I expected," Phainon tells her. "Last week. A month early."

For years, his ruts have been normal. Once every three months on the dot. He can predict the beginning of his pre-rut with striking accuracy. Never has he reacted so strongly to the scent of another to thrust him into an early cycle. It's concerning to be thrown back to how he used to be—a reminder of the truth he's run from for so long. The illusion has shattered, and he's left to pick up the remnants.

Hyacine's expression flickers. She opens her mouth to say something only to pause in her step. Phainon has known her for years, practically since the day he entered the city, and has spent much of his time with her when they were students at the Grove. It's obvious she knows more than she lets on. Cheerful and enthusiastic as she is, she's also easy to read when troubled, even if she tries to hide it behind a veil of sweet smiles.

As lead physician, half of her job is keeping positive even when the situation seems a downward spiral. He wishes he had her tenacity.

"Do you know why your rut arrived earlier?" Hyacine settles on asking. "Any reason you can think of? Maybe a scent that caused it? Or an emotional reaction?" In an instant, her somber expression brightens. She stares at him with wide expectant eyes, lips curved up into a knowing smile. It's like she's seeing through him, waiting for a specific response.

Little Ica zooms over, also watching with waiting eyes.

Pomegranate. Honey. Omega.

Quickly, Phainon responds, "No, none I can think of." He wipes those estranged thoughts out of his mind. "Maybe it's the heat. It's been hotter recently…"

It may be his imagination but he thinks he sees Little Ica roll its eyes. Hyacine sighs, shaking her head as she plants her palm against her forehead. All things considered, he's a little offended.

"Has Lord Mydei spoken to you about anything recently?" Hyacine prods. "How has your relationship been with him?"

"Eh? Mydei? We've been doing good…" A tight smile pulling at the corners of his lip. Or at least, they were. He's not sure what to think nowadays, not with how weird Mydei has been acting. It's hard to tell what Mydei thinks of him, if he's being honest.

Mydei never tells him no. If he has an idea, no matter how preposterous, Mydei always supports him, even if he does have some scathing words to say. But now, Mydei is refusing

him, keeping away as if he's afraid. Only that can't be it because Mydei does not know fear. There's no word for it in the Kremnoan dictionary, he's been told many times.

"Did he mention anything new?" Hyacine asks as she grabs a pack of scent patches from one of her many stocked shelves.

Little Ica makes a loud trilling noise, and Hyacine gestures for the little pegasus to shush.

"Uh, I remember he did tell me that he uses suppressants and scent blockers. I'm surprised there's no reaction yet, but he is more responsible than I am..."

Hyacine tilts her head, and so does Little Ica.

"I mean all of Okhema pretty much knew," Phainon laughs. "An alpha without a scent is the biggest giveaway. He's not Aglaea."

Hyacine laughs, a pinch nervous, while Little Ica gives up and flies back to its original resting spot to take a nap. Seems like the poor pegasus has had enough.

With a shake of her head, Hyacine lowers her voice and says, "Lord Phainon, this is serious. If you can recall any recent changes or any reasons for this sudden early rut then it will be very helpful. I say this as your physician and as your friend. I worry about you and my goal is to help you. This hasn't happened in years…"

Phainon brushes his bangs away from his eyes. Hyacine is aware of his preference for alphas, and his rather embarrassing crush on Mydei. But there's little use in hiding what needs to be said.

"I think an omega triggered it. You must have heard the rumors a few weeks back," Phainon, somehow, manages to say. His heart twists. It's a betrayal of his rational mind against the irrational.

"The rumors regarding Lord Mydeimos?"

Phainon nods. "The omega that Mydei had been with. Her scent is what triggered this early reaction."

He expects her to react with shock. After all, she knows his history, his refusal to be with an omega. He's half right. Her eyes do widen, but what he doesn't expect is for her to look like she's been vindicated.

"..." The corners of Hyacine's lips tremble. She tries to remain straight-faced as she shoves the pack of scent patches into Phainon's hands and turns her head away.

"Hyacine? You okay?"

Hyacine glances back at him and immediately falls into a fit of giggles. She covers her mouth with her hands, but the giggles don't abate. If anything, they grow stronger, louder. Turquoise eyes become hazy with tears as she tries and fails to calm herself down.

“Sorry—” she gasps out. “Sorry… Lord Phainon—Forgive me…” She clutches her stomach, trembling as a loud snort falls from her lips. Even Little Ica jumps at the noise.

Awkwardly, Phainon stands there, holding onto his pack of scent patches. Should he join in? Maybe he should laugh too. The situation would be quite funny if it weren’t so horrifying.

“Perhaps, you should speak with Lord Mydei about your affliction,” Hyacine says in between fits of laughter. She wipes at the edge of her eyes. “It would do you both some good to communicate… Also, stop scenting him. For both your sakes.”

“How do you know about that?”

“Lord Phainon, the question you should be asking is who doesn’t know?”

“...” Ah, he supposes that makes sense. It’s not like he was trying to hide it. Half of the thrill was in the potential of getting caught.

“Tell Lord Mydeimos your rut was triggered by the omega that smells like pomegranate and honey,” Hyacine continues. She slams her hands onto her desk. “Please…” Another giggle. “It’s for your own good that he knows…”

Phainon tries a smile, though it doesn’t quite reach his eyes. Thankfully, Hyacine doesn’t seem to notice, given how she’s busy trying to calm herself down.

Yeah, okay, so he’s going to go up to Mydei, who pointedly told him he didn’t wish to speak about the rumors, and tell him that his early rut was caused by the faceless omega who smells like a particular fruit that Phainon had so gracefully ranted on about. It’s like he’s asking to be punched.

“Can I try the medications again?” Phainon brings up once more. Hyacine easily gave him the patches, but ignored his request for the meds. He understands why, but he wants to try them again. It’s been years. Maybe they’ll work this time.

The effect is immediate. Her laughter falls away and her expression sobers until almost forlorn. “I don’t think it’s worth it, Lord Phainon.”

“ *Please* .” He needs to try. If he can’t get his pheromones under wraps, then he’s as good as screwed. The medications are his best bet. He doesn’t know how long he can last if he’s forced to stick with the patches and lotions.

Even if his body rejects the medications, even if he has to spend days in pain recuperating, he will try. Because, at the end of the day, he has his duties, and he can’t let Okhema down. He can’t afford weakness because Mydei won’t view him as worthy anymore, and he can’t have Aglaea disappointed in him either.

Hyacine eyes him, alarmed. Phainon scrambles to say, “Sorry! I can’t control it… Let me slap on a patch real quick.” He practically shreds the packaging in his haste, leaving bits and pieces of plastic on the floor. “I’ll pick that up in a second…”

Conflicted, Hyacine stands there quietly, watching as Phainon slaps the patches all over his body. She's at war with herself, and Phainon feels a little guilty for putting her in this tough situation. In the end, she acquiesces and silently hands him two trial bottles, each containing a week worth of pills. "Try them, but promise me, you will speak to Lord Mydei before taking them."

"I will," Phainon says. He can breathe again, the weight lifted off his chest. "Thank you."

Silence blankets the room. Phainon stares down at the bottles in his hands, turning them over as he reads the fine print and the giant list of potential side effects. Alpha suppressants and alpha scent blockers—a different formulation than the normal ones sold to normal Okheman citizens. These are modified with Chrysos Heirs in mind and thus have a higher chance of adverse reactions.

Hyacine steps back to her desk and begins scribbling notes down on a piece of paper. He's almost tempted to look over to see what she's writing, but he decides to take a seat next to Little Ica instead. The rotund pegasus stares at him then shakes its head, almost like it's trying to scold Phainon for his antics.

Okay. Now, he feels a little self-conscious.

"How are the villagers?" Phainon asks, changing the subject. "The ones Mydei brought back."

Hyacine blinks. "Oh! They're doing great! Settling in just fine. Minor injuries, if any at all."

"It's a real tragedy what happened to their home," Phainon continues.

Aedes Elysiae never stood a chance. For these villagers to come out relatively unharmed is a miracle. His friends and family weren't so lucky.

Patience is a virtue. Hyacine is practically a saint with how she treats him. With a soft hum, she tells him, "They're doing well and have been moved to the customary temporary apartment complexes. Aglaea is still sorting out the housing situation."

It's as he expects. Good. He can start there. Talking to Mydei is the last resort, even if Hyacine thinks otherwise.

He thanks her for spending precious time on him to which she gives him some kindly but cryptic advice about following his feelings and the importance of honesty in a relationship. There's little reason to think about it too hard, so he doesn't and only says his farewells before stepping outside.

Distracted and in a haste to leave, he nearly crashes into Castorice who jumps back on instinct. The pill bottles and scent patches fly out of his hands, clattering onto the floor.

Clutching tightly onto her pastel purple tote bag, Castorice bows. "Lord Phainon, my apologies."

"No worries," Phainon responds as he bends down to pick up the fallen medications.

Purple eyes shift back and forth. Castorice wrings her hands. “I did not mean to intrude. It was not my intention.”

“Don’t worry about it,” Phainon reassures her with his signature blinding smile. “Hyacine’s in her office right now if you want to see her. Are you here for an appointment?”

Castorice shakes her head. “I simply wished to send my regards to her. She has been working hard and—” She reaches into her bag and pulls out a crocheted plushie, plump, in the shape of a unicorn. “I wanted to give her a gift. It’s not that great because I’m still practicing but…”

“Hyacine will love it!” Phainon reassures, grinning. It doesn’t quite reach his eyes. “The plush looks great! You should give it to her.”

It’ll fit right in with the other colorful plushes Hyacine has. Now, he wonders if Castorice made most of them herself. It looks to be in her style.

Gesturing to the pill bottles in his hands, Castorice asks, “Hyacine gave you those?”

“Maybe they’ll work this time,” Phainon says with a shrug.

“You and I both know your body does not like those.”

In response, Phainon gives a tight smile.

Castorice knows him better than most. She’s witnessed him at his very worst and has never once judged him for it. Likewise, he knows her troubles too. If she had told him that she started taking medications again, he would have flipped out on her, worried for her health and potential adverse reaction to the seemingly innocuous white pills.

Back then he had taken suppressants and scent blockers by the bucketful. Anything to calm the burn inside him, the hatred that had taken route, the physical manifestation of the despair of watching his friends and family reduced to ashes right before his eyes. Only those pills inevitably failed and the backlash had been terrible.

Hyacine is a miracle worker, but even she can’t help him. The medications are risky, prone to failure, but when they work, they work incredibly well. The alternatives do nothing to fight the fire inside him.

“Lord Phainon,” Castorice says, worry tinged in her soft voice. She remains her careful distance away, though she looks as if she wants to reach out and grab him by the shoulder.

“I know my limits,” Phainon responds. “Don’t worry about me.”

As long as he kept his emotions in check, his scent remained pleasant, fragrant like a flourishing spring meadow. An inviting scent he’s been told by many. The years gone by, the days of the old withered away by the tides of time, most of Okhema has no clue of how he used to be.

And of course, Mydei doesn’t know. By the time the Kremnoan detachment arrived, Phainon had perfected his control, his sunny persona. He never planned on deviating from it. If Mydei

knew how he was before, pitifully weak and emotional, then he would have never been regarded as equal.

Only now, he's slipping once more, falling back to old habits. It's only a matter of time before he devolves into how he was when he first arrived in Okhema. Mydei has already grown suspicious, and even Aglaea can't help him if this is to continue.

"Why are you looking for the villagers?" Castorice asks, breaking Phainon out of his prison of thoughts.

"I wish to witness their safety and send my regards." It's half-true, after all. He knows what it's like to be thrown into a new place and expected to mesh in with the greater population while struggling to retain the identity of home.

The answer doesn't sit well with Castorice. Had it been anyone else, they would have believed him. She takes a deep breath and says, " *Lord Phainon* . I understand your sentiments, but you are going behind Lord Mydei's back."

An orange butterfly buzzes by, landing softly on a nearby sunflower. The carved stone fountain trickles a steady stream of crystalline water. It's a nice, beautiful day, all things considered, even if Phainon feels like his world is crumbling beneath his feet.

A touch bitter, Phainon replies, "How am I going behind Mydei's back? I simply wish to speak with the villagers that have been rescued and are now expected to live in Okhema as if their home hadn't been destroyed."

Castorice blinks. Her expression flickers between understanding and exasperation, and her mellow, floral scent begins to wilt.

"Sorry," Phainon quickly says, raising his arms up in surrender. His expression falls, moonlight bangs covering his eyes. "I didn't mean to."

"Lord Phainon, I understand what you're attempting to do. You will not find it," she says, resolute. "Speak with Lord Mydei first, I beg of you."

Hyacine told him that too. That makes the two of them.

Maybe he should, but Mydei made it very clear he doesn't want to talk about any topic related to the rumors. He only hopes Castorice won't tell him. She's not that type of person, so he should be safe in that regard, but still, he can't help but feel uneasy.

The temporary housing complexes are as he remembers—rows of towering white buildings all cut exactly the same. Each complex is stamped with a number, meant to accommodate hundreds of people at a time while Aglaea sorts through finding permanent housing. Situated in the back end of Okhema, there's not much to do in this area outside of a small park and a rocky hiking trail up to the baths.

Phainon had never been housed here. When he first arrived in Okhema, he had been hidden away from the general public and taken to live under Aglaea's strict supervision. After all, what good was there in placing a singular teenager in a complex meant to house tens if not hundreds of survivors.

In the weeks following Aedes Elysiae's destruction, he had wandered aimlessly, cutting down all manner of monsters. Stuck in a trance, he had been consumed by a state of frenzied rut and his body moved on autopilot as he slashed and screamed and fought with all the energy he had left. Aglaea found him in that disheveled, beastly state and brought him to Okhema.

His first few weeks had been under strict lockdown. He remembers his first moments in the eternal holy city, witnessing the giant city-state in all its dawn blessed glory. He had been overwhelmed by the grand marble buildings, the luxurious temples, and cityfolk who held themselves much differently than the humble villagers he grew up with. Emotions still a harrowing mess, he didn't react so well. Uncontrolled pheromones flourished and flooded the surroundings, an oppressive cloud of destruction, hatred, and decay. He had to be sequestered away before he made too much of a scene.

That's how it was back then—his first few months of living in Okhema, thrust into a new world and still reeling from his loss of, well, *everything* . He had no ability to regulate his emotions, not when his every waking and sleeping moment had been consumed by visions of the masked spectre and the blood that dyed his hands red. Adrenaline flooded his system with no signs of reprieve.

In his presence, alphas would grow aggressive, but it was manageable. Betas didn't like his burning scent, but it was more of a nuisance than anything else. With omegas… it was an entirely different story. They were terrified of him, of the oppressive atmosphere that followed him and smothered them in a haze of burning despair and falling ash. Even Castorice reacted negatively to his presence.

There was little he could do to ease the rampage of his mind. He can't fault anyone for reacting to him, but it was a lesson learned that he will never forget. Omegas can't handle him, and it's best to stay a good distance away. He doesn't want anyone to fear him, to be afraid of him for something he has no control over. It's safer this way.

Phainon smiles at the guards, and he's let into the complex without much hassle. Wherever he goes in Okhema, people recognize him and never question his motives. His reputation speaks for itself. After all, he's rescued and brought over his fair share of people.

It doesn't take long to find the village chief, a striking older alpha dressed in ornate, layered robes, who scurries out to greet him. They exchange pleasantries, and Phainon sends his regards. Delighted, the village chief invites him for a cup of specially brewed tea, a village specialty, fragrantly flavored with orange peel and cloves.

It's here that Phainon finds what he's looking for. The village chief reveals to him the most pertinent of information, the identity behind the scent that permeated Mydei's body and lay the basis for the rumors. Bitterness settles in his throat as the chief speaks.

"I promised my daughter to Lord Mydeimos. She has left my side, and I have not seen her since the day we entered Okhema's gates."

Confused, Phainon sets his teacup down with a loud clink.

… *What?*

There's no way he's heard correctly.

"Excuse me, to reiterate, you sent your daughter to marry Mydei?"

"Indeed, I have." The chief strokes his beard in contemplation. His deep brown eyes crinkle with pride. "Lord Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos is a worthy alpha, and my daughter is an unmated omega of age. As a show of thanks, I offered him her hand. He will protect her well, and she will provide him with bountiful pups."

Eh? The cogs in his brain spin to a halt. Okay, he's known that Mydei has had relations with a faceless omega, but for him to agree to marry her?! What in the Kephale is going on?!

No. He's jumping to conclusions. He needs to calm down.

"Lord Phainon?" the village chief questions. "I hope I did not offend."

Phainon scrambles for a response. "You did not! I was only in thought. Of course, it is without a doubt true that Mydei is a great warrior and protector of Okhema." A stilted laugh falls from his lips. "And… uh, Mydei accepted?"

The chief takes a deep sip of his spiced tea. "Indeed he did and laid out some terms of agreement. She is to be housed with the Kremnoans, and I will not be able to visit her or ask about her. It is a worthy sacrifice to secure her future. I have no qualms." He seems very unbothered for someone that practically sold his daughter off, and it rubs Phainon the wrong way.

Incredulous, he asks, "And you accepted?" Probably not the best thing to say, but it slips out before he can control himself.

Already, he's heating up, the familiar curl of anger brewing in his stomach. It's unsightly and immature, but the flames are fanned by his desire to have Mydei as his and only his. The idea of Mydei with someone else doesn't sit well with him no matter how much he tries to convince himself otherwise.

"Yes," the chief hums. "My daughter must fulfill her omegan duties as childbearer. It is an honor for her to serve the crown prince."

This is getting to be too much. Caged in like this, the beige walls of the communal kitchen caving in on him, he can hardly breathe. It feels like he's been kicked in the crotch and

slapped in the face at the same time. And then ran over repeatedly.

He almost wants to ask the chief if his daughter smells of pomegranates and honey when she's in pre-heat, but he stops himself short. Regardless of Kremnoan mating customs, it's an invasion of privacy to reveal that he, and the rest of Okhema, has smelled his daughter in such a vulnerable state.

The rest of the conversation happens in a blur. He keeps the confident, lax smile plastered onto his face, regardless of the twitching of his facial muscles, and continues running through pleasantries until it's time to say his farewells. He's barely touched his tea and decides to down it in one go. The cloying spice helps distract him from the ache in his chest, if only for a little while.

Truly, if this is the case, then Mydei's been lying to him this entire time. Phainon previously believed he knew Mydei, knew his beliefs, his thoughts, everything. Only now he realizes that he doesn't because never would he have thought that Mydei would agree to such a ludicrous request. Perhaps he needs to argue with the other alpha over the prospects of opening his worldview and forgoing old tradition. Potentially over a spar. Two birds, one stone.

The day continues on. Phainon feels the energy drained out of him. He's tired. So very tired.

When he steps once more into Kephale's dawn, he can finally breathe again. The light spring breeze feels good against his feverish skin as he airs out his stuffy collar. He takes the familiar path home only to find Aglaea waiting beneath the shade of an olive tree, her arms crossed against her chest.

Cloaked head to toe in the purest of gold, Aglaea is blinding to look at head on. Her appearance is striking and has Phainon's heart skipping a beat. Damn it. He's been caught.

Before he can get even a word in, Aglaea says, "I heard the commotion. Walk with me to the baths." She turns and heads off.

Phainon scurries after her, feeling much like a child about to be scolded by his mother. Aglaea calmly strides forward, and Phainon matches her step, nervousness creeping in with each foot forward. They pass through snaking marble corridors, silent save for the clacking of their boots against stone.

The pills rattle in his pockets. His skin chafes against the patch on his nape as it rubs against his tender skin. He had been under the false illusion that this day couldn't possibly get worse only to be slammed in the head with Mydei agreeing to marry someone who isn't him.

Phainon deflates.

Who is he kidding… Mydei practically rejected him outright a few days ago.

Together, he and Aglaea enter Marmoreal Palace, amidst the tall domed ceiling, the rushing water of the baths, and the lax gossip of the bathgoers. The change is immediate. All eyes are

on the two of them. Aglaea pays them no mind, but chills creep down Phainon's spine at the unwanted attention.

Once they reach the safety of the Hero's Bath, Aglaea says, "Phainon, I have already told you the rumors about Mydei are false. For what reason did you want to visit the villagers?"

"I wished to send my regards. And see for myself how the villagers are faring." An easy, practiced response.

Crystalline eyes regard him. Phainon gulps.

Lying to Aglaea is never a good idea, yet he still tries—and fails—to bend the truth. It's a terrible habit he needs to break especially because Aglaea knows everything. Her golden threads reach every crevice of Okhema, covering the city in an invisible net of gold.

"I did not hallucinate that omegan scent," Phainon says, taking a deep breath to calm his nerves. "Even if it's false, I want to meet the chief's daughter. To confirm for myself."

Patient as always, Aglaea effortlessly answers, "She is not the omega in the rumors." Her heels clack against the marble steps as her gaze trails the stream of shimmering golden water. She turns back to Phainon and softly says, "You don't believe me."

"The chief told me he promised her to Mydei and that he agreed to marry her."

"That is what he told you?" Aglaea asks.

"Yes." He didn't hear wrong. Oh how he wishes he did, but the man's deep, gravelly voice plays on loop. The shimmery water beckons him to jump in, if only to quiet the incessant buzzing in his head.

"From your conversation with the chief, how do you feel about him?"

Phainon's brows furrow in thought. "Erm… Uh, he's a traditional man who reflects the values of his village?"

"And what do you know about Mydei?" she asks gently.

"That he, erm, also agrees with those traditional values?" A pause. "No… that's not right… Uh…"

Aglaea shakes her head. "Let me tell you the truth of the situation. Mydei agreed with the chief as a way to safely send her over to me. She is not living with the Kremnoans and has no further relations with him. Instead of attempting to dig for information behind his back, I implore you to speak with Mydei yourself and have an honest conversation."

Ouch. That hurts a little. Phainon laughs it off.

It's a little strange seeing how Hyacine and Castorice both told him to speak with Mydei. Now add Aglaea into the equation. Are they conspiring together?

Okay, so now he's expected to reveal that he went into rut because of the omega who may or may not be the chief's daughter and that he went behind Mydei's back to ask about said omega when he promised to not bring up the topic anymore. Great. How is he even supposed to start that conversation without it derailing completely? He only hopes Mydei doesn't hate him afterwards.

"I'll speak to Mydei." His expression falls, blue eyes downcast. "But I don't know if he's open to responding to my questions. He's been hiding from me…"

It hurts to think that he doesn't know Mydei as well as he thought he did. These years of camaraderie, have they shown Mydei nothing? That even now, he still can't be fully trusted? His fists clench at his sides. It's pathetic really. To think he's holding onto these feelings, allowing them to consume him.

"Do you like him for him or because he's an alpha?" Aglaea questions.

Though his heart clenches, his answer is immediate. "I like him because he's Mydei."

Aglaea's lips curl into a soft smile, pleased by his response. For a moment, he's in shock. He hasn't seen that type of expression on her face in awhile, not with the heavy burden of the flamechase and her faltering humanity. Her next words come out gentle, reassuring. "Very good. Keep that in mind when you speak with him. Also, don't take those medications. Hyacine may have given them to you, but they will only hamper you. Speak with Mydei, and all will be clear."

Phainon sighs. "Alright, I'll try. If that's what it comes down to…"



The jealousy continues to burn. He tries to push it down. When that doesn't work, he tries to ignore it by thinking of literally anything else. It's like putting out a fire with gasoline.

He can barely control his pheromones as is. Any more of this, and he's probably going to have to hole himself in his house for the rest of time.

Speak with Mydei they all say. What is he supposed to speak to Mydei about? That he agreed to marry an omega and didn't tell him? If he brings it up, then he'll have to admit that he went behind Mydei's back to ask. Oh, boy. That's not the conversation he wants to have, not when he's terribly unsure of how Mydei feels about him.

But he has to. He only needs to find the right time for it.

He stalks his way through the city on his path back home, taking the familiar path that cuts through the middle of the city. It's probably not the best idea, but he wants to return as soon

as he can.

The cityfolk pause to stare at him. He's not leaking any pheromones, or at least he shouldn't be, but the stomp of his boots and his flat expression isn't helping him blend into the background.

"Hey, rascal," Cipher calls out, casually leaning against the stone railing. Her sharp gaze trails up and down his body like she's attempting to scour for his weak points.

"Cipher," Phainon greets evenly. He doesn't even try to smile this time. "You're back early."

Cipher grins, showing off her sharp canines. "Couldn't resist the temptation. Okhema is how I remember. Beautiful. Warm. Nothing like the evernight." Regardless of how light and airy her tone is, he can detect the bitterness hidden beneath. A touch of wistfulness.

"It's great. Really nice out here," Phainon responds. He only needs to pass two more blocks before he's finally back home.

"Look here, loverboy," she says, twirling around a familiar golden ring.

Phainon freezes. His blood runs cold.

"Where did you get that?" he asks, stepping forward. The last thing he wants is to deal with this right now.

"Swiped it from Chartonus when he wasn't looking," Cipher winks. "He's been holding onto it for quite some time now… I couldn't resist. Why, this can sell for a fortune!"

Phainon sighs and stretches his arm out. "Give it."

A long while ago, he and Chartonus hatched a plan to fish up Queen Gorgo's ring and had succeeded. He had given the small golden ring to the blacksmith for safe keeping, faltering between wanting Chartonus to hand it over to Mydei or build enough courage to do it himself. In between his busy schedule and the hectic mess that's been his life for the past few weeks, he's forgotten entirely.

"Oh, but I went through so much effort to grab this!" Cipher pouts as she fits the ring onto her index finger. Her eyes glint beneath the shade of the stone pillars. "You're quite the antique collector… Why, this might just be the best piece in your collection!"

"You've never seen my collection." Unless she's broken into his house. Oh, no—

Cipher grins. Her white tail swishes lazily behind her. "You leave your housekeys in that hideous red vase that you paid way too much money for."

"..." Mydei did tell him to hide it somewhere else. Maybe he should have listened.

Cipher leans forwards, her kaleidoscope blue eyes curving in amusement as she looks up at Phainon. Soft and low, she murmurs, "You know, I could potentially be persuaded to give it back…"

Phainon sighs. “What do you want?”

“Hm… What do I want?” Cipher tilts her head, grey bangs falling over her eyes, and lifts the ring up high. She rolls it around in her fingers, lips curving into a smirk as she watches it shine in the bright dawn.

The ring is impeccable. Made of the purest of gold and carved by the finest blacksmiths of Castrum Kremnos. It’s a symbol of the Kremnoan empire, a statement of power, of unrelenting will and defying fate.

“It’s for Mydei,” Phainon admits.

“Mmm…” she perks up at the mention. “The little lion.”

Little? Phainon blinks. Lion, yes, but little?

“I have yet to meet him.” Cipher jumps onto the ornate marble railing and lies against the carved pillar with her arms stretched behind her head. “From what I’ve heard, he’s quite the interesting figure. The talk of the town. An *alpha* like him must be a real catch.” She purrs out the word alpha, lips curving and kaleidoscope eyes glinting as if she’s been told a great joke and is trying not to laugh.

Her gaze is on him, eagerly awaiting response. There’s not much he can say, but the unpleasant feeling in his gut returns full force. She’s only trying to mock him, he knows that much, but any mention of Mydei has him on edge.

A bored sigh falls from Cipher’s lips as she rolls her eyes. She turns her head to the side and mumbles what sounds like another insult. Something regarding the alarming amount of empty space he has in his head?

Phainon fights the urge to growl at her. It’s inappropriate. He’s not that type of alpha.

With a yawn and a wide stretch, Cipher says, “I have some business to take care of… Selling this on the black market sounds like so much work!”

“There’s a black market?” Phainon questions.

“Innocent boy! It’s like you were born yesterday… Of course there is! Lots going on in the black market! It’s extensive too, a whole affair. I could get into the specifics but it’d take me all day, and I really rather not!”

Quick as lightning, she jumps off the railing and appears in front of him. She beckons him closer then whispers, “But… there are lots of priceless, never before seen antiques going around if you know where to look.”

The mention of antiques has him perking up like an attention-starved puppy when its owner returns home after a long day at work. Cipher laughs.

“But… that’s besides the point. I’m not here to dally. I’m busy, after all! Let me cut to the chase, boy. I’ve been hearing what’s been going on. Got cold feet?”

“I have no clue what you’re talking about. Can I get the ring back?”

It’s surprising how empty this part of the city is. Normally, there would be crowds of people passing through. Why are there none today?

“I really didn’t want to intervene but it seems like I have to! The situation is so much more dire than I expected! I better be paid double for my troubles…” she pouts, pressing a finger against her lip as she bends forwards.

“Intervene what?” He’s definitely missing something. Everyone has been acting so cryptic lately. He’s starting to feel a little left out.

“Wow, I thought you were smarter, but I guess I was wrong. No clue what Aglaea sees in you…” Cipher murmurs with a small huff. “My bad! My bad!”

She knows something he doesn’t or it could be another one of her many tricks. Cipher has never liked him, and Phainon can guess why given her history with Aglaea. It makes him wonder why she’s staying so far away from Okhema, but she must have her reasons and he rather not delve too deeply into it. It’s not his business.

“Put aside your biases for a moment and *think*. Really *think*.” Phainon opens his mouth to respond but Cipher shushes him and continues, “I wish I could tell it to your face, but it’s all about the journey and not the destination. All you need is that little push and off you go!”

The ring flies through the air, and he catches it.

With a wink, Cipher says, “You know what to do with it, boy.”

Then she’s gone. Disappeared without a single trace.

Chapter End Notes

me slapping yall with phainon’s backstory 🤭 he’s crash out king but he has his reasons (kind of)

thanks for reading! 💞

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Mydei's gaze sweeps yet over another new recruit. This time, it's a dainty female omega with snow-pale skin and sweet, doe-like features. Her body is willowy and soft, seemingly incapable of wielding a weapon, but looks are deceiving. The fire of determination blazes in her hazel eyes, and she fights furiously, swinging her blade with vengeance—her movements quick like a flash of lightning and merciless like a trained mercenary. She'd be fit as an assassin, hiding away in the dark of the evernight and striking like a viper when the moment calls for it.

But even with her prowess, it doesn't escape Mydei how the other soldiers eye her like she's a piece of meat they can sink their fangs into and tear apart. He almost wants to shield her from their view, but she regards him as she does the other alpha soldiers, with a type of hesitant respect and wide distance, suspicious towards his every move. Only with Krateros is she honest and open, her eyes glittering as she speaks with loud fervor to the man that has become her mentor. Mydei can't fault her for her reaction towards him. He's sure the rumors about him being a heartbreaker and promiscuous alpha must have come into play.

The Kremnoan training hall is no longer populated by only pheromone ridden alphas and silent betas. In the past week, the ranks have ballooned, and now, there are over ten new omega trainees. A rather strange turn of events if Mydei has anything to say about it. He had previously believed Iavokos to be the sole exception to the rule, but Krateros has been steadily recruiting more omegas, both male and female. Even weirder is how Krateros trains them personally, overseeing their progress, while not allowing any of the other instructors to intervene. It almost feels personal, targeted.

The temptation to ask is there, but Mydei refrains. He can't jump to conclusions, even if his curiosity grows with each passing interaction, especially when Krateros speaks proudly about the young omega soldiers. It's very strange, and Mydei doesn't even know how to begin to react to the rapid change of events.

Given his reputation and wisdom from years of hard battle, Krateros is second in command of the Kremnoan army. As such, no one dares to speak up against him or do anything drastic to upset the status quo, though the tension in the hall speaks volumes. Mydei bears witness to fervent whisperings, hungry gazes, and snide comments.

It's nearing the end of ascent hour. Mydei circles the hall, boots clicking against the stone floor. A few meters away, he spots two soldiers whispering amongst each other as they glance over at the group of omega recruits doing stretches.

"Is Krateros going senile? Recruiting these bitches and ruining the sanctity of Kremnoan tradition…" the first alpha soldier mutters to his companion.

The second one takes a big swig of water and chuckles. “Don’t worry, I’m sure Krateros brought them in as stress relief. After all, Okheman brothels lack the beauty of Kremnoan omegas. I call dibs on the blonde one with the wide hips and fat ass.”

Luckily, the training hall is a ruckus of shouts and the loud clanging of tempered metal against metal. It takes minimal effort to sneak behind the two gossiping soldiers.

Crossing his arms tightly across his chest, Mydei asks, “What are we talking about here?”

Both alphas jump, far too engrossed with their conversation on which omega would cry and moan the loudest to notice the crown prince approaching.

“Your highness! It is an honor,” the first one greets, bowing deeply. His fingers twitch at his sides. “We were merely taking a break and will be back to training soon. Glory to Castrum Kremnos!”

The second one nods along, fingers turning white from how tightly he’s gripping his water jug. “Thank you for checking up on us, your highness.”

Mydei fixes them with a cold, flat expression. “A break is meant to clear the mind, not create greater turmoil. Speak more of your inappropriate nonsense, and I will send you both to Krateros. Do I make myself clear?”

Both soldiers squeak out weak apologies, flimsy excuses that hold no weight. Mydei almost wants to snarl at them and slam them both into the ground. Fortunately, he has self-restraint, even if his fingers curl at his sides. There’s no need to make a scene. He will alert Krateros of the matter, though he’s sure the older alpha already knows.

The new omega recruits are made to wear scent patches and lotions, hiding away their pheromones from the other soldiers. It’s not a shock, even if it does feel unfair. After all, Kremnoan alphas wear their scents like a badge of honor, while Kremnoan omegas are hidden away, their bodies and scents deemed as a distraction.

Mydei sits outside, the breeze blowing at his blonde hair and jingling his metal ornaments. He places a silent hand on his nape, rubbing at the pristine skin. Beneath the cool shade of the olive tree, he stares down at his wrists where his scent glands lay hidden under the dark leather and heavy gold plating of his gauntlets. If it comes down to it and the medications stop working, then he’d be forced to wear the scent patches as well. He doesn’t quite know the logistics of wearing them nor how to properly layer on neutralizing lotion, but it seems like quite the hassle. Won’t combat and sweating cause the patches to peel and the lotions to slough off?

From how some of the recruits scratch at their neck, it must be very uncomfortable. Phainon didn’t seem pleased to have to wear them either, and he wonders why the alpha had taken to them again.

It’s only midday. He’s been here since the first quint of entry hour, circling around the hall and speaking with fellow soldiers and giving demonstrations. Kremnoan soldiers rise early,

beginning the day at the very crack of dawn and ending in the dark hours of the night. Or at least, that's how it had been back when the sun still rose and fell in the sky.

The month of plenty flourishes upon Okhema, Kephale's dawn beaming brighter than ever. Not the most welcome change, given how hot his body has been running lately, his mind a mess of distraction.

The past few days have been peaceful. Too peaceful. Without Phainon here with his endless antics and penchant for acting strange, Mydei has been left to his own devices. Whether it's the Deliverer's fault or not, he feels prickly all over in the worst way possible, almost like he's an addict experiencing withdrawal.

He almost wants to bury his head in his hands and scream. Though he tries to forget, he can't —the horrific slip in his behavior. He had been in a daze at the baths, his body moving on its own, his mind blurred with only the sticky desire to *claim.* If he hadn't caught himself in time, Phainon would have found out. After all, he had been leaking slick all over, gushing like a waterfall. If it hadn't been for the safety of the warm water surrounding them, it would have been an easy giveaway of his true nature.

With a low sigh, Mydei rolls his shoulders, easing the tension out of his muscles. He rises and strides back into the crowded training hall. The soldiers greet him once more, standing at attention, and he finds that he's starting to heavily dislike the attentiveness and the prying eyes.

It's why he doesn't visit as much as he used to.



By the third quint of action hour, Mydei debates heading home early. He's a little annoyed at having to deal with the noxious cloud of alpha pheromones that permeates the entirety of the hall, and he's shocked that the omega recruits seem to take it with no complaint. They're also beginning to get a little anxious, but none of them speak a word of objection even as their movements grow more sloppy and unrehearsed.

He trains with them, guards them from the gazes of the other soldiers. While Krateros doesn't allow the other alpha instructors anywhere near the omega recruits, he's given free reign to do whatever he wishes. The difference is obvious, but Mydei chalks it up to his status and not the very likely reality that Krateros has already seen through him.

"Keep up the good work," Mydei calls out. He much prefers these recruits. They lack the arrogance that many alphas naturally have and are willing to learn.

He should leave but the thought of returning to an empty, cold villa keeps him stationed in the hall. Only a day prior, Castorice had been sent off on an urgent mission to investigate a

rumor regarding the coreflame of Oronyx, promising that she would be back before the Chrysos Heirs gathering. She texted him this morning, sending him a selfie of her out in the ruins of the evernight, telling him that the mission had been going smoothly and she was set to return home soon.

The quiet calm of the villa reminds him much of his home in the Kremnoan district. It's a little alarming how quickly he's grown used to her comfort and warmth, her wildflower scent and gentle, melodic voice. Living with someone who understands him and does not judge him, someone who he can freely speak his mind with, has been surreal. Not even with Phainon can he be his honest self. There's a thin barrier that separates them. Equals, they are said to be. But if they were true equals then why does Mydei feel so *inferior* ? It's not like him to think so irrationally. Never has he doubted himself like this.

He speaks with Krateros, going over the progress of the soldiers. The older alpha's gravelly voice draws back memories of his early years following his re-entry into civilization. Krateros had raised him, a feral child, taught and trained him to be the prince he is today.

The conversation progresses as usual with Mydei giving his input when necessary, only to witness the moment the older alpha's expression grows grave, lips drawn to a tight line. Mydei briefly wonders if he's done something to upset the older man only to turn and be greeted with the familiar sight of moonlight hair and dazzling blue eyes.

Ah. That explains it.

"Hey," Phainon waves as he saunters towards them. Around him, the soldiers pause, some sneering, others in thin-veiled curiosity. It's always like this. The sight of Okhema's golden boy draws attention wherever he goes, especially in the Kremnoan district where most are still wary of Okhemans at large.

"Do not 'hey' the crown prince," Krateros snaps.

"Oh. My apologies!" With a low, exaggerated bow, Phainon says, "Greetings, your highness, blessed crown prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos. Will you allow me the grace of your awe-inspiring presence?"

Mydei's eye twitches. Krateros' hand lands on his leather scabbard.

"You have some nerve showing up here," Mydei says, crossing his arms defensively over his chest. His heart flutters incessantly—the sight of Phainon threatening the calm he's built for the past few days.

Phainon grins, and Mydei finds that he wants to bolt, run as far away as he can to escape the memories of the baths—of his vulnerabilities. Only he can't. Not when he's surrounded by his countrymen who view any slip as weakness to exploit.

"Wasn't easy, I'll tell you that. Almost got stabbed like thirty times! Someone even charged at me!" Phainon laughs, his voice as cheery and vibrant as ever. Moonlight hair is mussed from the spring breeze, looking soft enough to run his hands through. Mydei's fingers twitch at his sides.

“I wanted to talk.” His smooth voice lowers as he glances around at the Kremnoans who are advancing towards him for daring to get close to their prince. “Or not… Actually, probably not.” Phainon raises his arms in mock surrender.

Mydei stretches his arm out as a warning and the advancing soldiers stop. “You could have texted me. It would have made things easier for you.”

“I wanted to see you,” Phainon says earnestly, and it causes Mydei’s traitorous heart to skip a beat. “Besides, you barely look at your texts. I have to wait for hours sometimes… I wanted to speak to you directly. Your angry expression makes my day, you know.”

“Hmph.” Mydei turns away, ignoring the prickle that settles on his nape and the warmth that begins to spike his body. He’s not the best at answering texts, that’s true, and his teleslate is delegated as a distraction. Whenever he arrives at the training hall, he places it away so he’s not tempted to scroll and watch videos of hypereactive chimeras chasing after butterflies. Now that he’s grown close with Castorice, she has a penchant for sending him cute video after video.

“Mydei?” Phainon questions, stepping forwards. He almost reaches out to grab Mydei by the shoulder only to be stopped by Krateros blocking him off.

Mydei chews his bottom lip. Not having a suitable sparring partner has its downsides, he’s learned the hard way. Even a day without sparring Phainon has his muscles twitching in protest, itching for a worthy battle. He tilts his chin up, giving off an air of arrogance, and challenges, “Fight me, Deliverer. If you win, then we’ll talk. If you lose, then get out.”

“Here?” Phainon asks, surveying the surroundings with a raise of an eyebrow.

“Are you chickening out? I never took you for a coward.”

“I’m not. It’s just—” Phainon blocks a punch and yells. “Hey! At least let me finish!”

Mydei rolls his eyes and throws out another kick.

"Why are you like this?" Phainon sighs as he knocks Mydei's leg away.

They clash in a flurried frenzy.

Phainon is quick to recover his wits, effortlessly trading blow after blow. Outside of his alarming, almost inhuman strength, he’s also light on his feet, graceful like a practiced dancer.

Given how often they spar, they quickly fall into a familiar rhythm, bodies moving in tandem. A circle of soldiers begins to gather around them, everyone clamoring to take a look at the two clashing Chrysos Heirs. Even with Krateros yelling to get back to training, no one moves from their spot, too entranced to care about the potential consequences.

Mydei’s vision narrows, his focus entirely on the alpha in front of him. It’s moments like these where he finds himself most alive, most *free*. His breathing quickens, adrenaline alight in his veins as he dodges a kick and returns with an uppercut that’s swiftly parried. Each

punch sends reverberations through the earth and brings about loud cheers from the crowd. Mydei snarls as he lunges at Phainon, and Phainon, infuriating as always, opens his mouth, sharp fangs glinting as he grins.

That singular moment marks his downfall. Mydei, for reasons unknown, stalls in his step. His nape tingles and saliva begins to pool. In an instant, before he can even register it, he's swept off balance with Phainon landing on top of him, caging him in. Muscled thighs spread on either side of his body, and Phainon's gloved hands grip his forearms tightly, effortlessly forcing him flat onto the floor.

Blue eyes stare. A pause and a heavy breath. Phainon presses down, keeping Mydei's arms pinned to beside his head.

His vision wobbles from where he landed on the floor, and his heart thunders wildly in his chest. Golden eyes are half-lidded, dark and syrupy, as Mydei lays there, catching his breath. He turns his head to the side.

What just happened? His mind is a blur, and with Phainon looming over him like this, a shadow cast over his brilliant features and causing his blue eyes to glow, Mydei shivers, unable to move or even attempt to struggle.

"I win," Phainon smiles. His gaze flickers down, landing on Mydei's lips, and he slowly, agonizingly leans closer.

Hot. Phainon's warmth is blistering. His thighs quiver and begin to grow wet, and a blush blooms on his cheeks, regardless of how hard he's trying not to stare up at the alpha. Behind him, the soldiers shout and roar.

"*Haikas,* " Mydei murmurs, trembling beneath Phainon's grasp. It's dangerous to be this close, not after what had transpired in the baths.

Like a man possessed, Phainon continues to lean in. His golden pupils narrow to pinpricks.

He hears whispering. One soldier says something about Kremnoan courting rituals, and the flush deepens on Mydei's already warm cheeks. In the days of the old, alpha alpha claiming normally happened like this: a duel, a challenge amongst a crowd of clamoring onlookers. The winner took all.

Thinking about it has goosebumps rising on his skin. Losing to Phainon and in front of his people no less should be an embarrassment, but he can't help the excitement of being pinned down like this. Only, Phainon's scent is still missing, smothered by the patches and the thick lotion that glistens on his skin.

And Phainon being Phainon has no clue of what's going on nor why the soldiers are whispering so fervently. Krateros hovers, ready to yank the alpha off if he has to, a deep growl emitting from his throat, a warning.

"Get off me, Deliverer," Mydei huffs out. He hates how weak he sounds, nothing like his usually confident timbre. Only Phainon can make him act so off-center.

They’re nearly nose to nose. Mydei’s eyes flutter shut in anticipation of what's to come.

“I miss you,” Phainon murmurs, blue eyes twinkling like the brightest stars, stealing Mydei's breath away. “I want to be by your side again, so stop avoiding me, Mydei.”

“I’m not avoiding you,” Mydei murmurs back. In this compromising position, with his blonde hair fanned around him, face flushed pink and neck bared, he appears much like a bullied omega maiden. “Deliverer…”

The world begins to narrow and blur. Something in Mydei cries out for Phainon’s touch. His thighs grow even more sticky. He wants Phainon so badly, it begins to hurt. He wants Phainon to kiss him already, for Phainon to claim him and make him his—

Phainon lets go of Mydei’s arms and stands up. Fresh air floods Mydei’s lungs and his eyes snap open, staring blankly upwards at Phainon’s extended hand.

The soldiers continue to murmur amongst each other. Krateros once again yells at them to return to training unless they wish to run laps all night, and that’s when they finally begin to scatter.

His face burns, and his nape continues to tingle, soft pinpricks against his skin. Slowly, he picks himself up, ignoring Phainon’s hand as he dusts himself off. He hopes the tremble of his thighs isn't obvious.

This is terrible. He slipped again. It’s been happening more often as of late, and it’s concerning. Another visit to Hyacine is in order.

“Since when do Kremnoans accept omegas as soldiers?” Phainon questions, raising an eyebrow. His gaze trails over to the group of omegas that are not-so-subtly staring at them both, and Mydei has to stop himself short from snarling at them to get back to training and that Phainon is his.

“It was Krateros’ idea,” Mydei says, running a hand through his damp locks. “You look surprised.”

“I am,” Phainon replies. He flashes the recruits a wide grin. “I didn’t expect it, but it’s a good development. Okhema needs to follow in Kremnoan example.”

Mydei tilts his head. “I thought you didn’t like omegas.”

“Huh? My dear Mydei, what does liking omegas have to do with this? I respect omegas as people, even if I don’t prefer them as partners.”

“Hmph.” Mydei turns away, ignoring the bitterness that settles in the back of his throat. “What did you want to talk about?”

A group of rowdy children dash around, smiling widely beneath the brilliant dawn as they chase each other with wooden swords. Today, they gather to act out a scene from a classic fairytale of love, triumph, and devotion.

Waving around his sword, one boy proclaims himself the main character, the valiant hero Perseus who will save the beautiful princess Andromeda from being sacrificed to the merciless sea. Another boy roars, cackling loudly that he's the evil tentacle monster that will eat the princess. He wiggles his arms around, acting akin to a squid, causing the other kids to giggle.

Amidst the shouting and laughter, Mydei smiles, his gaze softening as he looks on from where they're seated. Even his own dislike of sea monsters can't dampen the joyous mood. Phainon had wanted to speak over refreshments, so they're here in this rather posh cafe, lounging around beneath a shaded umbrella as they sip cold drinks and snack on crumbly cookies and decadent desserts.

Leaning against his elbow, Phainon stares at Mydei, his expression sweet as the honey lemonade in Mydei hands. He watches Mydei in silence, his gaze burning a hole where it lands. Moonlight bangs fall messily over his eyes, a content smile gracing his lips.

It's a nice day to relax. The cafe plays soft classical music. Mydei takes a sip of his iced drink.

"So… Have you ever thought about marriage?"

Mydei blinks. "What."

Leave it up to Phainon to shatter the peace and quiet.

"Like… marrying someone. Settling down and having pups—Y'know the whole deal… You're a prince and all… so there's that whole continuing the bloodline and…" Phainon trails off. His expression flickers. He opens his mouth once more to say something only to stop in his tracks.

"That's not feasible," Mydei replies as he swirls his cup around. "We both know that."

Phainon sighs and brushes his bangs away from his eyes. "Yes, but don't think about that."

"Is this seriously what you wanted to talk about?" Mydei scoffs, raising an eyebrow, to which Phainon gives a fervent nod.

Okay. Mydei neglects to think too hard. Had this been any other situation, he wouldn't have humored Phainon for asking such a preposterous question, but unfortunately, he lost the spar and made a fool of himself in front of his countrymen. He would have won had it not been

for Phainon distracting him with his big blue eyes and sharp fangs that would pierce his skin just right—Mydei pushes that stupid thought away and focuses on his ideal future.

Unconsciously, his gauntleted hand lands on his abdomen, stroking softly. He stares down at the bare skin, flat and carved with toned muscle. Until now, it never fully registered. He has a womb. He can bear children.

The thought of a babe growing and kicking around in his belly. His golden eyes glimmer, a small curve to his lips as he envisions a life where he's no longer buried beneath expectation.

He'd like that. Raising a family of his own. If the circumstances had been different, he could imagine a family for himself—a family he never had, one filled with love and laughter and so much *joy.*

Cradling a baby in his arms, singing to it soft lullabies. Treating his child with all the love and affection he had never gotten, tossed away into the sea of souls and left to drown. He would make sure his baby would never have to go through the terrors that he went through.

The child would gurgle, brilliant blue eyes crinkling at the edges as Mydei boops its nose. It would look like its father, charming with a shock of moonlight hair. A spoiled little thing with chubby, grabby hands and a contagious giggle.

Try as he might, the baby only appears with moonlight hair and blue eyes, reminiscent of a certain Deliverer. He wants *Phainon's* babies.

Oh titans. The revelation is almost too much. He's falling, and there's no one to save him.

"Uh, Mydei?" Phainon questions, reaching out to poke Mydei's shoulder.

Mydei blinks, and his arm falls back to his side. Yes?"

"You alright? Do you have an upset stomach? Did the pastries do you in? I admit, they're tasty but a bit heavy for my tastes…" Phainon babbles on, regarding Mydei with his signature innocent and idiotic expression.

The urge to slap him grows exponentially, especially because Phainon has the audacity to tilt his head and blink expectantly at him with those owlish eyes of his. Before Mydei acts on his urges, he replies, "I'd like to have children and start a family. Does that answer your question?"

The corners of Phainon's lips quiver. He pulls his arm back and gently asks, "Do you have anyone in mind?"

"..." *You.*

But he can't admit that. Not after that whole scene he caused at the baths. And besides, Phainon doesn't like omegas, and he *especially* doesn't like Mydei's scent. Their relationship will never progress the way Mydei wants it to.

Even if he has to continue to hide, he will do it. He's deceiving Phainon every step of the way, but what else is he to do? Even if Phainon says he respects omegas as people, many in Okhema do not, especially not his own countrymen.

"A specific omega perhaps?" Phainon prods. He picks up a piece of baklava, careful not to drop any crumbs of pistachio, before taking a big bite. He gives a little wince and chases it down with some iced water.

Mydei's mood sours even more. Phainon is stubborn as stubborn can be. Has he ever given any inclination that he likes omegas? Or that he's an alpha? He doesn't know if it's a blessing or a curse that Phainon believes him to be an alpha along with the rest of Okhema, but a lump grows in his throat knowing that Phainon would never desire him if he found out the truth.

"No. I don't have anyone in mind."

Like a flower in the heat of summer, Phainon wilts. He chews on his lower lip and asks, "Are you sure? Not even a single omega has caught your eye? I find that very difficult to believe, my dear prince." Blue eyes search him, digging for any clue. Only there is none. It's a meaningless effort.

"This is a useless conversation. Either you say what you mean to say or drop it." Mydei twirls his straw before crushing it in his grip. He looks up, golden eyes narrowed and lips pursed into a flat line. "If this is about the rumors, I told you they are hearsay and mean nothing."

It's the wrong thing to say because Phainon's jaw clenches. "I didn't hallucinate that scent, Mydei. Who is it?"

"Why are you so hung up on that?"

Stop asking. Stop. Please.

"I have my reasons."

"What reasons could you possibly have? You said you don't like their scent. Why seek it out?" Mydei asks, his voice pitching louder. He reigns himself in, tells himself to relax, even if his hands ball into fists, sharp, gauntleted fingers digging into the meat of his palm.

"I simply wish to know who she is. It's not that hard of a question. I backed down last time out of respect for you, my dear prince, but I want answers."

Infuriating. Stubborn. Idiotic.

Mydei sees red. Something snaps. If Phainon so desperately wants an answer, he'll get one.

"I fucked an omega during my most recent mission and brought her back so I could fuck her some more," Mydei sneers. "There. Happy?"

The cafe's patrons pause. In an instant, all conversation ceases and all eyes are on him. The poor waitress that had been on her way to their table inadvertently drops her glass jug,

splattering a mess of shards and water all over the floor.

Fuck.

His heart thunders in his chest, exacerbated by the silence in the cafe. As quickly as it flourished, the anger recedes like the tides on a hot summer's day. Even the children nearby have noticed the change in atmosphere, pausing their play and staring over in curiosity.

Mydei swallows the lump in his throat. He mutters out a quick apologies to the flustered waitress before stomping away in a hurry. He doesn't run. No. He strides off as quickly as he can, ignoring the burn in the corner of his eyes. No tears fall. He hasn't cried in forever, and he doesn't think he ever will again.

The crawl of shame makes its way into his heaving chest. His steps quicken into a run, and he flees. Not towards the Kremnoan district, no, he can't go there like he used to. Not to the villa either because there's no one there. Instead, he runs in the direction of Hyacine's office.

He rushes past stone walls covered in vines, snakes through marble corridors among the roaring waterfall. The Verax Leo tries to speak with him, but he brushes it off and continues along, blinded by his desire to distance himself.

It doesn't matter if there's a new round of rumors. That's fine. He's dealt with it in the past and will have to continue dealing with it considering the city's love of gossip and his less than stellar reputation as a Kremnoan.

Oh, how he wishes he wasn't an omega. If he could go back to the times when he had no secondary gender, back when he didn't have to deal with any of this, not the heat hiding beneath his skin, threatening to spill over at a moment's notice, or the bitterness of the chalky white pills he has to take meticulously every single day, waiting and praying that they don't fail him.

In his hurry, he runs straight into a dead end. The towering limestone wall of Okhema's grandest temple looms over him.

He hates it so much, hates not having control of himself like he used to. With a yell, he slams his fists in the limestone wall. His lungs burn as he leans against the wall to catch his breath, blonde bangs sticking to his forehead.

If he had presented as a beta, everything would have been fine. An alpha, even better. Why an omega? Why was he stuck like this? Why—Why did he present in the first place?

"*Mydei*."

Chills run down Mydei's spine. Silently, he curses himself. Like a hound to blood, of course Phainon would find him. He steels his expression and turns to find the white-haired alpha slowly advancing towards him.

"Why are you running from me?" Phainon questions. Anger blazes hot in those blue eyes.

Fighting the urge to shiver, Mydei scoffs. "I'm not."

“*Liar.*” Phainon snaps, voice low. “Why not be honest about it to begin with? For what reason are you hiding from me? What are you so afraid of?”

What are you so afraid of?

Panic rises. His mind blanks. Blindly, Mydei responds, his voice trembling at the edges, “I didn’t want you to know. If you found out the truth, you would think less of me.”

Phainon’s expression slips, brows furrowing in confusion instead of anger. “Why would I think less of you for being with an omega?”

Mydei backs away slowly, steps shaky and uneven, only there’s nowhere to run. He collides with the wall as his eyes blow wide. “No… That’s not…” He shakes his head fervently, gauntleted fingers digging into the limestone wall. “No. I’m leaving. Let me go.”

When he tries to dash off, Phainon grabs him by the arm, clamping down on his wrist. His scent gland tingles beneath the tight grip. Deep blue eyes regard him, no trace of sunshine left. “The villagers. Is it the chief’s daughter?”

Mydei tries to pull away. Phainon’s strength is immense, and being reminded of it only serves to dig the dagger deeper. Even beneath layers of clothing and armor, the touch *burns* .

“Is it the chief's daughter?” Phainon repeats, a hollowness to his tone that Mydei’s never heard before. “You married her, didn’t you?”

Confused, Mydei replies, “No. What are you talking about?”

“If it’s not her, then who else can it be?” Phainon hisses, grabbing Mydei by the shoulders and slamming him into the wall. His back collides with hard stone, and he winces.

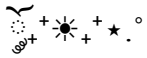
“So some random omega you picked up then? Mydei, what the hell?” As he speaks, his fangs glint in the dawn. Mydei fights against the urge to bare his neck, and his thighs begin to grow wet once more. He’s thankful that the bulk of Phainon’s pheromones are covered by the patches, merely a wisp and not a blazing wildfire. He’s sure his reaction would be even worse had he been hit with the brunt of angry alpha.

His head spins. Mydei spits out, “You have no clue what you’re talking about, Deliverer. Stop running your mouth before you regret it.”

Fingernails dig into his shoulders. Phainon’s breathing grows ragged, raw desperation in his voice. “No one tells me! I’m kept in the dark and that’s why I don’t know anything! Even when I try—”

“Because it’s none of your fucking business."

“I…” Phainon trails off. His expression flickers, and the fight leaves him. Eyes downcast, he murmurs, “Yeah, I guess that’s true.” A bitter laugh escapes from his lips as he lets go of Mydei’s shoulders and turns away. “I’m sorry if I care about you, Mydei. Seems like I trust you more than you trust me.”



Thanks to Castorice, his bedroom at the villa is now chock full of silken pillows and fluffy plushies, a far cry from how it had been when he had first moved in. It looks lived in, plushies flung around, pillows and blankets pushed into a circle.

His old bedroom had been sparse in decoration, covered crimson and gold in traditional Kremnoan style. It was a place to sleep, and it served its purpose. The idea of hoarding a bunch of pillows and blankets had seemed preposterous at first, but now he prefers this space over his old one.

If this had been any other day, he would have loved to flop down, a relieved sigh falling from his lips as he pushed his face into a soft blanket. After all, nothing feels greater than the comfort of being greeted by a soft, welcoming bed after a tiresome day.

Only now, staring down at the pile—his *nest* — he's reminded of the truth that he can't run away from. His sleep has been the best it has been, and no longer does he awake at night with premonitions that he can't escape.

Mydei turns to his side, and his heart skips a beat. Hidden beneath a pillow like it's a priceless treasure is Phainon's rumpled chiton. It's a little pathetic, he knows, to still hold on so desperately to what isn't his. Maybe it's time to wash and return it, but he can't bear to part with it. At least, not yet.

Or ever, a small voice whispers.

It's his little secret. The treacherous article of clothing that carries with it the scent of citrus and spring. Normally, the sight of it has him loopy, a pleasant buzzing in his head as he readies himself for the familiar, comforting scent.

But now, looking at it, his heart aches and bleeds. He shouldn't indulge himself. Not when his relationship with Phainon is falling at its seams. He stares blankly at the fabric. He should toss it out of sight, wash it and return it. Close this chapter of his life. Pretend it never happened.

Only he's weak. He desires Phainon, and it eats away at him. He doesn't know what to do. Not when he can't bring himself to tell Phainon the truth.

Holding the soft moonlight fabric to his nose, Mydei takes a deep inhale. He purrs in delight —or as a way to self-soothe, he can't tell anymore—long eyelashes fluttering as he rubs his cheeks against it. The scent is beginning to dissipate, what once filled his nose and flooded his scenes, now only a small tickle.

His chest tightens. The corners of his eyes burn. He misses having Phainon's scent on him as an almost permanent addition to his body, misses the feel of Phainon's lips against his neck and the warmth of his strong arms wrapped around his waist.

These instincts. His love towards Phainon. It claws at him. Even knowing that Phainon isn't attracted to the most intimate parts of him does nothing to abate the desire that makes its home in his chest.

Chimes jingle harmoniously outside, the spring breeze refreshing as it blows through the open window and rustles the curtains.

Try as he might, he can't banish the thoughts of being Phainon's mate and bearing his children. Even the stupid fight did nothing to abate the crawl of desire, the wish to be Phainon's chosen. He can barely think straight, not when he's inhaling Phainon's scent and imagining a life together where Phainon accepts him and desires him. He curses the man for even bringing up the idea of marriage in the first place.

He's always wanted children. He has always known that, but now he wants *Phainon's* children. Damn it. He curses himself as he buries his face further into the moonlight fabric as if attempting to hide from the truth. The omega in him cries out for his chosen mate, even if Phainon himself doesn't know it.



He doesn't know how long he's been asleep nor how long he's spent hiding in his nest.

Time blurs and fades. Familiar heat creeps in and out. It's as if he's drifting aimlessly once more, the waves unpredictable, a moment of calm followed by the storm that threatens to pull him under. Sweat beads at his temple, his bangs sticking uncomfortably to his forehead. He throws off his blankets and curls into a ball.

Why's his room so horrifically hot? He cracks an eye open, blearily looking around.

There's the slow creak of the front door. Mydei blinks away the sleep lurking behind his eyes and forcing himself to be alert. He quickly pulls himself out of bed, pats himself down so he doesn't look like a tired mess, and steps into the living room, ready to welcome Castorice back from her mission.

Instead of wildflower nectar and sweet, delicate features, he's greeted with the peculiar sight of a certain alpha grinning and clutching onto a bunch of colorful bags.

Mydei gives a blank stare. "What the hell are you doing here?"

"What does it look like I'm doing?" Phainon laughs as he holds his bags up.

“...” Mydei narrows his eyes. Is that the outline of a vase he sees?

Phainon waltzes in like he owns the place. He sets his bags beside the living room couch and exclaims, “I’m moving in!”

Already, he feels a headache coming. “Excuse me?”

“There’s no space on my floor. I have too many antiques as you so kindly told me,” Phainon pouts. The anger from before has dissipated entirely. Phainon acts as if their argument hadn’t happened, while Mydei can’t bring himself to move on.

“Whose fault is that?” Mydei says bitterly. An astringent taste floods his mouth. He wishes Castorice were here. She could deal with Phainon for him.

“There’s no room in my house! It’s better for me to live here,” Phainon says like it’s so obvious. Not like he’s wrong.

“You can’t just…” Mydei swallows. No, Phainon *can*. After all, the villa is for all the heirs. There’s nothing stopping Phainon from moving in. “Okay. Go ahead. I’m going back to my room. Good night, Deliverer.” He turns to leave.

“Mydei.”

Mydei glances back. Phainon’s eyes crescent as he says, “Good night. I wish you sweet dreams.”

Butterflies birth and flutter in his belly. “Hmph.”



In the morning, he finds Phainon working hard in the kitchen. A dollop of whipped cream is smeared across his cheek as he slices a batch of ripe strawberries and juicy peaches, releasing their sweet, fruity aroma.

“Morning, Mydei!” Phainon grins, giving off his signature brilliant smile, his ahoge bobbing in tune with his movements. He’s wearing Mydei’s orange apron, the one Hyacine and Little Ica had bought him as a thank you gift after hearing his other apron had been destroyed in an accident that involved Phainon and fire.

Gingerly, Phainon places down a plate of homemade honeycakes topped with whipped cream and sprinkled with pomegranate arils. It doesn’t look as round or decadent as the ones from the restaurant, but Mydei’s mouth waters all the same.

He stares down at the plate, unsure if he should dig in or wait. Already, he feels a little bad for his outburst, even if his chest pushes and pulls each breath. Phainon seems less bothered,

smiling as he plates his own set of honeycakes. He brings over a basket of bread and fruit as well.

Phainon glances over and asks, “Where’s Castorice? I haven’t seen her. I thought she lived here. I made some honeycakes for her too.”

“She’s off on a mission and won’t be back for another few days,” Mydei replies as he pops half of a strawberry into his mouth.

Phainon’s lips form an o. “I see...”

The conversation over breakfast is stilted. Awkward. Mydei quietly sips at his tea, giving one word answers while Phainon tries so desperately to fill in the silence. Maybe he feels a little bad for forcing Phainon’s hand like this, but he’s not in the mood to talk. At least the prickling in his nape is gone.

“We have to prepare for the whole Cipher visit and all. She’s coming in a few days isn’t she?” Phainon brings up. His voice tightens, and Mydei looks up to see Phainon attempting a smile.

“Oh.” He had forgotten about that. “Yes.”

Phainon laughs, broad shoulders remaining tense as he reaches over to grab a piece of bread. Mydei watches as Phainon tears his fangs into it and wonders how those fangs would feel sheathed into his neck.

Fuck. His thighs quiver, leaking slick. It’s like he has no control over his body anymore. His attraction to Phainon has only grown, and he has to fight with the voice in his head that tells him to present himself to the alpha. It’s stupid to feel this way.

Another few minutes of stifling, suffocating silence. Mydei is used to it, so he carries on as usual, scrolling through his teleslate to watch the backlog of videos that Castorice had sent him. It’s then that Phainon sighs and says, “Look, Mydei. I’m sorry for what happened yesterday.”

Mydei raises an eyebrow.

“I don’t want to fight with you anymore… I’ve been a mess, and I haven’t been honest with you either,” Phainon continues.

Mydei pokes at his honeycakes. The poor hibiscus plant in the corner of the kitchen droops down, looking like it’s had better days. Maybe he'll water it later.

“You asked me why I’m so hung up on that omega, so I’ll tell you.” Phainon clasps his hands together as if sending a desperate prayer to the heavens. “Her scent sent me into an early rut.”

Mydei drops his fork. “... *Huh?* ”

Chapter End Notes

another chapter. more tomfoolery. and now mydei's starting to show symptoms again...

i'm shouting mamadei from the rooftops!! who's with me?! 🤭

thanks for reading!! 💞

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

hehe im back :3

cw: masturbation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The fork falls with a clink onto the wooden table. Mydei stares blankly ahead, unable to find the words to formulate a coherent response, not with the way his heart thunders in his chest, loud enough that he's sure Phainon could hear it too.

It's as if all the air has been pulled out of his lungs, his throat closing in on itself. He only hopes the abject horror doesn't show on his face. It must not because Phainon, oblivious to the fire brewing beneath his skin, repeats, "The pomegranate scent sent me into an early rut."

Awash with a wave of anger, scalding and unrelenting, Mydei snaps, "I heard you clearly the first time, *haikas*. No need to say it again."

His lips begin to curl into his telltale sneer, the one he uses when he needs to appear threatening, but it all falls away when he sees the expression marring Phainon's usually vibrant, handsome features. The alpha radiates *exhaustion,* tired in a manner Mydei has never seen before, not even in the darkest of hours, the most difficult of missions ending in innumerable loss. His brilliant blues are flat, lacking its usual bright luster, like an unpolished sapphire, and the playful boyishness that decorated his sweet features has disappeared, leaving the grooves on his face more pronounced.

With a deep sigh, Phainon stuffs another piece of honeycake into his mouth, his movements stiff and lacking the usual soft grace that Mydei has come to appreciate. His voice comes out like a quiet prayer, "Mydei, I know you don't want to talk about it, but I need to know for my own peace of mind. So, please, if you care about me even a little…" He trails off, eyes downcast. "*Please*."

Defeat is what he sounds like, all life has been drained away from him, the remnants of the sun that once was. Mydei shifts in his seat, chewing his bottom lip as he picks up his fork and wipes it clean with a napkin. He doesn't like this, doesn't want Phainon's fire to burn out and be the reason for it. To have Phainon acting like this, begging him for the truth, it's like he's being submerged once more, memories of the times before he even knew himself. He should tell Phainon. He needs to—

"I'm not trying to take her away from you if that's what you're worried about," Phainon continues, hand on his chin as he stabs away at the peach slices on his plate.

Just like that, he's snapped out of his reprieve and throws his fork at Phainon's head. It's dodged with ease. The alpha's reflexes are sharp, fast as the lightning that strikes and scorches the earth.

"Do you think before you speak, Deliverer?" Mydei hisses. His mind is a mess—he doesn't know what he should be feeling. "Is there anything knocking in that giant head of yours?"

Phainon leans back in his chair, attempting nonchalance. He tries a laugh but it fizzles out as quickly as it began, his voice pitching low, "Defensive as always, aren't you, Mydei? What a pleasure it is to speak with you…"

His pulse continues to quicken. Maybe he does need to calm down before this conversation devolves into an argument again as it has these last few times. He knows it will, and he rather not deal with the turmoil of having Phainon angry at him once more.

Even without Phainon's scent spilling all over, reigned in by the patches on his neck, the atmosphere is thick and stifling.

"That's not it," Mydei murmurs, more to himself than to Phainon.

"Then what is it?" Phainon prods. "You've been cagey lately. I know we all have our secrets, but Mydei… it seems like you're an entirely different person sometimes. You never used to be like this, and I… I don't know what to do. Is there any way I can help you?"

Help… His hand moves on its own, landing on his nape. He rubs absentmindedly at the unmarred skin. It's warmer than the rest of his body, searing hot against the pads of his fingers.

"If you just tell me. I promise I won't be angry or view you differently." Phainon lips part as if to say more, only to stop short, his expression falling into listlessness.

"You mentioned the chief's daughter," Mydei says, hand dropping onto the table. He picks up half a strawberry and twirls it around. Though he tries to be gentle, the soft, ripe fruit bruises easily beneath his grip.

"I did," Phainon says, swallowing thickly as his gaze lingers on Mydei's tongue peaking out to lick the juice that drips down his fingers.

"How do you know about her?" Mydei asks. He plops the rest of the fruit into his mouth, savoring the sweetness as he wipes his hands on a napkin. "I'm assuming you spoke with the chief from how you're looking at me."

A loud cough into his sleeve. "Are you angry?"

"No. Do you want me to be?"

"Of course not!" Phainon waves his arms around, urgency in his voice as he tries to explain, "The guy told me he offered her up for you to marry… I wanted to know—"

“I accepted,” Mydei states, watching in muted amusement as the alpha flits through approximately fifty emotions at once. He’s tempted to laugh. If this were any other situation, he would have. “She wanted to get away from her father and begged me to help her, so I did. She’s now living her life free from the pressure, studying at the Grove and pretending to be a beta.”

He doesn’t like the village chief. The man is too far rooted in tradition, raised on the traditional values of his village and Amphoreus at large. There’s little he could do to try to change the alpha’s mind, and he tried, only to be ignored and taken the wrong way at each turn.

Like usual, he dealt with the villagers with polite distance, but the chief’s daughter seeked him out on her own accord. She spoke of her goals and desires of a life where she can choose her own path, of how she was destined to be married off by her overbearing father and made a childbearer when she had dreams of becoming a scholar, studying the origins of life and matter. She took a risk with him, unsure of whether or not he would out her to her overbearing father.

After all, his reputation as the leader of the Kremnoans spoke for itself.

“I see…” Phainon trails off, blue eyes flitting to the side. “Isn’t that stifling? To have to pretend to be someone she isn’t? Constantly having to hide all the time, living in fear of what could happen if the truth were to come out.”

Those words are nothing but the simple ponderings of an alpha, yet no matter how well intentioned, Phainon will never understand.

“Some people don’t have a choice, Deliverer.” His voice comes out rough around the edges, the bitterness making itself known. “Being born an alpha allows luxuries and freedoms not afforded to other secondary genders.”

Phainon sighs, brushing his moonlight bangs away from his eyes. “I know. I don’t disagree with you, but I can’t help but feel like she should be able to live how she wants and not according to the whims of her father and her people. It’s archaic to think someone’s value comes solely from what they present as. Even here in Okhema… Aglaea is open-minded, but others are not. I’ve witnessed my fair share of injustices, spurred on by arrogant alphas who believe they’re above law.”

This is the first time they’ve breached this kind of conversation. Before he presented and was thrust into this new world, a topic like this would have never crossed his mind. As a soldier and crown prince, he was constantly surrounded with alphas and the occasional beta, away from omegas entirely. He had been part of the problem without even knowing it, and that’s the worst part.

Phainon gives a small hum before continuing, “Castrum Kremnos prizes alphas as powerful warriors and kings. Omegas are not a part of that equation.” It’s spoken so blithely, so effortlessly, as if those words don’t mean anything at all, as if he’s stating something so obvious that it doesn’t even need to be said.

And it's true. Castrum Kremnos does not prize omegas. It's carved into the very essence, the city-state that thrives off strife and war, domination through destruction and the subjugation of those weaker.

"My dear prince, I'm curious to hear your perspective." While Phainon's voice comes out contemplative as he leans against his hand, his gaze speaks volumes, piercing and attempting to rip through Mydei's defenses.

He can't help the way his heart lurches, yet somehow, he manages to wrangle the thoughts in his head into something coherent, honest, and wholly *naive*. "Judgement of worth should be based solely on character and character alone."

Aglaea had said the same, pushing him towards a certain direction with her clever words and knowing eyes. But…

"This entire debacle about secondary gender is useless. To erase millennia of belief is a difficult feat, and those who are stuck in their ways will not waver, even if the truth is brought upon their eyes, even if…" He bites his lip. He should stop. There's little use in continuing this discussion. All it's doing is exacerbating the ache in his chest, the breathlessness that breaks through the calm he's tried so hard to sustain.

Kremnoans do not cower. They do not know fear. No matter how difficult the battle or how low the odds, they will continue to fight until their last breath, pushing against the growing tides, clamoring for honor even when drowning in a pool of blood. There is no honor in running.

But in this case, he will. He's made his choice for the sake of his people. They will not find out. It's easier this way. Cowardly, yes, but easier.

"If no steps are taken, there can be no progress," Phainon says, nails tapping idly against wood. "I'm glad we share the same sentiments."

Had this been any other conversation on any other day, he would have scoffed and responded with *What don't we share?* Instead, he says nothing, only stares down at his cold tea, at the reflection that stares back at him, the messy mane of blonde, red-tipped hair and sharp molten gold eyes marked with crimson.

The kitchen falls to an uneasy silence. Neither of them have much of an appetite anymore. His honeycakes lay half-eaten, glistening with sugary syrup and fresh whipped cream. Silently, Mydei stands up, wraps it up, and places it in the fridge for later.

"Thank you," he murmurs. "For breakfast."

Wide blue eyes stare back at him. Phainon brightens, his lips curling into something sweet he responds, "Of course! If you'd like, I can make honeycakes for you everyday." There's a light dusting of pink on his cheeks. "Ah—I mean, erm—I can make other things too! Like salads… Or whatever you want to eat!"

Phainon looks at him like he's something precious, like he's worth protecting. It makes him feel sick. He almost wants to leave. End the conversation here and return to the closed confines of his room where he can hide, bury himself in his nest.

Yet, what comes out of his mouth is, "I'd like that."

"Oh!" Phainon exclaims, jolting forwards, as if he hadn't expected Mydei to respond accordingly, but his expression is sweet, a little sheepish as he rubs the back of his head. It lasts for a moment only to falter, falling away like leaves come autumn. "Mydei… About—"

"You wish to meet the omega that sent you into rut," Mydei cuts in. "Why? What are you hoping to accomplish?"

Phainon begins cleaning up the table, and Mydei moves to help him. Their fingers bump, and Mydei withdraws as if burned. If Phainon takes notice, he doesn't say anything.

Eyes downcast as he picks up the glass mugs, Phainon says, "I want to know who it is. Once I see her, the attraction will stop. I know it will."

"How are you so sure?"

"Because I only have eyes for one person." This close, there's no mistaking Phainon's cheeks are flushed pink. The alpha smiles once more, tenderness filling in his sweet features. He still doesn't look Mydei in the eye.

Mydei stills—waits for Phainon to say more only to be greeted with silence.

With back turned, Phainon places the glassware into the sink. "And besides, I can't be with an omega. Even if I wanted to."

There it is. The inevitable reminder that Phainon will never desire him.

"Why?" Mydei can't help but ask.

"They can't handle me. It's for the best that I keep my distance."

What do you mean? I can handle you fine. There's nothing you can do that I can't handle. But he'd be a fool to voice it.

"Didn't think you were that kind of alpha, especially after you gave that whole spiel about being equals and looking past secondary gender."

"It's not that, Mydei."

"Then what is it?"

Phainon sighs. He seats himself back at the dining table and says, "Don't worry about it."

It's more than he's making it seem, but if he doesn't want to talk about it, then Mydei won't press further. Not when he's stuck between a rock and a hard place.

As much as he wants to deny it, Phainon deserves the truth. The other heirs, barring Cipher, all know that he's an omega, and they've kept his secret for this long. He's fine if the other heirs know but Phainon… Phainon is different.

He needs to ask Castorice for advice. She would know what to do, and besides, she's known Phainon since their days at the Grove. If there's anyone that knows Phainon, it'd be her.

"I'll set up a meeting for you and… her. Give me some time," Mydei says. "We need to prepare for Cipher's arrival in a few days. The villa needs to be cleaned and presentable, and we have to figure out what we're going to make."

It's an excuse, but Phainon's expression softens nonetheless. He gives an enthusiastic nod, and Mydei thinks the conversation is over, only for alpha to ask, quiet and uncertain, "Can you at least tell me what she's like?"

"...Kremnoan." *Me.*

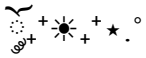
"That's it?" Phainon laughs. "C'mon, give me something a little more specific."

"Blonde." *Me.*

"Personality? Anything? Do I know her? What's she like?"

"*Deliverer.*"

Phainon raises his hands in mock surrender. "Okay, okay. I'll ask again after the gathering."



Alone in his room, Mydei can finally breathe again.

His cheeks begin to burn, and he bows his head down, blonde bangs covering his eyes. When faced with only himself, it's inevitable for his thoughts to wander. The thought of Phainon, of the alpha thrown into an early rut because of *him* is overwhelming. His nape heats up, and his fingers twitch with the urge to scratch at the unmarred skin.

Phainon is *attracted* to him. Phainon desires him, even if he doesn't know it.

His thighs tremble. It's been like this lately. The medications are no longer holding, though he's still taking them day in and day out. He needs to seek out Hyacine, but he can't, not when Phainon is right there, ready to join him at a moment's notice.

No more scenting. No more casual touches. Phainon's scent is muffled, gone as if it had never existed to begin with, only… Mydei curses himself.

To deny it is to deny reality. Phainon is the reason why. Because he's weak to Phainon. Because he desires Phainon and has since the moment they lay side by side after ten days and nights of battle. It was then he knew, he had found the one, but he locked it away, hid it because he knew that it wasn't the right time or place.

He's seen Phainon naked, seen the alpha's cock heavy between strong thighs. Felt him hot and hard against his ass.

Butterflies flutter. He lies on his bed, and shucks away the clothing stifling against his skin, leaving himself bare. Thankfully, he had the foresight to not wear his armor this early in the day.

His body feels warm all over. The thought of Phainon in the throes of rut because of him… His fingers roll down, ghosting over his half-hard cock, landing in between his legs.

Touching himself to the thought of Phainon while the alpha resides only the next door over. If he had more shame, he'd be scandalized.

Had he not presented, he would have loved to live with Phainon, share in the small moments. They've spent countless nights together, huddling together, basking in the same warmth as they hid away from the frigid outside, the dark of the evernight. Having Phainon beside him made it less lonely. No longer was he floating alone in dark waters, not when he had his own personal sun by his side.

Before he never understood why he clamored for the comfort that only Phainon could bring, but now he's made aware of his feelings, the constant, incessant whisperings in his ear and the desire that runs hot through his veins when Phainon so much as glances at him.

Only, their relationship is precarious, unstable. He doesn't know how long he can hold onto the lie. Not when Phainon is within a ten meter radius of him at all times, hovering around like a playful pup wagging his tail and waiting for his owner to play ball.

The walls are crumbling all around him. His messages to Castorice aren't going through, and he doesn't know what he can do to not arouse suspicion. He's tried calling her multiple times, only for the call to go straight to voicemail.

He almost texts Hyacine, but his fingers hover over the send button. Already, he's spent so much of her time. She has better things to do than deal with him.

Mydei leans against his nest of pillows and spreads his legs. The villa runs warm, given its closer proximity to Kephale's dawn device, especially with his windows closed and curtains drawn shut. His tattoos glow crimson and pulse at odd intervals as the pads of his fingers meet a familiar wetness blossoming between his trembling thighs.

He's never fucked himself on his fingers before—never explored that area of himself. He's jerked off, yes, that's a given but not this. Swallowing the growing apprehension, he prods at the tight ring of muscle, spreading around slick, warm and thick, as he takes deep breaths in and out to relieve the tension building in his shoulders. Easing his legs apart as far as he can,

he slowly pushes the first finger in. It's a strange feeling, a slight burn as he clenches down on himself.

There's no need for lube when he's already gushing slick like a waterfall in the height of the rainy season. The thought of Phainon, of his springtime scent, of his hidden strength and the beauty of those blue eyes, has him dripping onto his poor bedsheets.

He's not used to the changes. It's not the greatest feeling to walk around with wet, sticky thighs, nor having to deal with the ache down there that screams at him to be filled, but at least he doesn't have to spend money on lube when he's practically trickling like a leaky faucet.

Maybe he should have laid out a towel beforehand. If he hadn't been so desperate, his heart fluttering fast in his chest, desire awash in his veins, he would have had the foresight to not ruin his freshly prepared and fluffed nest. But one finger isn't enough, no, even as he sinks to the second knuckle then to the base. Even a second finger doesn't stop the ache, the desire to be filled, stretched to brim, molded around cock.

Mydei's expression scrunches, his cheeks burning hotter. It's the omega part of him talking, but he can't bring himself to care, not when heat simmers beneath his skin, threatening to spill over at any moment. The pressure in his chest becomes overwhelming as he drives his fingers in and out, starting slow before gaining pace.

It's not enough. No. Frustrated, he hisses as he arches his back against his pillows. One hand moves to play with his chest, rolling his nipples until they pebble and stiffen.

In the corner of his eye lies rumpled moonlight fabric, peaking out from beneath a plush pillow. Without a second thought, Mydei lunges forward to grab it. He brings it to his nose, inhaling the scent of sunshine, while he fucks himself hard and fast, increasing intensity with each thrust of his fingers. It burns, the stretch feels good, but this position leaves much to be desired.

A soft purr leaves his throat as he continues the inhale. A third finger added, and he nearly cries out in frustration because it doesn't reach deep enough.

With his fingers still nestled in his ass, he gets down on his knees and pushes in deeper. At this new angle, he has an easier time hitting that spot inside him that has him quaking and seeing stars. His vision blurs and he chases the high, screwing his eyes shut as he pushes his face against the soft moonlight fabric.

If only Phainon were here. If only they weren't separated by a barrier that extends further than the thin walls of their bedrooms.

The wet squelch of fingers driving in and out fills the silence, his breathing growing ragged as he swallows down a moan. His head spins, dizziness washing over like the high tides of a summer day. While his fingers are by no means small, Phainon's cock is thicker, longer than three combined. It would easily him to the brim, satisfy him the way he wants.

Phainon would fuck him so well. Mydei knows it, and by titans, he wants it so badly.

His thoughts wander to that day. The scent of Phainon in the midst of a heavy rut, a rut caused by *him*.

Slick continues to trickle down his thighs. Even plugged up, the ache is unbearable, the fire blazing. He imagines Phainon fucking him, calloused hands digging into his hips as he's taken mercilessly from behind, words of praise whispered into his ear. The scent of lush spring and ashen smoke meshing with the fullness, the sweet burn of Phainon's cock pistoning in and out.

"Deliverer…!" Mydei gasps, long lashes fluttering. "Alpha—"

Phainon pulling at his hair, yanking his head back as he slams deep, reaching all the way, molding the omega around his cock. Instinctively, Mydei bares his neck, broken noises escaping his lips.

He comes untouched, the heat of orgasm wreaking tremors though his sweat-slick body as he clenches down on his fingers. Slick squirts everywhere, drenching his thighs as it sprays out of him. His vision whites out, and for a moment, it's only Phainon and him, connected, as one.

The entirety of his body prickles, nape burning for a bite from an alpha that isn't there. It's as if all his bones have melted, and he slumps forwards, falling from the high like Icarus falling from the sun. He lays there, face smushed into Phainon's chiton as he takes slow breaths, fingers still lodged inside.

Shame begins its slow crawl, making its home in his chest. Gingerly, he pulls his fingers out and flops onto his back, wincing at the feel of wetness on the bedsheets. A hand is laid over his eyes to blot out the bright light. His bedroom is stifling, far too stuffy and warm with the remnants of his desire.

It wasn't satisfying. Not at all. He wants—*needs* more. His fingers couldn't reach deep enough, couldn't satisfy the ache in his core. He needs toys, or better yet Phainon himself.

There are stores in Okhema that sell what he needs. He'd like nothing more than to fuck himself on thick alpha knot, but visiting an establishment like that… The workers will talk. It's a given.

"Fuck," Mydei groans. Already, his cock is beginning to harden, and his hole clenches around nothing. He rubs around at the loosened rim, suppressing a gasp as shockwaves roll down his spine. It's tempting to plunge in once more, but he forces himself up and out of bed instead. No. He's not continuing this.

The bedsheets are pulled off and changed. Pillows and blankets stripped away and replaced with new ones—thankfully, he had the foresight to buy extra as per Castorice's suggestion. He takes a quick shower, unable to resist the urge to finger himself to orgasm a few more times, leaning his forehead against the shower wall as he comes in the haze of the shower steam.

Phainon is so close. Only a few steps away. He could tell Phainon the truth, rip off the bandages instead of letting the wound fester beneath, and then beg Phainon to fuck him to ease the throbbing between his legs.

Even if he's attracted to Mydei's scent, Phainon has repeated that he does not like omegas and cannot—will not—be with one. The bitterness settles and to distract himself, Mydei pulls open his laptop and begins working on his animations. Drawing is a comfort, a small hobby of his that would have the entirety of the Kremnoan detachment laughing if they knew. Sitting beneath the lamplight, he falls into the comforting rhythm, but his imagination stays firmly planted in one direction.

This one he's not going to post. It's far too risky. Many people in Okhema theorize who's behind the popular Fig Stew account, and he rather not out himself in the most embarrassing way possible.

The tension in his body fizzles out as he stares down at his newest animation, still in its rough draft stages. Fig Stew and Beagle Coconut are surrounded by a litter of energetic pups, all grey with round blue eyes. Fig Stew chirps and the pups follow while Beagle Coconut stays nestled tightly beside Fig Stew.

The next scene has Fig Stew curled up on the grass, purring softly as it feeds its little of unruly pups, while Beagle Coconut whimpers, walking in circles, vying for Fig Stew's undivided attention.

His expression softens, a pull of a smile at the corner of his lips.

Beside him, his teleslate pings. From an unknown source, it reads: "Have you told him yet?"

Ridden with confusion, he places his stylus down and grabs his teleslate. Is this a spam caller? Perhaps, someone who's gotten the wrong number?

He answers with a simple and clear: "You must have gotten the wrong number."

The response is instantaneous, almost mocking: "Have you told him yet, crown prince Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos?"

What in the river of souls? He stares blankly down at his screen, the words clear in their intent. This person is targeting him. Are they attempting to draw out information?

Then comes a knock at his door, snapping him out of his daze.

He ignores it. The knocks continue, and Phainon yells, "Hey, Mydei! I know you're in there!"

His eye twitches. After what must have been the tenth knock, he yanks the door open, fingernails digging into the white painted wood, and snaps, "Quit making a ruckus."

Effortlessly charming as ever, Phainon leans against the doorframe and grins, "My dear prince, may I come in?"

“No.” He slams the door in Phainon’s face.

“Mydei! Hey!”

If Phainon truly wanted to, he could easily kick the door in. He’s seen firsthand how strong the alpha is when he isn’t holding back. There's been many times where Phainon pins him down, and he’s unable to do anything but wait for Phainon to get off him—a feather against a boulder.

Aglaea wouldn’t take so kindly to finding the villa’s pristine walls caved in by an overeager Phainon, and he knows how greatly Phainon respects her, so he should be safe in that regard.

Under no circumstances can he have Phainon entering his room. Not when it looks like this. Not when his bedsheets and blankets lay soiled in a corner and his bed piled high with what is evidently an omega’s personal nest. The pill bottles, blue and white, stand proud on his nightstand, and he quickly shoves them into the cabinet.

Maybe he should throw everything into his closet. Pretend the nest never existed. Return to normalcy. A bed with nothing more than a single pillow and a measly blanket.

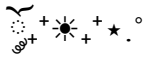
Only… It feels like he’s ripping a piece of himself away, caging himself once more.

No. He can’t do it. The prospect of losing what little comfort he has and having to return to a cold, barren room has him shaking his head.

And there’s that infuriating part of him that coos to invite Phainon into his nest and have him rub his scent all over his blankets and pillows until every nook and crevice is filled with the scent of spring and sunshine. He wants to cuddle beside Phainon, wants Phainon to praise him for being a good omega, for having a soft nest perfect for mating.

It’s stupid. Irrational. He knows it to be, yet he can’t resist. There’s little it takes for him to crumble. He never used to be this way, never acting so rash.

Back then, he couldn’t afford to. Coming to Okhema has changed him, and he’s not quite sure if it’s for the better or for the worse, but he wouldn’t exchange what he has now, not for anything.



Usually, he’s not one to complain. It’s unbefitting of him to raise a ruckus or proclaim his dissatisfaction. As the crown prince of Castrum Kremnos and survivor of the wretched sea of souls, body forged and re-forged thousands of times, he learned young that there’s little use in crying over what cannot change, the rules etched into the core of the earth, the code of the world. It may be unfair and frustrating, but complaining solves nothing.

Now, he feels differently. He's ready to launch into an avalanche of complaints all because of one infuriating alpha who won't stop with that blinding grin of his.

Sleep is important. Now that he's no longer constantly watching behind his shoulder or on guard for the next ambush, safe within the confines of Okhema, Mydei takes his sleep very seriously.

Phainon, on the other hand, does not. He knocks and knocks, yelling for Mydei to wake up, insisting that they have to get ready in the morning together, establish a routine together. With deep-set eyebags and an irritated scowl that would frighten anybody with a functioning brain, Mydei pulls himself out of bed only to be dragged to the communal bathroom by Phainon who refuses to let go, even as Mydei tries to swipe at him.

Now, they're here. Mydei yawns and rubs at his eyes as he grabs his toothbrush.

"Your toothbrush…" Phainon murmurs, looking at it as if it's the most fascinating thing in all of Amphoreus, more so than any priceless antique. "Erm, why is it pink?"

Mydei stares at him, eyebrows pinching together, disbelief written all over his sleepy features. "Yes."

Phainon holds in a laugh. Or attempts to. He fails, a tidal wave of giggles spilling from his lips as he clutches his stomach, tears forming droplets in the corner of his eyes.

What's so funny?

Mydei's fingers twitch at his sides. It's way too early for this. He thought he was an early riser, but it seems Phainon has got him beat. Makes no sense too because he swears Phainon rises later than he does.

Another loud giggle. His eye begins to twitch.

What kind of grown man giggles like *that*? Even through the exasperation, he can't help the heat that floods his cheeks. He turns away before Phainon can tease him for it.

"Do you have a problem, Deliverer?" he bites out.

Once more, Phainon tries to hold it in only to snort. He stares down, noticing the pink bunny slippers adorning Mydei's feet and promptly starts to choke. Mydei frowns. Castorice had bought the slippers for him when she noticed him not so subtly eyeing them at the market, stating that it was a welcome gift.

His ears burn, and he turns to leave only for Phainon to grab his wrist. Blue eyes crinkle, shining with tears. "I think it's adorable."

He's itching to make distance, but his attempts to wretch his wrist free results in his downfall —Phainon giving him the widest of puppy eyes. Sometimes it's hard to believe Phainon is an alpha with how he acts, nothing at all like the toxic bravado of Kremnoan alphas he's used to.

From the first quint of entry hour to the last quint of curtain-fall hour, Phainon sticks by his side. His every waking moment is spent with the alpha, and he even has the audacity to begin to whimpering when Mydei insists on taking a midday nap. Alone.

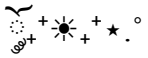
“Why won’t you let me in? We can nap together!” Phainon exclaims, staring at Mydei with those big blue eyes of his. If he had puppy ears, they would be drooping, and he even gives a small, pathetic whine when Mydei refuses him yet again.

Under no circumstances can Phainon enter his room.

It takes a lot of effort to remove himself from Phainon’s side. The alpha insists on staying within five feet at all times, even choosing the room beside his to occupy. He should be complaining, telling Phainon to stop with his antics, but it’s not so bad. He feels warm and fuzzy all over like he’s wrapped up in soft blankets.

When he’s with Phainon, he’s safe, and safe isn’t a word he’s used to.

He doesn’t know what to do with this new information.



It’s the middle of the week when Castorice returns. She carries a bag full of goodies, her eyes sparkling in excitement as she skips through the door.

“Lord Mydei!” Castorice smiles. “Ah! Lord Phainon, you’re here too!” The confusion is written all over her face, and her wildflower scent falters.

“I moved in,” Phainon says, lounging on the living room *kline* as if he owns it. He gives a small frown. “Like two days ago? Right, Mydei?”

“Three days ago,” Mydei replies gruffly. They sit beside each other with Phainon’s legs crossing over Mydei’s lap. He’s told Phainon to get off five times now only to be refused each time. “Welcome back, Castorice.”

“Thank you, Lord Mydei…” Castorice trails off, eyeing the both of them. “Erm, uh, that’s great news! Anything else you two would like to share?”

“Hm?” Phainon tilts his head. “No. Nothing else that I can think of…” He tilts his head, pondering over Castorice’s question. A light bulb goes off in his head, and he continues, “Oh! Actually, I may have borrowed a blanket or two from your room since *a certain someone* wouldn’t let me borrow any of his. I tried texting you to ask, but I’m not sure if you got my messages.”

“Stop pouting, Deliverer,” Mydei says, somewhat distracted, as he scrolls through his teleslate, ignoring the weight of Phainon’s muscular calves pressing against his thighs. As of late, he’s been into looking at baby clothes and accessories lately—cute little onesies with chimera patterns and pastel bow headbands. It quenches the fire inside him, the desire that’s overtaken his thoughts lately—to be Phainon’s mate and bear his pups.

Not that he’d ever willingly admit it.

His teleslate pings, and he has to bite back a groan. It’s yet another message from that unknown source. The same old “Have you told him yet?” Mydei’s eye twitches and his fingers move on autopilot, blocking the number even knowing that in an hour, they’ll be back with the same damn message.

Whoever the person is, they’re persistent. What do they want from him?

He only hopes they’re not referring to his conversation with Phainon. Unless there’s spy cameras in the villa, there’s no way they could know. He’s tried subtly asking only to receive “You know exactly what I’m referring to” as a response. Cryptic and useless. It reveals nothing.

Phainon turns to give Mydei a miffed look with his lips pouty and nose scrunched. “Can you blame me? You used to let me into your room with no issue! Remember when you gave me keys to your house? And now you won’t even let me borrow a blanket…”

“Get your own, you big baby.”

“Look at him!” Phainon says, indignant, as he jabs a finger towards Mydei. “This is what I have to deal with!”

Castorice giggles. “You did choose to live here, Lord Phainon.”

“Okay, but that doesn’t mean he has free reign to do whatever!”

“Hmph. Quit complaining.” His eyes land on a white baby onesie patterned with pastel blue flowers. It’s adorable and for a decent price too. He should buy it and save it for when he and Phainon—*No. That’s never going to happen. Stop.*

“He’s a terrible roommate…” Phainon sniffs. “Won’t even cook dinner without burning it on purpose! And why did you put that much sugar into the beef stew? You’re not that dumb! I mean, salt and sugar do look similar, but the jars were clearly labelled. Mydei… Ah, I forget you can’t read…”

Mydei rolls his eyes, ignoring the obvious bait as he continues scrolling through his teleslate. There's a subtle ache that’s settled in his chest but he pays it no mind. “How have you been, Castorice?”

“Good…” Castorice trails off.

“You’re no fun, Mydei,” Phainon pouts. He pulls his legs off of Mydei’s lap and scoots over to sit right beside him. “Eh? Why are you looking at baby clothes?”

Castorice blinks. Mydei's cheeks burn.

Mortified, Phainon asks, "Did you get someone pregnant?!" A pause and a loud gasp. "Don't tell me it's—"

Mydei clamps a hand over Phainon's mouth, face burning. His eyebrows draw together as he hisses, "Shut up. Stop talking."

"I brought some gifts," Castorice quickly interjects, showing off the items in her tote like she's an experienced saleswoman. "Look! Woven bracelets for everyone. With cute animal charms too! I got myself this bunny with floppy ears. A fluffy white dog for you, Lord Phainon, and an orange cat for Lord Mydei! I got some for the others too! I didn't forget Lady Cipher either. She's visiting soon, isn't she? Haha…"

Later in the day, Mydei finds himself in front of Castorice's door. Phainon had left the villa on short notice, giving him time to visit her without making it a three-way conversation.

"Lord Mydei!" Castorice exclaims. "How can I help you?"

"Should I tell him?" Mydei asks.

Castorice blinks. The words settle in, and she perks up, grabbing him by the shoulders. Given their height difference, she has to get on her tippy toes to even reach but that doesn't stop her from shaking him like she means business. "Yes! You should tell Lord Phainon!"

When she realizes her outburst, she pulls away and says, "Sorry, I mean, you should have an honest conversation with Lord Phainon. Really speak with him and understand his point of view. I think you should tell him, but only you can really decide that."

She lets Mydei into her room, walls colored light lavender and decor cutesy with soft, fairy lights patterning the walls and crocheted dolls covering her desk, colorful yarn strung all over. There's a wreath made of lavender and lilac flowers at the head of her bed, and a shelf stacked full of books of all genres.

Her bed is pushed to the side, nest artfully arranged, a bouquet of pastels, white and soft purples. While Mydei's nest is mostly glossy satin pillows with minimal design and the occasional soft plush, Castorice's nest is exclusively fuzzy textured ones and ones shaped like different creatures. Her collection is vast and what she has out today is not the same as the first time.

Looking over her arrangement, at the adorable purple daisy plush sitting beside the tall chimera hugging pillow, Mydei is tempted to add more to his own collection. He even spots a large pomegranate in the corner of her nest, its deep crimson contrasting against the soft colors of her nest. Castorice perks up, grabbing it and handing it over to Mydei.

"It's for you," she beams. "I found it at the market but didn't have time to give it to you until now. Hope you like it!"

Mydei hugs it to his chest, face heating up. "Thank you."

Together, they lay side by side in her nest, nestled amongst a sea of warmth.

“Phainon told me my scent sent him into rut,” Mydei tells her. It’s almost embarrassing to admit.

Castorice chokes on air. Her long purple hair fans around her as she grabs a nearby pillow and hugs it. She turns to face him, amethyst eyes glowing. Her sweet voice comes out dire, urgent in a manner he’s never heard before. “You should tell him. Lord Mydei, you have to tell him. He needs to know.”

“I…” Mydei brushes his bangs away from his face. “I told him I would arrange a meeting after the gathering.”

“There’s no rush. Do so when you’re ready, but Lord Mydei, promise me you’ll tell him.”

Mydei stares up at the ceiling, eyes tracing the hanging butterfly lights, glowing purple in the dim light. It’d be nice to decorate his room more and to not have to hide. To have Phainon with him, hanging out in his room like how it used to be.

Regaining a sense of normality. Not having to pretend. He’d like that. Even if revealing the truth would mean Phainon would never desire him the way he wants, what other choice does he have?

“I promise,” he murmurs—a prayer.

Chapter End Notes

i’m a mydei is a squirter truther!! who's with me?!

next chapter will be fun hehe. cipher makes her appearance again 🫣

thank you for reading! 💞

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

10 chapters already... oh my. it's crazy to think about

i want to thank everyone for the support and kind comments!! love you all 💞

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Objectively, it’s nice up here. Warmer than usual—the dawn’s rays burn brighter this high—but there’s a clear view of Okhema and the surrounding waterfall, the rush of crystalline water as it slams against hard rock. Had it been any other day, he wouldn’t be here alone. Mydei would have been nestled right beside him, where he should be.

He recalls the first time they sparred together at this rooftop, the frenzy as they attempted to one up the other, clashing in broad daylight amongst the sea of passing cityfolk below. Hours of combat had resulted in the two of them landing on their backs, side by side as they basked in the bright dawn and the blue skies. Ever since, this rooftop has held a special place in his heart. Call him sentimental, but that’s the truth. When it concerns Mydei, he latches on and never lets go.

His foot taps rhythmically against red, dusty tiles. A soft breeze brings the scent of spring, rustling his moonlight bangs as he gazes upon the city around him, the bright whites contrasting with the deep blues accented with gold. With a soft sigh, he plops down on the rug, one leg bent upwards, and turns his attention to the world-bearing titan carrying the dawn device atop its shoulders, the sole source of light in all of Amphoreus.

When Phainon had gotten a sudden and unwelcome request from Cipher for a casual chat, he had ignored her. He wasn’t in the mood to cater to her whims, not when it was already nearing parting hour, and he was in his nightrobes already.

You don’t want the ring back then? >:3c is how she responded when he left her on read. Phainon had stared down at his teleslate, repeating the words over and over until it clicked.

Embarrassing as it is to admit, he panicked and asked where and when.

Somehow, Cipher had broken into the villa without either him or Mydei noticing and had stolen the ring from where he had kept it tightly locked in his room. Even after all the precautions, she still saw through him and dug the ring out of the deepest corner of his closet. He had planned to keep it hidden—his treacherous secret—until he figured out the best time and method to give it to Mydei—if it were ever to arrive.

Time flies by. No Cipher in sight. He doesn’t even need to check to know it’s nearing the last quint of parting hour. He’s half tempted to leave, sleepiness burgeoning behind his eyelids.

Begrudgingly, he hoists himself up and steps into the shade of the nearby temple balcony. The cool, smooth stone wall feels good against his back, and he lets his eyes flutter shut. A quick reprieve before he has to deal with the inevitable.

Familiar footsteps echo, the harsh clink of metal greaves against white stone. Warmth burgeons in his chest, followed by a shred of unease. The rhythm isn't correct, faster than usual and not nearly as steady. A body lands firmly in front of him, and Phainon cracks an eye open.

"Deliverer," Mydei greets, in all his ferocious Kremnoan glory. He's even dressed in full armor—chest half exposed, golden greaves, gauntlets, heavy jewelry, and all.

Eh? Phainon blinks.

Last he had seen, Mydei, clothed casually in a loose tank top and chimera patterned sweatpants, had retreated into his room for the day. Once again, Phainon had tried to enter only to be pushed away in the same manner as before, the door roughly slammed in his face. It doesn't escape his attention how red Mydei's face had turned at even the briefest mention of Phainon entering.

He's hiding something, that's for sure. As for what that is, Phainon has little clue.

"Mydei!" Phainon greets, a wide smile blooming on his features despite the confusion. The presence of the other alpha is always a welcome surprise.

Blonde hair dipped in red sways lightly from the afternoon breeze. Mydei stands before him, arms crossed tight against his chest in that manner that has the round of his breast look even rounder, squeezing against the solid muscle of his forearms.

Phainon sucks in a breath. No, he's not staring. He's simply making an observation.

"Stop staring," Mydei says, only to pull his arms closer, pressing his chest tighter together. The motion doesn't go unnoticed by Phainon who has to forcefully yank his gaze away.

"I'm not," Phainon argues, though his eyes begin to wander once more. He clears his throat, "What brings you here, my dear prince? Did you miss me that much?"

He's about to say more, but a glint of gold catches his eye. There on Mydei's index finger is a ring—the signet ring. It looks good on him, perfect and fit for a king.

How does he have it? Phainon's stomach drops, and it doesn't escape his notice how Mydei's gauntlets have disappeared entirely. They were there only moments ago. When could they have…?

Oh.

Okay, this makes infinitely more sense.

Phainon narrows his eyes. "Cipher."

“Who?” Mydei questions.

“I know it’s you.” No wonder he felt so uneasy. This isn’t Mydei.

He should have known. The heir of trickery is known for her ability to shapeshift, changing her appearance and even pheromones in less than a blink of an eye. Her accuracy is uncanny, her disguises virtually indistinguishable from the genuine articles. Naturally, she has no scent —yet another alpha who’s able to control her pheromones.

Mydei—Cipher grins. “I have no clue what you’re talking about, *Deliverer*.”

“Give me the ring back,” Phainon sighs. “And stop with the Mydei disguise. It’s creepy.”

“You’re no fun!” Cipher pouts. Only she’s wearing Mydei’s face, and it has Phainon pausing in his step.

Mydei. *Pouting*. His plush bottom lip jutted out and trembling ever so slightly, complete with glimmering golden eyes lined with crimson. Oh titans. His head spins.

Cute. Mydei is so cute.

“Stop with the disguise,” Phainon repeats. “*Please.*”

“Mmm, how about no?” Cipher purrs, eyes curving in amusement. “I quite like it. I’m so tall and imposing… Amazing figure too!” As she speaks, she runs a gauntleted hand down the ridges and hard muscle of Mydei’s bare torso. “It’s no wonder he’s so popular with omegas.”

A snarl brews in Phainon’s throat.

Cipher laughs, “Besides, I can’t exactly take it off now. Everyone would see! It’d ruin the surprise if Aglaea were to hear that I’m back early. Humor me, will you?”

“How are you so sure she doesn’t already know? This is Aglaea we’re talking about.”

“I know my workarounds,” Cipher shrugs, baring sharp canines as she arches her back in a wide stretch and yawns.

Mydei’s canines aren’t nearly that sharp. How odd. Now that he thinks about it, they’re rather flat for an alpha.

“I didn’t think you’d be affected, but I guess I was wrong,” Cipher continues, tilting her head to the side as she places a hand on her chin. “Aren’t you the closest one to the little lion? You should have been the first to figure it out.”

Figure out what?

“He’s my comrade,” Phainon says, hesitant. “And fellow heir, as are you.”

Cipher scoffs, rolling her eyes in the same manner Mydei does when he’s annoyed at Phainon’s ceaseless antics. “You can’t be serious… Considering the gossip that the bathhouse

staff like to throw around, I'd expect you to say more than simple comrades." She turns away and mutters, "But that's just like you, isn't it? Tch."

Phainon can't help but squawk, his cheeks burning as he remembers what last transpired in the baths, the feel of Mydei on his lap, the warmth of their bodies in the hazy steam. "We're simply improving our camaraderie by bathing together! What do you mean the bathhouse staff are gossiping about us?! There's nothing that—"

He's shushed by the press of a finger against his parted lips. Cipher takes a step forward and leans in, closing their distance. Her voice comes out as a deep purr, "You look up to him. Am I correct?"

If he could, Phainon would have backed away. Unfortunately, the heel of his boot meets stone. "Is that a trick question?"

Cipher presses closer. Had she been in her usual form, he wouldn't have hesitated to slide out of the way, but his body doesn't move because *Mydei*.

Sharp golden eyes flecked with orange glint in the shadow. Her voice pitches lower, "*Answer me*."

His body reacts as if it were Mydei in front of him, caging him in, their bodies too close for comfort. He can hardly breathe, and he turns his head to the side to escape Cipher's piercing gaze.

He knows it's not Mydei. Rationally, he knows Mydei is probably asleep in the villa, snoring in that soft way he does, sounding too much like a content cat's purr. He catches his wits and says, "I'm taller than he is, as you can see." A few wild arm gestures later, he continues with a weak, "If anything, he looks up to me..."

Cipher's lips split into a predatory smile. She leans in until they're almost nose to nose, chest to chest, and Phainon fights the urge to shriek. His back is flat against the wall now, and the beginnings of panic brew hot, lighting his nerves.

Mydei radiates warmth, and like a foolish moth to flame, Phainon is drawn to it. He wants to lean in and capture what he hasn't allowed himself to have. What he doesn't deserve to have but wants so terribly.

No. Stop. This is Cipher. Even if she carries herself like Mydei does, it's still Cipher.

Beneath the patches and lotion, his pheromones burn and blister. Cipher grabs him by the chin and yanks his head back. Her nose wrinkles, and fear pierces through Phainon like an arrow.

"I'm being serious here. Doesn't happen often, but the situation is rather dire…"

"Can you get off me?" Phainon asks—*begs*. "What if people see? There's bound to be some misunderstanding…"

"I'll get off you if you stop with the deflection, boy."

“I’m not deflecting…”

Cipher slams her free hand beside Phainon’s head and continues to lean forwards.

“Fine! Okay, you got me!” Phainon acquiesces. Laughter bubbles in his throat. “Who doesn’t look up to Mydei? He’s something else. I can hardly describe him! I’ve never met anyone like him, and it’s astounding. He’s a beast on the battlefield—you should watch him fight, it’s inspiring—and he holds himself so effortlessly and fights for what he believes in. He’s a born leader, charismatic and confident—the perfect alpha who inspires awe wherever he goes. He has conviction, and he’s not afraid to be himself. Not to mention, he’s beautiful with a body carved by Mnestia herself. He’s…” Phainon coughs. “He’s everything… He—”

“He’s your equal, so I’m told,” Cipher cuts in. Golden eyes glint like she has him cornered. “But you don’t actually believe that, do you?”

“...” It hits like a slap in the face. To be told so forthrightly by someone he barely knows, it's almost insulting. His shoulders tense.

Mydei considers them equals, believes in it wholeheartedly and mentions it frequently, acting as if it’s effortless fact and not falsities concocted in the passionate throes of battle. Those ten days and nights they spent fighting, basking in each other’s presence, the heat of sweaty bodies clashing and entangling, all coalescing in the formation of their early relationship as equals, yet…

He can’t help but believe it as a joke or Mydei’s sincere attempts to placate him. He’s only a village boy—one thrust into the flamechase after the destruction of his home. Compared to Mydei, the crown prince of a city-state, leader and future king, he’s *nothing*. It’s day and night.

Mydei holds himself as such, effortlessly confident and commanding as if it were as simple as breathing. They aren’t alike in the slightest and for Mydei to even consider him an equal… it’s a miracle that Phainon, years later, can’t bring himself to fully believe.

He doesn’t need to respond. Cipher sighs and steps away. “Really, it’s no wonder. I miscalculated.”

“Miscalculated what?” Phainon asks. He can finally breathe again, Cipher’s suffocating presence bearing down on him gone.

“Remember what I told you last time?”

“You said many things.”

“The other heirs had no trouble seeing it,” Cipher muses. She looks over at him, eyebrows pinched in what looks to be concern…? Only this is Cipher, so there’s no way—

“There’s a lot going on up there, rascal. You sure you’re okay?” she asks. Her voice is still Mydei’s, and it squeezes Phainon’s heart to hear those words.

“I’m fine.” His response is instant, unyielding.

Cipher shakes her head, hand planted against her forehead. “You’re hopeless.” She twirls her braid around. “And so is he.”

Confused, Phainon responds, “You’ve never met him.”

“I’ve heard enough.”

He almost wants to ask her what she’s heard, if it’s the rumors or something else entirely. He opens his mouth only to lurch back when Cipher lands in front of him once more. There’s a flick of fingers against his forehead, then silence.

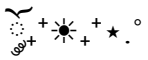
Phainon stares on, unblinking, unseeing.

It was gentle, not intended to hurt or impart much of an impact at all, but the change is palpable. He’s not sure what happened, but he feels lighter, like a weight has been pulled off his chest.

Something had shattered. Maybe his skull? He places a hand to his forehead to find the skin intact.

“There,” Cipher smiles, lips stretched wide in glee as if patting herself on the back. She wears Mydei’s appearance like she owns it, brightening his features in that exaggerated manner she prefers, but he finds that Mydei looks good smiling. He only wishes he had the ability to make Mydei smile like that.

“Now, off you go,” Cipher continues, handing Phainon the ring once more. “Go snag that little lion.”



Phainon quickly comes to learn that he’s the odd one out. The third wheel so to speak.

His head buzzes—Cipher’s words repeat in his head. She’s seen through him, and it’s terrifying. Not only is she unpredictable, she also doesn’t hide her dislike of him. He’s but an injured mouse caught in the grasp of a crafty cat, sharp claws sunken deep into his soft body. There’s no way she’s not planning something, but she also seems to be rooting for him? He’s a little conflicted there.

He stumbles his way back to the villa, the path a blur. If he trips on a stray rock here and there, that’s only for him to know and the odd cityfolk that walk the streets at this late an hour. The doors to the villa welcome him and he enters, ready to flop onto his bed only to come face to face with Castorice and Mydei cuddling.

Cuddling.

In Castorice's room. In her nest.

What in the Kephale is going on? Is he losing his mind?

He's in awe for a moment, unable to compute what's before him. Castorice's room is only a small distance away from his, and the door had been slightly ajar, revealing the two entangled together in the comfort of fluffy pillows and soft blankets.

His heart squeezes at the sight of the two of them so close. The full force of knowing that they're closer than he had previously believed hits him and knocks his breath away.

"He's asleep," Castorice whispers, glancing over at Mydei who's curled up against the cozy purples and whites of Castorice's nest, looking as if he belongs there. She smiles up at Phainon, and it does nothing to stop the bitter tang in his throat. "How may I help you, Lord Phainon?"

Mydei is clutching a pomegranate pillow to his chest as soft snores, barely audible, fall from his lips. It's a sight to behold, and Phainon's leg twitches with the urge to get a better look. He's still standing outside Castorice's door, keeping a respectable distance away.

An unmated alpha and an unmated omega nesting together. There's no mistaking it.

It could be that Castorice and Mydei are only friends, but it seems unlikely given the current situation. This isn't a matter of familial relations. His mood was already teetering on the edge, and now he feels even worse. This is the worst possible outcome for someone like him —someone so deeply in love with a fellow alpha who, most certainly, doesn't return the same feelings.

"Do you want to cuddle with him?" Castorice asks. Her voice pitches higher, eyes glimmering in excitement. He knows her and he can't be mad at her, not for long. She's a sweet soul. Most of the time that is.

Cuddling with Mydei… Phainon gulps.

His mind works on its own. The answer is obvious.

"It's your nest…" Phainon croaks out.

"I give you full permission!" Castorice beams.

No matter how much he wants to, he can't bring himself to cross that boundary.

Entering Castorice's nest to cuddle with Mydei when he's not conscious is wrong. Objectively wrong. He can't take advantage of Mydei like that, and while Castorice's scent is nice, he would rather not be surrounded by it even if he has Mydei, warm and purring contently, right beside him.

If only Mydei had his own nest, his own carved out space where they could cuddle together and indulge in each other. If only Mydei would allow him in instead of pushing him away. If only…



Phainon swears he’s going crazy. He likes Castorice, he really does, but he’d be lying if he didn’t admit that he preferred when she wasn’t here.

It’s horrible of him to feel this way, yet he can’t shrug off the negativity. He's a bad friend but even that admonishment does nothing to abate the bitterness. Why is that?

Because Mydei sticks to her side more than he does with Phainon—the brutal, honest truth.

It’s like the rug has been pulled out from under him and he’s nursing a huge bruise on his ass from where he fell. The hurt threatens to spill over, the twitching of his facial expressions whenever he sees the two of them together. He’s glad the scent patches and lotions are doing their job but now he’s layering on double just in case.

They even giggle over some inside jokes that Phainon has little clue about! He really is an outsider.

Phainon wonders… Does Mydei have a crush on Castorice?

He wouldn’t be surprised if he did. The image of him in her nest is seared into his brain at this point, and considering how close they’ve grown in a matter of weeks, it’s the most reasonable option. Mydei is one of many alphas that have taken to Castorice. He can’t even fault Mydei because of how sweet and kind she is—even with her curse of death—and how honeyed her scent is, irresistible to many alphas. It has Phainon pondering if Mydei moved into the villa to be closer to her. When did these feelings even begin? Probably recently, given their sudden change in relationship.

It’s especially strange how Mydei doesn’t succumb to her curse of death anymore. Phainon recalls the tournament where Mydei and Castorice armwrestled for the title of champion. Mydei had died, drifting over to the River of Souls, the light leaving his eyes for the briefest moments, thus ensuring Castorice’s sound victory. But now, he’s unaffected by her touches.

Could it be that they're compatible and meant to be together? No one else can stand to be within four paces of her, yet he acts as if her curse does not exist.

The thoughts run rampant, and the weight of the signet ring in his pocket continues to grow. There’s no way he can give this to Mydei, not now. He hides it in his closet once more. There’s no use in trying to hide it in a new spot because Cipher can swipe it whenever, but he’s not about to keep it in his pocket when it’s a constant reminder of his one-sided feelings.

Even if Mydei likes her, Castorice isn’t interested, not at all. If anything, she’s weirdly invested in getting them together. Had Phainon not read her very graphic and detailed stories, he would have believed that she simply supported their friendship. Now, he knows better.

There are monstrosities brewing in that innocuous purple notebook of hers, the one decorated with cutesy flower designs and hand-drawn chimera stickers.

Phainon can picture it. Kind of. Some of the positions that Castorice wrote about are nigh impossible to fulfill. One of them had him doing a handstand while Mydei bent down on all fours. He doesn't even want to think about the logistics of that nor the catastrophe that would ensue if he were to topple over. Though, he is intrigued by the position she calls the mating press. It sounds reasonable enough and the thought of folding Mydei in half is hotter than it should be.

From what he's had the pleasure—displeasure?—of reading, he's always the one fucking Mydei. And it begs the question, does Mydei know? Has he read her fantastical stories? What would he think? Would he object to it? Would he even care? Would he be upset that the omega that he's potentially clamoring over is writing graphic smut about him and his rival? There's much to think about, and he's getting wildly off topic. He's free falling off a ledge, and there's no ground in sight.

"Lord Phainon, please do me a favor," Castorice says, sitting at the table with her notebook—that accursed notebook—in front of her. She leans against her elbow and clicks her pen at random as she stares idly at the blank page.

The kitchen smells sweet of whipped cream and shortbread pastry. Mydei is meticulously slicing away at an assortment of colorful fruits, the intensity of his expression unbridled. He always has that look in his eye when he's focused, the one where the gold of his iris grows darker and his pupils narrow into slits like a lion honing in on prey.

"Yes?" Phainon asks.

"Stand behind Lord Mydei," she commands like a queen ordering her knight.

Curious, Phainon does as he's told. Knowing Castorice, he has a pretty good idea of what's coming next, but he never thought she would be this bold. He eyes Mydei, trying to gauge his reaction, but from this angle, he can only see the alpha bending down slightly as he continues his task.

In the midst of fashioning bunny shapes out of crisp apples and kitty shapes out of strawberries, Mydei remains unbothered by the commotion around him. Even when Castorice asks for Phainon to inch closer until they're nearly back to chest, he gives little reaction.

Phainon has to hand it to Mydei for his dedication. All of this work in the name of an overly intricate fruit tart that'll probably be consumed in mere minutes. Earlier, he had tried to sneak an apple slice only to have his hand unceremoniously slapped away. He's still a little miffed about that one.

"Now, wrap your arms around his waist."

"Huh?" Phainon squawks.

“Excuse me?” Mydei turns, hand wrapped around the hilt of his knife. The metal glints, strawberry juice drips, a silent threat.

“I need this for research purposes,” Castorice says, nodding to herself. “It’s super important. Now, Lord Phainon, if you will.”

“For your stories?” Phainon can’t help but ask.

“I’m doing a collaboration with Fig Stew. I need inspiration.”

“...” Mydei’s eyelashes quiver.

Phainon gasps. “Fig Stew?! Congrats! That’s wild! Does that mean you know who they are?”

“Uh, huh,” Castorice responds, smug in a way he’s never seen before. “Fig Stew gave me full creative control.”

“You still need to run the ideas through them. They can refuse,” Mydei says. “Deliverer, go make yourself useful and get the grapes out of the fridge.”

Castorice holds an innocent expression, soft amethyst eyes and a sweet smile. She nibbles her pen and says, “Fig Stew is very understanding and can be reasoned with. Now, Lord Phainon, wrap your arms around Lord Mydei’s waist. The grapes can wait.”

Phainon turns to face her.

“Grapes, Deliverer. *Now*.”

He turns back to look at Mydei.

“No! Wrap your arms around his waist. Don’t be shy. I know what you two get up to in the baths.”

He’s torn. His eyes flit from Castorice to Mydei back to Castorice then to Mydei once more. Mydei’s expression grows stern while the smile on Castorice’s lips stretches wider. He’s a rope pulled taut in a game of tug of war, a puppy being told by his lovely owners to do opposite things at once. He wants to please both of them but—

Mydei’s teleslate pings, and Phainon jumps at the opportunity to swipe it from the kitchen counter. “Got it!” He exclaims, louder than necessary, and squints his eyes to read, “Did you tell him yet?”

The teleslate is snatched out of his hand. With far too much force than necessary, Mydei stuffs it in his pocket before fixing Phainon with a deep glare.

Laughter bubbles in Phainon’s throat. *Cute.* Had Mydei’s cheeks not been flushed lovely pink, it’d be more menacing. Instead, he looks like a bullied maiden, eyebrows drawn together and long eyelashes quivering as he quickly turns away.

“Tell him what?” Phainon questions, curious. He glances over at Castorice who has begun to scribble wildly in her notebook while not meeting his gaze, purple bangs covering her face from view.

He leans closer, and Mydei *snarls* like a defensive kitten protecting its territory. He holds his kitchen knife in front of him, and his face has only gotten redder.

Phainon can’t help but grin. He pulls his arms up in mock surrender and says, “Calm down.”

A faint scent of pomegranate saturates the air, fragrant and soft. Only it dissipates as quickly as it came, leaving no trace of its existence.

“Grapes, Deliverer,” Mydei says—*commands*. His shoulders are squared as he turns back to finish the last of the strawberries. His ears are crimson now, and the giddiness only grows in Phainon’s chest.

Mydei is adorable. Radiant and powerful, yes, terrifying—especially on the battlefield— yes, but simultaneously the cutest person that Phainon has ever had the pleasure of meeting. And with his nape bared, messy red strands pushed away, Phainon finds himself approaching Mydei once more, his legs moving on their own. His fangs have begun to elongate with the anticipation of sheathing themselves into an omega’s neck.

Did he imagine it? The pomegranate that burst forth in the air, sweet and tart, lasting for less than a moment. His entire body tingles. His arms find their way around Mydei’s waist—narrower than what he expects for an alpha like Mydei—and he buries his nose in that pristine nape. Soft strands tickle his nose, the faint scent of mellow but fruity shampoo filling his senses.

He searches for the scent, lips pressed against the soft skin. Beneath his tight grip, Mydei stiffens, trembling ever so slightly like silent prey caught beneath the grasp of a curious predator.

“Oh, my…” Castorice murmurs, entranced.

Phainon’s tongue peaks out to have a taste, his fangs scratching softly against the smooth, feverish skin. A soft whine falls from Mydei’s lips—music to Phainon’s ears—yet he keeps still, stiff as a board.

“Perfect!” Castorice claps. The sound of pen scratching against paper grows louder, more fervent. “Stay there! Don’t let go, Lord Phainon. Even if Lord Mydei tries to push you away, you have to hold on!”

His fangs ache. The pomegranate scent is gone, but the fire has been lit, the flames stoked by the desire brewing in his chest.

“Mydei…” Phainon murmurs. The temptation to sink his fangs in is paralyzing. He continues to lick softly at the patch of skin as if attempting to ease out the sweet pomegranate that had permeated only moments before, as if Mydei owned that scent.

Only Mydei isn't an omega so there's no way that scent came from him… Right?

His body tingles. Did he envision it then? Mydei's skin is soft and supple. His fangs could pierce through with ease, drawing Mydei's cries and rivulets of golden blood. Mydei would bear his mark and—

An elbow to the gut has him slammed back to reality.



That night, Phainon fucks into his fist until his cock aches and his knot no longer forms. His fangs continue to ache with the need to pierce tender skin, and he bites his bottom lip until blood drips down his chin to stop from groaning out Mydei's name. They're separated, a few walls away, but he's already made a fool of himself too many times.

If Mydei were to hear him chanting his name while rutting into his fist, he would never live it down.

Little does he know, Mydei does the same. Fucks himself on his fingers until his vision whites, and he collapses into a heap of warm pillows and blankets.



Hyacine arrives early, little Ica floating beside her. In her hands is a platter of sweet meats, figs, and decadent cheeses.

She exclaims her greetings, her sweet features lit up with excitement as she chats with the three of them. It's then she notices the tacky antique vases stacked in the corner of the living room. A jarring new addition to the once harmonious decor.

Lounging on the living room *kline*, Phainon supplies, "I brought them over when I moved in. The best of my collection, and they're all real! Not a single fake in sight!"

"Right," Hyacine laughs. Her grip tightens around the platter as she forces a grin. "The living room does look more lively…"

The words process. In an instant, all joy is wiped away and the color drains from her face. Hyacine stares at the antiques as if they have personally offended her.

"..." Hyacine sways. Little Ica makes a loud trilling noise, nudging its face against her cheek.

Alarmed, Mydei starts, "Hyacine—"

"What do you mean you're living here?!" Hyacine shrieks. Her face cycles between horror, shock, and resignation before returning back to horror. The platter wobbles in her grip, and Mydei quickly grabs ahold of it before she inadvertently drops the entire thing.

"I moved in a week ago," Phainon recounts.

"*Why.*" Hyacine's voice pitches low.

Phainon blinks. "I wanted to live with my friends?"

"Oh, dear. No… Nonononono… This can't be happening…" Hyacine mutters. She shakes her head fervently as if trying to wake herself from a bad dream, pink pigtails bobbing wildly back and forth. With pleading eyes, she looks over to Castorice who is suddenly very interested in studying her nails.

"Hyacine," Phainon tests. "Are you okay? Do you need to lie down?"

"Fine!" Hyacine squeaks, giving a forced smile. "Amazing! Thank you for asking!"

The concern on Mydei's expression grows, and Phainon gives a nervous laugh. Castorice starts whistling, tapping her feet against the plush carpet as she grabs her cup of tea and chugs it in one go.

"Excuse us," Hyacine says before she stomps up to Mydei and clamps her hand around his wrist. Without another word, she drags him into the hallway.

A door slams, and Phainon is left deeply confused. He almost wants to chase after them, but little Ica blocks his way, shooting loud trilling noises whenever Phainon gets close. Turning to Castorice for help does nothing because all he receives is a shrug.

Defeated, he flops back onto the living room *kline*.

Okay, then. Left in the dark once more. He can't help but be a little worried, even if he knows that he's overreacting. Mydei is fine. Probably.

If that's the case then why did Hyacine look so scared?

Cipher arrives in all her cat-eared glory, ombre tail whipping back and forth as she greets them, a lilt to her voice. A sharp gaze rakes over his figure, and Mydei feels like a spotlight

has been dropped on his head. Again.

It's like she's picking him apart, pushing against the cracks in his armor and leaving him open to the elements. It's disconcerting to say the least. Does she do this with everyone?

"Little lion," Cipher grins, all glinting eyes and bright teeth. She looks at him in amusement as if she knows something he doesn't. She purrs as her sharp gaze trails him up and down. "You're bigger than I imagined."

It doesn't escape his notice how Phainon rolls his eyes. Cipher's grin grows wider, her fangs glinting in the bright light.

"This is Cifera," Aglaea says. "Cifera, this is Mydeimos." Her crystalline eyes glow brighter, warmer, and her tone of voice is lighter too, the same wistfulness present as when she first announced that Cipher would be visiting.

"Nice to finally meet you. I've heard a lot about you," Cipher purrs before turning to Castorice and winking.

Castorice coughs.

Even Anaxa arrives. It's the first time Mydei has seen the green-haired scholar, a beta, fellow Chrysos Heir even if he objects to the title and one of the Seven Sages of the Grove of Epiphany. Aglaea mentioned that he was the one who helped the village chief's daughter gain entry into the Grove.

There's no denying the odd tension in the air brought forth by his sudden appearance. Aglaea had requested all heirs at the gathering, and Anaxa had indeed followed her orders, only to state that he had visited for the sole purpose of greeting his previous students.

For a moment, Anaxa's gaze settles on Mydei, and Mydei feels like he's been seen through.

"Quite the complicated relationship they have," Cipher whispers into his ear as she watches the scholar exit the villa much to Aglaea's dissatisfaction.

Mydei nearly jumps. How did she get behind him?

The gathering carries on without a hitch.

Cipher sits beside him instead of next to Aglaea and spends half the time *staring* at him. When he turns to ask her what's wrong, she replies with a simple and quick, "Nothing!"

The dining table is grand, set up with dishes, fresh picked fruits, and beverages of all varieties. Aglaea brought drinks, artisan bottles of *assyrtiko* grape wine and aged honeymead, while Tribbie brought over fresh baked breads and specialties from Januspolis, juicy roasted meats and savory pies. Even Cipher arrived with a grand platter of seafood, and Mydei couldn't help but wrinkle his nose at the grilled octopus with olive oil and lemon. The tentacles, curled and charred to perfection, taunt him.

In the center of the table is the fruit tart that Mydei had so painstakingly crafted, strawberries, apples, and kiwis carved into animal shapes arranged artfully atop sweet vanilla custard and flaky pastry.

For the most part, Mydei stays quiet and lets the others do the talking. He simply observes, taking small bites of his food and offering his opinions every once in awhile. It doesn't escape him how Cipher, for all her lax attitude and wide cheshire smiles, seems at odds with herself, uncomfortable with Aglaea's presence but wishing to close the distance. There's a barrier between them, a separation that Cipher has built up.

If there's tension, Aglaea ignores it, even if she's cognizant of it. She's only happy to have Cipher back, and it has Mydei wondering what happened between them.

And this entire time, Hyacine eyes him like he's a bomb about to burst.

She had freaked out at him, panicking over Phainon living in such close proximity, and then slapped a scent patch on his nape. Mydei could only stare in shock as she told him point blank that he was definitely fucked. He had never heard her cuss before, didn't think she could, but she had been deathly serious.

It itches, the corners of the patch rubbing incessantly against his skin every time he moves his head. His fingers twitch with the desire to rip it off, but thankfully, his hair covers it from sight. He didn't panic then, and he doesn't panic now.

Maybe he should. Hyacine shifts in her seat, letting out nervous giggles every so often. Even Little Ica is unnerved, wings flicking as the unicorn nibbles on grapes.

Mydei takes a careful sip of his glass and tries not to wrinkle his nose at the astringency. Ugh. He doesn't take to wine or alcohol, and no matter how expensive or luxurious. It all tastes the same to him.

"Here," Phainon whispers, handing over a glass of pomegranate juice.

A kind gesture, so much like Phainon. "Thank you," Mydei whispers back.

Aglaea and Tribbie chat as they do, the conversation inevitably devolving into how to best destroy the Council of Elders and ensure prosperity of the flame-chase. It starts to get violent with Aglaea musing over different methods of using her golden threads to inflict pain and that's when Cipher cuts in with, "Let's talk about something different! More light-hearted, yes?"

Castorice's expression grows grim. She downs her alcohol in one go and reaches over to pour herself more.

"So, I heard some fun rumors going around. Regarding a little lion," Cipher purrs, swirling her cup of honeymead around as she reclines on her chair.

"Cifera," Aglaea speaks up, expression stern.

“I can’t help but be a little curious!” Cipher says as she takes a light sip. “It’s the talk of the city. ”

Her kaleidoscope eyes glint, egging him on. Mydei responds with a simple, “They are unfound.”

Phainon scoffs and murmurs, “Yeah, sure. Remember when you told me that you fucked her for days and brought her back to fuck her some more?” Only he says it a bit too loudly, and the entire table quiets.

Mydei glares, cheeks burning, and Cipher chokes on her drink.

Castorice downs another glass, and Hyacine joins her.



In the hours following the gathering, Mydei had spent much of his time cleaning. Phainon had been called away once more and left in a hurry, while Castorice had retired early after much coaxing from Mydei’s part.

A peaceful end to a rather hectic night. He had wiped his hands on the kitchen towel before making his way back to his room. The day’s events had worn him out and he couldn’t wait to finally make it to the safety of his bed.

Only he finds his door ajar. At first, he thinks it’s Phainon’s room, but the closer he approaches, the more confused he gets.

His room had been tightly locked before the gathering began. He checked once. Twice. Then checked again. He had even debated throwing all the pillows and blankets into the closet, making his room appear as it had when he first moved in, but stopped himself short. It was the paranoia speaking.

So, how…?

How could his door be open?

Phainon is standing there with back turned. The click of pills hitting plastic echoes in Mydei’s ears.

“Omega suppressants,” Phainon murmurs, rolling the bottle in his hands. He glances at the other bottle. “And omega scent blockers.”

Mydei rushes in. “What are you doing in my room?”

Phainon turns. “Where did you get these?”

The white bottle in his hand. Mydei's blood runs cold.

"They're medications. Why do you look so shocked?" Mydei says, voice remaining remarkably even, even with the thundering of his heart against the confines of his chest.

"Omega suppressants from Hyacine," Phainon responds. Blue eyes glance over to the mountain of pillows and thick crimson blankets. Rumpled, moonlight fabric rests on a golden pillow, contrasting against the deep, dark colors of the surrounding nest.

Mydei can hardly breathe. He wants to scream at Phainon to get out, but the words don't leave his throat. A million thoughts run through his mind, countless possibilities. None of this makes sense.

His door had been locked. He triple checked it beforehand, ensuring that no one would be able to enter. There's only one key, the one he keeps in his… It's gone.

Fuck.

"So, this is what you've been hiding…" Phainon's grip tightens on the bottle, indenting the thin plastic.

Everything, the entire setup, the bottles out on his counter, his nest fluffed up with Phainon's chiton out on display, it's all been placed there on purpose. He had hidden the bottles in his nightstand cabinet and the chiton in the confines of his closet. How—How are they out?

"I didn't hallucinate that scent either," Phainon murmurs, more to himself than to Mydei. "It's been growing stronger these past few days… I thought there was no way, since I've been by your side this entire time. When could you have snuck off?"

"Deliverer—"

"Mydei." Phainon takes a step closer, blue eyes flashing beneath the lamplight. "Is there something you'd like to tell me?"

Chapter End Notes

im not a ragebaiter i swear >:3c

thanks for reading!

twitter (come yap with me abt phaidei!)

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

hi, i'm back with another chapter! this is a fun one, i promise 🤭

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A whirlwind of excuses run through his mind—all weak and none remotely believable.

Phainon is awaiting a response, but what can he feasibly say? *Those aren't my suppressants, they're for the mysterious, faceless omega I've been fucking behind everyone's back. You know, the one that brought you into rut, the one that you're so desperate to find even though you proclaim to dislike omegas and want nothing to do with them.*

It's a weak excuse, and he's already been found out. A part of him wants to run, but where is there to go?

No. He won't run. He *can't* run, not when the truth is staring him in the eye and demanding him to cower. He keeps his feet planted firmly on the floor and lifts his chin up, challenging Phainon's authority. To submit is the lowliest of actions.

Regardless of how hard he tries, he can't help the embarrassment that curls in his chest, nor the burning of his ears. He's glad it hasn't migrated over to his face, though his lips tremble and his heart rattles.

"This is what you've been hiding from me. This entire time…" Phainon's expression falls. He twirls the bottle of suppressants in his hand. "It's no wonder why Aglaea was so insistent about the rumors…"

Phainon stares over at Mydei's nest, impeccably neat and arranged *deliberately*, inviting any passing alpha to take a good look. Only a *proper* omega could have created such a beautiful nest, arranged artfully with silken pillows and soft plushes and covered in thick, warm blankets. Phainon's gaze trails over the nest to its center—the rumpled moonlight chiton laid atop a pillow, the star of the show.

The urge to bolt grows overwhelming. He stays grounded. A warrior doesn't run, even if his leg twitches and the voice in the back of his head screams about how he's made a grave mistake. It's irrational. He can handle Phainon just fine. There's that other part of him, the lingering shadow, that whispers for a fight.

"Who else knows?" Phainon asks, voice low, almost scratchy in quality.

The air seems to grow thicker with each word. His eyes hurt from the lamplight.

Mydei says nothing, only continues the haughty expression on his face. Phainon can take his silence however he wishes. There's little else that needs to be said.

After all, Phainon had broken into his room. He doesn't *deserve* answers. Anger burgeons in his chest at the thought. How dare he? To be disrespected like this, to have his privacy thrown away, by his closet ally and friend no less.

"Aglaea and Tribbie know, I'm sure of it. Castorice must also know, given you live with her and she lets you into her nest like it's no big deal. Hyacine because she's the one who gave you these medications and she's very particular about giving out those specialty medications. Cipher knows because she…" Phainon trails off, turning his head to the side to hide the twist of his expression. "Forget it."

The windows are strewn shut, and the room is warm, two bodies sharing the same space.

"Bravo," Mydei says, forcing the words out. "Should I clap for you, now that you've figured it out? Perhaps, a celebration is in order since you've finally grown a brain."

The wide-eyed look Phainon gives—the *audacity*—has Mydei sneering.

His door is still ajar. His chest feels like it's about to burst, and his vision streaks red. Why is Phainon even in his bedroom? How did he even get in? The nest was placed by someone else, that much rings clear, so someone must have led him here.

It's mortifying to be caught like this, to be exposed in such a forthright manner. Shame is a bitter taste in his mouth, but he swallows it down, pushes that accursed feeling aside, and stomps on it until it's gone. Only rage remains. His voice comes out low. "Everyone else found out without me saying a thing, yet you've stayed ignorant to the truth this entire time. What does that say about you, Deliverer?"

"You were attempting to hide this from me to begin with," Phainon says, eyes downcast and eyebrows pinched. "All the deflections, the promises. You made me think you were… I didn't want to push you too far, but I also didn't understand why you were so secretive."

"We all have our secrets." Mydei stomps up to the alpha and snatches the suppressants out of his hand. He leans closer, golden eyes burning. "You're not completely honest with me either. Don't act like you aren't hiding from me—from all of us."

"Mydei…"

He sets the bottle down, rattling the wooden nightstand. "What does that say about you, Deliverer, when you believed me to be the kind of promiscuous alpha to sleep with an omega maiden and break her heart?"

Out of all the heirs, Phainon knew him the best. Or at least, that's what he had tricked himself into believing. Perhaps, it was only wishful thinking that kept him from seeing what was in front of him.

"That's not…" Phainon trails off, fidgeting with his hands. "I never…"

“That’s not what? I told you that the rumors had no basis, yet you continued to press and even went behind my back expressly because you didn’t believe me. So, is that not it? You don’t view me the way the other heirs do. You view me in the *same* manner as the ones that throw around the rumors as if they are fact, and that’s why I could never tell you the truth. The other heirs didn’t need me to tell them. They *knew*.”

“I…”

“Nothing to say for yourself?” Mydei scoffs. The corner of his eyes burn, tears forced down as he takes a steadying breath. He won’t cry, hasn’t in years. He’s not about to start now. “Of course.”

Phainon remains quiet, unable to meet his gaze. The energy has been drained out of him, and he resembles more a wilted plant than angry alpha, as Mydei had hoped.

It’d be easier if Phainon were to get angry. They could clash with their fists instead of their words. Less heartache. They would speak with their bodies, and Mydei could lose himself in the heat of battle instead of the thoughts making a mess in his head.

“Who I decide to entangle with is none of your business,” Mydei says. He catches a glimpse of himself in the mirror, the hard angles and planes of his body, the muscles that adorn his frame. He doesn’t look like an omega, not at all. It’s no wonder people believe him to be an alpha, and he never cared to correct them.

But he wants his words to hurt, wants Phainon to know that there are boundaries that shouldn’t be crossed. Had Phainon desired him, maybe it’d be a different story, but to be told time and time again, that he disliked omegas for reasons that sound more like excuses than anything else. The secret is out now. There’s no more hiding. He only hopes their relationship doesn’t change too much, but that’s only wishful thinking on his end. It’s too late.

Phainon jolts. The air saturates, the scent of charred ash and burning flora flourishing, spilling free from the confines of the patch behind his nape—the same type of patch that Mydei wears.

Mydei can’t help the baring of his teeth. His nape tingles. Already, his body is reacting in ways that it shouldn’t, in ways that it wouldn’t have had the medications still worked. He hates it.

He shouldn’t be feeling this way. Before he knows it, he’s grabbing Phainon by his collar and slamming him into the wall, a loud thud resounding in the air. His gauntlets aren’t on, nor are the heavy plates of his golden armor, but he’s still rearing for a fight.

Phainon allows it to happen, allows himself to be cornered. “I guess you’re right.”

Fingernails dig into fabric. The ache between his legs blooms. “I rather be judged by the strength of my character and by the choices I make rather than my secondary gender. You broke into my room, Deliverer. Do you have anything to say about that?”

“I… I didn’t…” Phainon trails off, eyes flitting around as if searching for something. “That wasn’t—”

“What was it then? Say it clearly.”

“This was an accident,” Phainon says. “I…” He sucks in a breath and looks away. “Never mind. There’s no use. I’m sorry, Mydei.”

The villa is quiet, not a noise, when it had been bustling only a few hours ago. Glasses clinking, laughter bright in the evening air as the heirs feasted and enjoyed each other’s company. Now, it’s only the two of them. He only hopes they don’t wake Castorice.

Phainon’s snowy lashes quiver. He shifts, uncomfortable, yet not a word leaves his lips.

The silence is deafening. He can hear the thump of his heart, the sound of their joint breathing, the rhythmic rise and fall of their chests. Phainon is warm beneath him, their bodies only centimeters apart.

It’s hard to keep the anger, when embarrassment claims all in its wake. It slips through his fingers, falling away like leaves come autumn. There’s that part of him, what he knows now as that accursed omega instinct that begs for him to stop. Each breath he takes is Phainon, the scent of him, the feel of him. He loosens his hold on the alpha’s shirt and lowers his gaze, blonde bangs hiding his expression.

It’s dangerous. Breathing in Phainon’s unrestrained pheromones like this when he’s already teetering on the edge.

“Control yourself,” Mydei says. His nape stings, pomegranate tinging the already thickened air.

There’s an aura around Phainon, and his gaze is empty, almost unseeing. The alpha takes a step forward. Mydei takes a step back, attempting to maintain distance, even if he had been the one to first breach the barrier. It’s hard to keep a clear head when he’s unsure of how he should feel, when the throb between his thighs halts the thoughts in his head.

Mydei falls back first onto his bed, nestled into the crimson and gold pillows of his nest.

Something wet lands on his cheek.

For a moment, he’s stunned. He’s never seen Phainon cry. Never thought the sunny Deliverer who wore bright grins and had the loudest laughter would ever be caught looking like *this*. Phainon is a stubborn man, never betraying any such emotion that would compromise him and the persona of golden boy he’s held onto for years. For him to shed tears, for him to show such unbridled emotion, he must have hit a nerve.

Phainon looms over him, tears falling from blue eyes. “You don’t trust me. I thought—I really thought…” He laughs, a touch bitter. “One-sided. Of course. I guess, that’s how it is.”

“If I had it my way, you would have never found out.”

Push and pull. That's how they always are. Only this time, it's the wrong thing to say.

"Why?" Phainon asks. "*Why*?"

The question sears itself into his mind. Why? Why did he hide? Why did he run from the truth, denying reality in pursuit of a version of himself that no longer existed?

Because it's easier this way. Because as long as no one else finds out, the flame-chase can continue, and he doesn't have to deal with the added baggage that comes with being an omega in a society that prizes alphas for their strength and worth. Because he doesn't want Phainon to view him as anything but an equal.

Because Phainon admitted point blank that he doesn't like omegas and that alone makes him want to hide.

It's pathetic, really, but what else can he say? He's held the truth for this long. The seed had been sown long ago.

"We all have our secrets."

Phainon stares down at him. The tears continue their path.

Even crying, he still has that radiance. Mydei has to remind himself to be angry, to hold himself back from reaching out and attempting to placate the crying alpha. He shouldn't be feeling this way. Guilt and anguish shines in those blue eyes, and Mydei turns away, his gaze focused on the pillows beside him instead of Phainon's face for fear of his own reactions, his own weakness.

Mydei murmurs, "Had you known that I was an omega, would you have treated me the same or would you look at me the way you're looking at me right now?"

It's an admission unlike any other, one that's been strapped to his throat since he presented, awaiting release, awaiting the moment to let free. Each breath is suffocating, coating his lungs in thick ash. His body reacts. Slick leaks out of him, making a mess between his thighs, and his clothing feels too tight against his feverish skin.

Phainon's gaze flickers down to the scent patch on Mydei's nape. Mydei's eyes widen at the pressure on his neck, the warmth of calloused fingers against the scratchy fabric.

Fingers trembling, Phainon pulls it off and sweet pomegranate bursts forth, saturating the air. Before Mydei even knows what he's doing, his neck is bared in offering. He screws his eyes shut and *waits*.

Something snaps. Phainon steps back, eyes blown wide.

"Mydei," he whispers. He reaches out, only for Mydei to shrink away from his touch. "I—I didn't mean to—"

Castorice runs in, purple pigtails fluttering about. Her expression is dire as her gaze flits between the two of them, Mydei trembling on the bed and Phainon's look of guilt. She steps

in front of Mydei and summons her scythe, pointing it at Phainon's direction.

"Lord Phainon. I implore you to leave," Castorice says. "Go speak with Lady Hyacine."

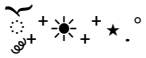
Phainons hesitates. Blue eyes scan the premises, searching for something just out of reach. When he doesn't find it, he wilts and leaves without another word, no goodbyes, no smiles, only a turn of his heel as he walks out the door.

He doesn't slam it. The silence speaks more than enough. Had Phainon been angry, it would have been a different story to tell. Mydei would have preferred the anger, instead of the hurt.

But Phainon is Phainon. He doesn't allow himself the anger.

"Lord Mydei, are you hurt?" Castorice asks, searching for any sign of injury.

"I'm fine," Mydei says, then takes a deep breath. He lays a hand over his eyes, blotting out the light. "He knows. Castorice, he *knows*."



The longer he stays in this room, the worse it gets. Phainon's scent remains seeped into the fabrics and silks of his nest until he's drowned in the scent of destruction. There's no sweet spring, no lavender, no bulrushes flourishing in a light breeze.

Regardless, Mydei tries to sleep. This is his room, his place of comfort, he's not about to leave it now. Unfortunately, he can't, tossing and turning, making a mess of his nest, with no reprieve.

Still, he tries. Another quint later, and he's beginning to feel the weight of sleep overtake him until he shifts onto his back and is met with something hard and lumpy. It's small, around the size of a coin, yet noticeable and irritating. He'd be content to ignore it if he wasn't already in a bad mood.

With his sleep interrupted, terrible as it was, he digs beneath the blankets and pulls out the object of his discomfort. Even in the dimness of his room with the windows strewn shut, he can make it out as a ring—golden and carved with the symbol of Nikador.

"This is…" Mydei stares down in awe. He almost can't believe it, but this is no dream.

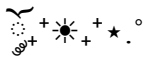
It's not possible, yet… It's here. In his hands.

His mother's signet ring.

Though he can't prove it, operating purely off instinct alone, he knows it's hers. It has to be.

He turns on his bedside lamp and holds the ring up, watching as the gold glimmers in the light. Scratch marks show its age, worn by the tides of time and the perilous waters of the sea of souls. It's no fake.

"How…?" Mydei murmurs, eyes wide. "How did this get here…?"



Hyacine's office smells like sugar and vanilla. Her desk is covered in a tower of desserts, cakes and pastries of all kinds. It's almost like she's brought a whole bakery's worth of sweets.

Little Ica flies in a flurry of rainbow, loud trilling noises filling the room. The plump pegasus scours the near endless options before landing on a batch of confetti cupcakes.

"Don't eat too fast," Hyacine chides. Little Ica snorts and flies away with the entire box.

With a small smile, Hyacine offers Mydei his pick of pastry, stating that the baker had brought them over as a thank you gift, but he declines. He's not hungry, his appetite quelled by the heat between his legs and the constant ache that rolls down his spine at interval.

Castorice chooses a strawberry danish, dripping with thick, sweet custard, and takes a seat beside him.

It only takes Hyacine a few moments to look him over. She doesn't even need to lay a hand on him before she's telling him the bad news. "You're in pre-heat again."

He had steeled himself for it, for her to say those damned words, but regardless, he reacts. His breathing seizes. Quickly, he swallows it down and says, "Is there any way to stop it from occurring?"

It's a futile attempt. He should have listened to her when he had the chance. He had so many chances, yet he blew it. Even Castorice had warned him.

The scent patches remain a weight on his nape, scratchy and annoying. He dreads having to wear them, unable to get used to the muffled feeling. Is it even worth wearing at this point? His scent had leaked through and so had Phainon's.

Castorice has a grim look on her delicate features. She says nothing, only shakes her head, familiar as she is with the prospect of the medications failing.

They both warned him, but he couldn't help the need to be by Phainon's side. He was used to it, used to the bright laughter, the warm presence, the push and pull. It was only a matter of time.

He’s not the exception to the rule. If only he were.

“Suppressants are the only way to fully stop heats.”

Desperate, Mydei asks, “Can I up the dose? Are there any natural remedies? Anything?” His voice pitches higher at the end. He’s grasping at straws, he knows, but there has to be something he can do.

Hyacine shakes her head. “Upping the dose will do nothing but worsen your condition. There are natural remedies, but those are poisons and will have you bleeding out for weeks.”

Going through heat is horrifying, worse than even the most bloody of battles, worse than the years spent floating in the sea amidst nothing but monsters lurking, awaiting the chance to shred through flesh. He doesn't know why. By all means, it’s irrational. Heats are a natural process that all omegas have gone through, but the idea of it sets his nerves alight with panic.

He’d rather take a thousand deaths than be incapacitated in such a manner. His throat closes.

“I’ll take the natural remedies,” Mydei forces out. “I can’t go through—”

“*No*,” Hyacine interrupts. Her tone is final, not up for argument, and Mydei’s words wither on his lips. She sighs and continues, “Lord Mydei, I know it’s scary, but it’ll be okay, I promise. Heats don’t have to be terrible. It’ll be over before you know it.”

Castorice lays a gentle hand on his shoulder. “You’ll be fine, Lord Mydei. We’re here for you.”

Her words make him feel a little better, but still, he doesn’t want to go through with it. He supposes this is divine retribution. If this is what it comes down to, then so be it. He’ll survive. Changed, but alive.

“We’ll prepare everything you need.” Hyacine straightens her posture and exclaims, “You can count on us!”

Finished with the cupcakes, Little Ica shoots a loud trill and flies onto Mydei’s lap.

“Okay,” Mydei relents, running his fingers through Ica’s soft coat. “I still have some time, yes? You said pre-heat, not heat.”

“I’d wager another day or two, but that’s a generous estimate.”

They make some idle conversation while Hyacine files through her cabinets for supplies. Castorice samples all the sweets, favoring the ones with fresh fruit over the heavier chocolate and vanilla cakes. She splits them with Little Ica, the two of them on a mission to try a little bit of everything.

“Don’t feed Ica anything with coffee,” Hyacine warns. “He gets the zoomies.”

Hyacine gestures for Mydei to follow her into her backroom where he’s shown a startling variety of fake knots and silicone toys. He’s no prude, but the thought of fucking himself on a

dildo as thick as his forearm is… alarming, to say the least.

Does this count as medical supplies? He's not too sure.

"Uh," Mydei says, dumbfounded. "Do you have anything smaller?"

Hyacine's smile is as sweet as the desserts that cover her desk. She chooses a blue one with a thick knot, around the size of his fist. "It's best you get used to this size." She speaks with such innocence, as if she isn't handing him a weapon of mass destruction.

How foreboding.

He tries not to look at it for too long but it's so in his face, and it's wobbly too. He wonders how it'd feel inside him only to realize he rather have the real thing—

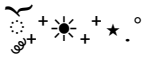
Eager to change the subject, Mydei asks, "By the way, did the Deliverer come to see you?" Tentatively, he places the dildo on a nearby shelf. He doesn't want to think about it. That's a later problem.

Hyacine's expression grows grim. She picks out lube, towels, heat pads, amongst other supplies. "He set out on a mission after I met with him. I don't know the specifics or when he's due to return."

"I see." Of course.

His anger had gotten the best of him. He shouldn't have lashed out like that, but what's done is done. He only hopes Phainon stays safe. Normally, they would tackle missions together, but he's sure the last person Phainon wants to deal with is him.

It's for the best that he's not here. Easier this way, for the both of them.



Mydei groans, burying his face in his pillow. Sweat beads down his temple, blonde bangs sticking against forehead in wet clumps.

The fire rages on. His breathing comes out ragged, punctuated by soft groans and gasps, as he tosses and turns, unable to find a comfortable position, not with the way each slight shift brings electricity racing down his spine. An ache brews inside him, hot and unrelenting.

His thighs tremble, and his cock is hard. Still, he refuses to sate his base urges. He wants so badly to rut into a pillow, to fuck himself open on his fingers or on that accursed dildo Hyacine had given him, the one standing proud on his bedstand, clean and ready to be used, but he refrains. He's holding onto the last vestiges of his sanity until the haze of heat claims all remaining reason.

The golden blood running through his veins isn't doing him any favors. Heirs naturally have stronger heats and stronger ruts, he had been told.

Regret is a bitter taste on his tongue. He should have listened to Hyacine. She had warned him repeatedly on what to do and what not to do, yet her words had fallen on deaf ears. He wanted to be close to Phainon, wanted to take in the warmth of the man that he fell in love with on that fateful day years ago.

To sacrifice what he had with the Deliverer was out of the question, even if the damage would be astronomical.

And now, he's here. Nursing a throbbing ache between his thighs, slick leaking out in rivulets and making a mess of his blankets and bedsheets. The cramps too, overwhelming and leaving him breathless with each seize of his abdomen.

He knew it was coming, but that doesn't make it any easier.

Along with the plethora of supplies given to him by Hyacine, the other heirs have brought their own additions to his nest. A teddy bear from the triplets, a pastel unicorn plush from Hyacine, some silken robes from Aglaea, a chimera onesie from Castorice, and even a dromas pillow from Anaxa. Cipher also brought him some cat patterned blankets and some specialty pomegranate tea from a Kremnoan cafe he long favored.

It warms him, knowing how much they care, yet the hole remains. There's one missing.

Nothing from Phainon. The rumpled moonlight chiton has long lost any source of scent.

He wonders, if Phainon had been here, would he have brought something too? Or would he be too disturbed by the notion of him going through heat to even bother?

The signet ring glimmers on his ring finger. He stares down at it, tracing the seal of Nikador with his eyes. It's a comfort, knowing that his mother is here with him in spirit. He doesn't know how the ring managed to find its way into his bed, but he's not complaining. He cradles it to his chest, and brings Phainon's chiton to his nose, a futile attempt to wrangle any scent of the alpha left in the thin fabric.

The blankets wrapped around his body suffocate him, yet they're not enough. Chills run down his spine at interval yet sweat beads at his temple, unbearably cold and blistering hot all at once. A part of him wants to kick off his blankets completely and rip his robes off, stifling as they are against his feverish skin.

The windows are strewn shut and the lights are off. His door is closed, but not locked. Castorice is only a few doors away, ready to help if he were to call for it, and Hyacine had moved into the villa temporarily as well.

It's almost pathetic, being a grown adult and having to go through his first heat. He's been through wars, through battles that lasted months on end, through the loss of allies and friends, but nothing made him feel like this —powerless like the days of the old, back when he had no one but himself, back when his days were spent fighting for his life, fighting for the right

to exist, back when he had been drifting in the sea of souls, a mere child torn apart by monster after monster until he learned how to fight back.

The wetness between his thighs grows and grows. He finds his fingers moving down, pressing into that slick warmth. He spreads his legs wide, fingers teasing his hole in small circles.

If only Phainon were here. If only…

Every nerve in his body is lit up, and he's left twitching and out barely in control of himself. It feels like he's burning from the inside out, and his scent pours out of him, unrestrained.

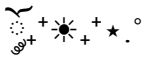
He hates this. To lay here and succumb is antithesis to his ideals. He will fight until his last breath. Perhaps, the strength of his will will overcome the heat that wracks his body.

Another bad choice in a basket of many. Mydei pulls himself out of bed and begins to dress, pulling on his armor even as goosebumps rise and chills roll down his spine. The press of cold metal against his feverish body has him wincing, and his gait is unsteady as he makes his way out the door. He doesn't care how off-kilter he must look.

He has to do something. Anything. He won't allow himself to lay in bed, wasting away as he allows the heat to claim him.

Maybe he could venture into the evernight. Kill a few monsters and have his heat in the cold and the dark where no one could see. He'd be screwed if titankin and black tide monstrosities were to find him, but he wouldn't die. At least, not permanently.

A dull ache centers on his tenth thoracic vertebrae—a reminder of his morality though he is immortal. His one weakness. His only physical weakness. He does bear another in the form of an alpha that does not desire him—yet another secret he will keep until it's inevitably forced out of him.



When he arrives at the Kremnoan district, all eyes are on him. Once again, the spotlight is shone down. His countrymen watch him, surprised to find the crown prince has returned. He should be used to the attention, used to the gazes, ranging from adoration to fear to slightly veiled anger, but he's grown used to the calm of the villa, grown used to the comfort that wasn't prying eyes and loud whispers.

The Kremnoan district smells of alpha. There are more alphas here than any other secondary gender as compared to the relatively balanced distribution in the rest of Okhema. After all, the detachment had been mostly soldiers, alphas that had fought with him, ones that had left

Castrum Kremnos to forge a new path with the flame-chase. Some had wives, families, but many did not.

He makes his way down the cobblestone path to the training hall, gleaming gold and silver in the dawn's bright rays. The Kremnoan royal sigil is carved into the stone pillars at the front, a reminder of the empire that once was. His boots echo against stone, and he keeps his head up, his strides confident, while fighting the urge to bare his teeth at any passing alpha. A few of his countrymen greet him, and Mydei nods at them in acknowledgement, no words said.

When he enters, the pungent mix of alpha pheromones and sweat hits full force, stinging his nostrils. He nearly recoils, a slight stumble to his step, and a momentary hesitation.

The sudden arrival of the crown prince has the day's regimen cut short. Fire roars inside Mydei's body, begging for release. He calls out for his countrymen to spar him. They crowd around the center, the veteran soldiers being the first to try their hand at fighting him.

He bares his teeth and channels all the anger and frustration into his hits. There's no mercy to be had. Many of the veterans have seen him on the battlefield, have seen him tear through a legion of titankin with his bare hands, know how aggressive he could be when given the chance, but not the new soldiers. The omega recruits watch in a mix of awe and fear, and when one tries his hand at joining the arena, Mydei stops him a jerk of his head.

"Not now," Mydei snarls, unable to ease his tone into something nicer. "Not today."

The recruit jumps back, face red as he stumbles out an apology.

His gauntlets run red. The older soldiers can handle him, know what it's like to be injured on the battlefield, while the newer ones can't. Scars are a badge of honor for Kremnoans and to bear the marks of the crown prince—of Kremno's strongest warrior—is an honor for many. Even so, he will not spar the younger recruits, not when he's like this. It's ironic, but he has little care for that when his lips curl into a sneer at the arrival of a new alpha challenger to the arena.

Alphas become stronger during ruts, channeling that pent-up energy into battle. It's why the fiercest warriors were the ones in the midst of violent ruts, all inhibition destroyed, only a need to claim. But omegas in heat? It's a different story entirely.

His countrymen shout. Mydei loses himself to the heat of battle instead of the wetness between his thighs. It's still there, but less prevalent when his energy is spent punching and kicking and snarling. He throws an upper cut to his opponent's and the man is thrown a good distance away, tumbling onto the floor.

Mydei approaches, a slow prowl, golden eyes constricted to pinpricks. This alpha's scent pisses him off. As do the scents of all the other alphas around him, a nauseating concoction that has every cell in his body on fire. He rejects them, rejects these alphas with their thick, cloying scents, even if the ache between his legs grows ever more pronounced.

Thankfully, his pants are dark and his cape covers his backside from view. For extra caution, he had slapped two scent patches on his nape and one on each wrist. He even added one on

his lower abdomen. All hidden, but enough to soak up any pheromones that may try to escape.

The alphas around him are unable to detect his scent yet they react. It doesn't escape Mydei's attention how the air in the hall has thickened substantially since his arrival. The omega recruits begin to shift, airing out their collars, uncomfortable by the change.

The ones that fight against him, clashing blow after blow, fare the worst. Arousal in their eyes, pheromones flourishing. Mydei almost rips a soldier's throat out, only stopping when Krateros jumps in to mediate. The man's scent flares, offensive and vile, sticking to the inside of Mydei's throat.

Agitated, the alpha, broad shouldered and handsome face weathered with age, wipes his brow, smearing blood down his temple, and barks out. "Which one of you useless bitches is in heat?" His gaze roams to the omega recruits, disdain in his dark eyes like the very sight of them is enough to ruin his day.

Confused, the omega recruits stare at each other. It's obvious that none of them are in heat, no flushed faces, no signs of arousal, whilst Mydei's face has taken a permanent shade of rosy pink. His breathing comes out ragged, and if one were to look closer, they could see the glassiness in his usually sharp golden eyes and the tremble of his thighs.

A few others nod in agreement.

"There's a reason why Kremnoan tradition dictates omegas are for the home." The man's gaze lands on Krateros. "Are we so desperate as to need the extra bodies? They can barely fight! They're a liability. It's despicable how far we've fallen."

"You have decades of experience. They have barely started. To proclaim they can barely fight when I recall you struggling to keep up when you first began certainly is a choice," Krateros says, calm. He doesn't seem too surprised by the outburst, though he does eye Mydei like he *knows*.

"A bitch in heat is a liability," the man repeats. His grip tightens on his sword.

Krateros stands firm. "Change is necessary. Staying in the old ways will not do us any favors."

"Stop with this madness," Mydei snaps, forcing himself between the two. "If you are to argue, you will not do it here."

"You have little to do with this, your highness. This is between me and Krateros. Kindly, excuse us."

"I will not," Mydei says. "This has everything to do with me. You will not cause a ruckus in this hall."

The alpha sneers and sheathes his sword, rattling the leather scabbard. "Quit the pretense. You're never around anymore, too busy sucking up to the Okhemans and forgoing your

people for hedonistic pleasure. At least you still have the ability to fight, even if your form is lacking."

"*Enough*," Mydei says. He steps forward. His vision sways.

The reds and golds of the tapestry lined walls mesh together, the crest of the Kremnoan empire little more than a blur. The soldiers around him clamor, hundreds of eyes focused on the three of them.

"The way you're defending them is suspicious. Have any of those whores caught your fancy? Perhaps, the one with the long legs and the light hair. He looks like the Deliverer boy, yeah? Just your type."

Mydei bares his teeth. He's about to grab the man by his crimson *chlamys* when Krateros intervenes.

"It is as his highness said, enough," Krateros says before he's forcefully dragging Mydei away. "Get back to training. *All of you*."

Even with the iron restraint that Kremnoan soldiers are taught to have, fights are common. It's inevitable, with so many alphas crowded about in the same space, spending day in and day out with little reprieve. The barracks get messy, especially when recruits become of age, their ruts making them more prone to aggression.

Mydei lets Krateros drag him off, his chest heaving with each breath. It's a struggle to keep himself upright.

The grooves of Krateros' lined face are more pronounced. He looks like he's lost weight and gained years, not in wisdom but in stress. His beard is a lighter grey, no longer the dark brown it had once been. His left eye, blinded, looks milkier than it had been, the corners lined red.

Towering olive and oak trees cast speckled shadows on the grass. Mydei stands across from Krateros, keeping a distance. While Krateros doesn't smell as offensive as the other alphas, his scent still has Mydei on edge.

Krateros says, voice low with urgency. "Mydeimos, you need to go."

The spring air is fresh and free of pheromones. He can finally breathe again, taking in deep breaths to get rid of the alpha coating his lungs.

"It's not safe for you here," Krateros continues.

"It's not safe for me here?" Mydei echos, crossing his arms. "Am I not the leader of the Kremnoans?"

"Don't be daft."

"I'm only getting started. Isn't it your desire to have me more present?" Mydei says. He cracks his neck and rolls his shoulders. A part of him wants to continue with the spars, but he

had left the challengers in rough shape, going too far in the blaze of battle. Phainon could easily match him, a voice whispers. He ignores it. “I have time today.”

“Are you looking to go into heat in front of everyone? If that is your choice, so be it. I won’t be able to rescue you if it comes to it.”

Mydei freezes.

“There are hundreds of alphas here. You may be strong, my young lord, but do not overestimate yourself when surrounded by this many pent-up soldiers.”

Mydei steadies his breathing. “I have no clue what you’re talking about.”

“You’re on the verge of collapse,” Krateros says. “And you’re agitating the soldiers. It won’t end well. Heed my warning, Mydeimos. I know you better than you think.”

“I don’t—I’ve never—I’m not an omega,” he chokes out. His words shake with a type of urgency, a need to convince, though he’s aware it’s futile.

Krateros *knows* and has known for a while now.

“I am aware of my limits,” Mydei says before turning and walking back into the training hall.

The mood of the soldiers has changed, even as they continue through structured training drills. Some soldiers eye him with disdain, while others turn away the moment Mydei looks in their direction.

His boots echo off the stone floor as he makes his way toward the omega recruits. He sticks with them. Every so often, his vision fades in and out, but it’s bearable. His thighs, however, are grossly wet, and he’s sure his pants have already soaked through.

“Lord Mydei—” Iavokos begins, noticing the lack of color in his face.

“I’m fine,” Mydei manages, staggering. “Continue with the drills.”

The atmosphere is stifling. Everywhere he turns, there’s another alpha soldier, eyeing him, watching him.

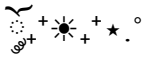
He feels exposed, naked. The scent patches rub against his skin and he wants so badly to rip them off and rake his nails down his nape until liquid gold runs down his back. Anything to make the ache stop.

There’s a force pushing him down like hands gripping his throat.

When he’s with the omega recruits, it’s easier. They don’t eye him like they’re expecting something from him. He feels safer with them, less a fish out of water when once the training hall had been his safe place.

“My young lord,” Krateros says, approaching once more. The concern in his grey eyes has Mydei faltering. He hasn’t seen such an expression in years.

“I’ll go,” Mydei bites out. “Keep an eye out on the soldiers.”



In a daze, Mydei stumbles around the Kremnoan district, following the familiar stone paths he knows like the back of his hand.

He had been here for all of it, the construction of the temple of Nikador, a pathetic imitation of what they have in Castrum Kremnos but enough for his people to worship, the creation of the central plaza with the lionhead fountain, crafted by a now retired renowned Kremnoan craftsman.

The bustle of the plaza doesn’t match that of Mamorael Market, but the Kremnoans have carved out their own subset of the city for themselves.

Mydei stays in the shadows, walking through corridor after corridor. He doesn’t go into the light, unable to brave the dawn’s rays. There’s no need for the extra attention, not when his vision fades in and out every few seconds.

Vendors shout their wares. Kremnoan children laugh as they scurry around, wooden swords in hand.

“I want to be a big strong warrior! Like Lord Mydeimos!” a little boy says, waving his sword around.

His friend laughs and chases after him.

Mydei continues to walk, listless in his step. The walls are caving in on him. He stumbles through the alleyways until he lands in front of a familiar mural. He knows this as the decorated path of strife that goes straight to the main temple of Nikador. Various paintings of Castrum Kremnos through the ages line the stone walls, stories of the glorious triumphs of the once prosperous city state and of the celebrated violence that Kremnoans had inflicted on their path to glory.

King Gorgo stands atop a cliff, triumphant after slaying the feared Chryseus Leo with his bare hands. He dangles the beast’s head, a crown of gold and rubies atop his head, red cape fluttering in the breeze. The beast’s dead body is beside him and below are his subjects, cheering and offering up their praises. At the top of the mural, Nikador shines in a radiant light, the titan gazing down on the victorious king.

Mydei runs his hand over the painting, dust building on the leather of his gauntlets.

Castrum Kremnos had been founded by an alpha king, had been maintained by generation after generation of alpha rulers. There's never been an omega on the throne, never a chance to allow what they deemed as weakness on the throne.

But he can't change who he is. He can hide, yes. He can pretend all he wants, ignore the fire and ache brewing beneath his skin, the wetness between his legs, but the truth remains. He wonders how his mother must think of him, how disappointed she must be that her son is so weak. He's never met her, never knew her before he had been thrown into the sea, even if her signet ring weighs in his pocket.

His countrymen are so blinded in their belief of him being an alpha when he had never proclaimed to be one. It was never a question of his secondary gender. Alpha or nothing. That's how it was, and at the time, he hadn't cared. It was no bother what his countrymen assumed as long as he was able to keep the peace.

His eyes burn, and before he knows it, a tear runs down his cheek and more follow. He leans his forehead against the stone wall, hiding his shame from view. He only hopes no one passes by, but that's a tall order. It doesn't matter.

A tear lands on the stone floor. A lily blooms, beautiful, fragile white petals, lightly pink in the center. He bends down and holds it, cradling it as if it were his child.

In a day's time, the lily will wilt and die. Its delicate beauty is fleeting, awash by the tides of time until only a memory remains. Softly sweet and delicate, many would view it as weakness.

He holds in a sob. His breaths come out shaky.

The flower crystallizes. His vision swirls.

Mydei blacks out.

Chapter End Notes

the cat's out of the bag! now, its angst time 😳 and ofc another cliffhanger bc i can't help myself

i have sm planned for this fic. the ride isn't over just yet

thanks for reading!!

twitter

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

i want to thank everyone for all the love and support! 💞

this chapter is another fun one :3

cw. masturbation, descriptions of drowning

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The evernight is a wasteland of the broken.

Echoes of the past whisper for the times long lost, and the remnants of once powerful, vibrant city-states stand cloaked in darkness. There's nothing here but the forces of nature that have wrangled back control. Curling vines crawl through decrepit buildings and tufts of grass burst through splintered tile floors.

Phainon treks up the winding stone path, careful not to stumble into any loose branches. It's a windy night, the evergreen leaves rustle a gentle whisper in his ear. This is what is left of Amphoreus—ruins of civilizations that no longer stand, save for broken passages and crumbled tomes, unreadable from decay. Every time he ventures out, he's struck with the reality that Okhema is all there is left of the once proud and lively Amphoreus. The last bastion of humanity.

Enchanted bronze braziers light his way, as if expecting his arrival. It's a little eerie, but he's glad for the light and the clear direction forward. His boots clack upon stone.

Titankin crawl in these sorts of areas, attracted to the energies of once sacred prayer grounds. The desecration of these one glorious temples by creatures of the night and the corruption that stains Amphoreus is a pity, but it does serve as great areas for testing his combat prowess.

Normally, he'd have Mydei here with him. They would compete over who could kill more titankin or who could reach the highest level of the temple first, all in the name of friendly rivalry. Grim situations are better with another, especially someone as effortlessly powerful and confident as Mydei.

Only now… Phainon forces a smile, if only to keep his morale up. He doesn't want to think about it.

Combat comes easy for a warrior like him. His entrance into the temple is met with a hoard of monsters. Titankin after titankin fall. The veins in his arms bulge with each slash.

He loses himself to the rhythm of battle. Adrenaline lights up his body. He had forewent the patches and lotions completely, allowing his scent to flow free, unrestricted. Monsters grow vicious in his presence, attracted to the scent of death and destruction, the char of ash from smoking battlefields. It feels good letting loose and allowing his weapon to speak for him. The titankin stand no chance. He slices through them as if they were made of butter.

The mission Aglaea had given him had been simple—clear out as many monsters as possible and explore a recently discovered temple of Oronyx for any signs of the titan and coreflame. She had called him up for an impromptu meeting, a knowing look in her eye as she laid out the instruction. If she hadn't given him the mission, more an excuse to get him out of Okhema than anything else, he would have left on his own. He'd rather brave the cold of the evernight than stay in Okhema amidst the shame and embarrassment and the realization that this entire time, he had been oblivious to what had been so obvious.

Because fuck.

He doesn't think he can face Mydei ever again. Not after that.

It was as he had feared. There was a distance between them that couldn't be breached. Mydei didn't trust him, and he blew any chance of Mydei ever trusting him.

His movements are swift, precise. He lashes out, baring his canines as he slams through a hoard of monsters. He blows through an entire floor's worth in less than an hour.

He had shed his ruined outercoat and armor long ago, leaving himself in only a high collared compression shirt. Not the best protection against the monster's blades, he can admit. Aglaea is sure to give him an earful when he returns, but that's the least of his worries. Normally, he's particular about keeping his clothing and appearance as pristine as possible, but not this time.

There's a light trickling of stale water from what was once a grandiose waterfall, the scent of mildew and dirt flourishing in the damp air. The statue of Oronyx in the center of the hall has eroded into nothing but a slab of cracked stone and the base it had been standing on.

Sweat beads his brow, and he wipes it away. He takes in the sight, at the staircase that beckons him upwards. There's nothing here aside from monsters.

"So, how'd it go?" Cipher asks.

Phainon jolts and nearly swings his greatsword at her. Luckily, he catches himself in time and it embeds into the stone beside her feet.

He catches his breath and says, "How do you think it went?" He yanks his weapon out, causing a splintering in the already crumbling temple floor.

Cipher whistles. "Judging from the lack of Mydei and the atrocious alpha pheromones stinking up the place, I'm guessing not so great…"

Phainon stalks up the staircase. The last person he wants to see is Cipher, but once she's sunk her claws into a victim, she doesn't let go. He's the latest in her games.

Somehow, she's there when he makes it to the top. It's darker up here. No flickering flames to light the way, no gleaming of magical runes carved into the temple wall. It's also smaller, and his pheromones saturate the space with no path of escape. Cipher reacts, and Phainon holds himself back before he can ask her what's wrong.

"I've never met an alpha who smells like you do," Cipher says, wrinkling her nose. She fans the air, as if it would make a difference. "Emotional alphas smell musty and sour. It's disgusting. But you… you smell like how Dolos did when it was destroyed."

"I didn't think I would have company," Phainon grits his teeth. "Forgive me for not preparing ahead of time."

It takes a few moments for her words to register. To other alphas, he's been told he smells like an opponent, a foe to cut down, conquer. To betas, his scent is unpleasant and acrid, but to omegas, he smells like a calamity.

Omegas seek warmth and comfort, and Phainon is the very opposite. He's taken solace in it. It's night impossible to change his charred scent, nor remove the memories of the day his life as a simple village boy burned into ashes before his very eyes.

"Aren't you an alpha?" he asks.

From the darkness, a titankin comes barreling at them. In one fluid motion, Cipher jumps to the side, the monster's blade missing her by a mere centimeter. "Ouch! That one almost got to me!"

Phainon cuts it down.

The demigod of trickery has no scent. Tales spin her as an alpha, and it's regarded as fact that she is indeed one, for how could the legendary cat thief be anything but an alpha? Either way, it doesn't matter. Whatever she is, she's still Cipher.

And by that, he means a nuisance. When he met her for the first time, many years ago, he wanted to be her friend. She looked rather lonely, hiding in the shadows as she stared at the laughing children. Her expression had been one of yearning, but she remained in the dark. It was as if there was a barrier that she couldn't cross, unable to brave the dawn's rays for longer than a moment's notice. All it took was one look, and he knew they couldn't be friends. He had been sneered at, mocked as Okhema's darling. Aglaea's *new* favorite.

The second floor is the same as the first, down to the decrepit waterfall and remains of the Oronyx statue. He takes little note of it. Many multifloored temples follow in a similar format.

The coreflame of Oronyx is a mystery. No one knows where the titan has gone. The discovery of this newly unearthed temple could give answers, or it could be yet another dead end. The trees had grown dense, covering it from view. For a temple to be in the middle of

the forest, between large stretches of civilization, it left a less than stellar omen. But a clue is a clue, and Aglaea needed someone experienced to chase it down.

Cipher lets out a sigh of relief. “So, the cat’s out of the bag!”

“...” Phainon braces himself.

“Mydei is in heat,” Cipher continues.

His throat closes. Against common sense, he asks, “And how is that my problem?”

He doesn’t wait for her to answer. There are more titankin to kill. In one swift movement, he hacks through two more. They aren’t particularly difficult monsters to defeat, given their lack of self-awareness. The ones corrupted by the black tide are a great deal heartier, their touch corrosive, but, like the rest of the monsters that lurk in the evernight, they fall to his greatsword.

“He’s been calling for you in his sleep,” Cipher says, pouncing in front of him before leaning forward, beckoning him closer as if revealing a great secret. “Our little immortal prince has been murmuring Deliverer over and over in that mighty cute way of his. You know, the one where he sounds like a purring lion.”

“Probably because he’s thinking of strangling me. Thank you for that, by the way.”

Cipher has the audacity to laugh and clap him on the back, acting as if he’s told a great joke.

It’s not funny. His eye twitches, but he steadies himself. Cipher wants him to react, that much is true. He’s not giving it to her.

“Contrary to what you think, I’m not here to sabotage you,” she says. “I’ve been on your side since the beginning.”

In a flash, she’s gone and two nearby titankin slam onto the ground, kicking up a storm of dust. “I simply wanted you to confess.” She drags one dead titankin atop another and smushes them together. They fall in a tangled heap onto the floor. “Like that!”

Phainon grimaces. Not the greatest visual, but it does its job. If only it were that easy.

“A grand exchange of love and passion! The two of you falling into bed together and ending this whole tiresome situation. Mnestia must be in deep despair watching the two of you prance around each other like you’re both barefoot, stepping on hot coals.”

It sounds too idealistic to ever come true. Did she think it was that easy? Mydei doesn’t even desire him that way. He also doesn’t know where the signet ring went, considering Cipher had snatched it away from him *again* before he could even think of formulating a plan to confess.

“Where did you put the ring?” Phainon asks.

Cipher smiles. “Use that pretty little head of yours.”

“His nest,” Phainon states. Internally, he curses himself.

“Bingo!”

Of course it was in Mydei’s nest. Where else would it have been? No wonder he couldn’t find it. Entering Mydei’s room had been a bad decision all around. He shouldn’t have gone in, but he needed the ring back, and Cipher wouldn’t tell him where she hid it.

“If you want it, go and find it~” she had told him, gesturing to Mydei’s room, the door swung wide open. “Or he will. I’m sure you don’t want to ruin the surprise. It’d be a shame…”

She opened the door wider, giving Phainon a glimpse of Mydei’s bed and what looked to be… a nest?

It was a momentary impulse. His first instinct had been, was the omega there with him? Living with him? Jealousy curled in his gut, overtaking all reason. Yet, he remained planted, conflicted.

So, Cipher, legendary speed and all, disappeared then reappeared behind him and kicked him straight into the room. He tumbled and landed facefirst onto the floor, right in front of the impeccably prepared nest. His fate was sealed.

He should have left immediately. Had his brains not been a jumble and the flames of jealousy stoked in his chest, maybe he would have. Unfortunately, he stayed.

A mistake. A lapse in judgement. Mydei hates him now, and he deserves it.

“I was saving it,” Phainon says. “I wanted the perfect time to give it to him, to make my feelings known.”

“And that’s why you suck!” Cipher twirls her finger around in a spinning motion. “Mr. Boring! It’s always the same answer from you.”

Phainon frowns. His grip on his greatsword tightens.

“At the rate you were going, you would have never confessed if I didn’t throw you off the deep end. You keep second guessing yourself.”

“You’re having fun with this, aren’t you?”

“Maybe a little!” Cipher tries a grin, but her lips shake at the corners. She clears her throat and promptly steps on the wrong tile.

There’s a clicking noise, then silence.

“Oops,” Cipher says. “Wasn’t supposed to do that…”

“What did you do?”

The floor begins to rumble, and Cipher grabs him by the collar. In a flash, they land on a platform above, just in time to watch a trap door open from where they had just been standing. “These interruptions. Ugh. Anyways, you’re wasting your time, you know.”

Phainon yanks himself out of her grasp. His heart feels like it’s about to pop. “You set me up.”

“I did. Had I not done anything, would you have ever confessed to Mydei?”

“I was waiting for the right time.”

“And when would that be?”

“... I was working on it.”

Cipher’s eye twitches. It doesn’t escape Phainon’s notice of how she’s trying her best not to breathe in his presence.

“Do you want me to confess to him for you?” Cipher asks, venom dripping with each word. “You can take the spoils. That way you won’t fuck up again. Little lion will never know. I’m a great actress! The best, actually.” She sobers up at the end.

Phainon shakes his head. Nothing that comes out of her mouth can be trusted. What is her end goal? It’s nigh impossible to elucidate the strange workings of her mind nor does he want to try. If she were to pretend to be him, it’d be a great way to make an already precarious situation worse, especially if Mydei were to find out.

But that being said, how did he not notice it sooner? It was obvious by all means that Mydei wasn’t an alpha. Had he been so blindsided to believe in what Mydei, himself, had never confirmed?

Cipher remains a wide distance away from him, gaze studying the remnants of the Oronyx statue at the end of the hall.

They make it up the next staircase. Another dark, dusty hallway full of titankin and another main hall with the same waterfall and statue. Unfortunately, Phainon’s a little distracted to take note.

“He’s an omega,” Phainon says. By now, his compression shirt has started to shred, and his arms are littered with small cuts that drip gold.

Cipher remains unscathed save for the scrunching of her expression every so often. “Yes, he is. Very observant of you.”

“How did I not get it sooner?”

“It’s not all your fault,” Cipher says, and that rouses him more than any of her jabs. “Well, sort of. Eh, kind of?”

“What?” Phainon asks.

“Don’t worry your pretty little head about that,” Cipher waves him off. The cat-shaped accessory on her neck clacks as she turns back to stare at him. “Anyhow, this is where we’re at right now. The little lion is in heat. What will you do?”

“I—”

“Wrong.”

“I haven’t even said anything yet.”

“Yeah, because whatever nonsense comes out of that giant mouth of yours will only worsen the situation! So, I’m gonna tell you what to do.”

Phainon feels a headache incoming. “What makes you think I’ll trust you?”

“Considering the choices you have made thus far have led you nowhere, I would say you have a pretty good chance!”

“I don’t need your help.” He really doesn’t,

“The veil has been lifted, yet you still act like this…” Cipher sighs, shaking her head. She looks back at him, pity in her eyes, as if she’s staring at a helpless little puppy instead of a grown man.

He’s missing a big piece in the puzzle, he’s aware of that, but he also doesn’t expect to be given any answers. That’s how it’s been lately. Left in the dark.

Regardless, he asks, “What veil?”

As he expects, Cipher doesn’t respond. Instead, she hops off the platform and scurries around the hall, clicking all sorts of mechanisms, messing with runes, and toppling pillars. Loud thuds echo through the hall, creating enough of a ruckus to summon a hoard of titankin swarming in their direction.

“What are you doing?!” Phainon yells as he parries an attack. One of them manages to slice his cheek, dripping gold down his face.

“You piss me off,” Cipher says. “What can I say? It’s fun testing what goes on in these temples. Use that brain of yours. You have one, right? We’ve been stuck on this floor for a while now.”

“Oh.” He’s never been met with this sort of trap before, but he also doesn’t take to exploring temples of Oronyx. “Is that why you haven’t dragged me back to Okhema? We can’t leave.”

“You only noticed now?” Cipher says. “And you’re supposed to be the grand hero of deliverance, savior of Amphoreus, usherer of the Era Nova? Stupid alpha…”

He can’t argue, not when he’s slamming titankin into the ground and chasing after Cipher who’s somersaulting over the crumbling floors and monsters with ease, leaving Phainon to fend for himself.

She shouts at him, “Ever since we got to this floor, it’s been the same. This is why you don’t go into suspicious looking temples alone! Surely, that’s the first thing Aglaea taught you. Where’s your survival instinct, rascal?”

“This was a solo mission,” Phainon says, narrowly evading the swing of a blade. Sweat stings his eyes as he jumps onto another platform. He nearly slips on a puddle and falls on his face.

“See how frustrating this is?” Cipher continues, watching Phainon struggle to steady his breathing. “This is how I feel dealing with you.”

Phainon glares at her. His arms tremble from exertion, from killing what felt like a thousand titankin in the span of an hour.

“Ha! Finally!” Cipher grins, looking so proud of herself with her chest puffed out like she’s won a prize. “I didn’t know Okhema’s golden boy could glare like that! Oh, how scary!” She pouts and places a hand on her chest. “If only someone would come and save me! Princess Homebody, perhaps… Maybe I should call her, she would know how to deal with you.”

The reminder of Castorice lights an idea in his head. She had dealt with something like this before and had made haste to alert the other heirs about it. A time loop mechanism, she called it.

“The Oronyx statue,” Phainon says, pointing to it. “The enchantment is connected to the statue.”

“Bravo! Took you long enough!” Cipher exclaims, propelling herself forwards.

He only wishes he had her agility. What he lacks in speed, he matches in strength. His calf muscles burn, and his canines sink into his lip. His bangs fly in his face, but he can’t stall. They have to get out of here.

Cipher turns back and says, “You know, Cassie wanted you to confess on your own. She didn’t want me to step in. She’s been trying to nudge you two together for some time now.”

I know, Phainon wants to say. It’s rather obvious that she’s been trying to push them together, but Mydei isn’t moved in the slightest. Even after all the scenting, the touches in the baths…

Shouldn’t Mydei be aware of it? The boundaries that have been crossed.

When they make it to the statue, Phainon is heaving for air, hands on his knees. He’s sure that once this whole ordeal is over, he’ll be sore all over. Even his biceps are beginning to cramp.

Cipher places her hand on the Oronyx symbol carved at the base and whispers what sounds to be a prayer. Behind the statue, two pathways manifest, one carved with a symbol of the moon and the other the sun.

“Mmm, quite the sticky situation we’re in,” Cipher laughs. Her nose wrinkles. “Let’s split up.”

Phainon frowns. “Didn’t you say—”

“Let’s split up,” Cipher bites out. “You try your best to figure your way out, and I will too. We don’t have time. You want to get out of here or not? You have your omega waiting for you.”

“My omega?” Phainon echoes.

“Yes, you idiot,” Cipher hisses. “Now, get a move on.”

Against better judgement, he splits up with Cipher.



Water.

Everywhere.

In his lungs. Burning his eyes. Flooding his ears.

Each gulp is another mouthful. His lungs burn. The rest of his body is cold.

He tries to thrash, but there’s nothing to grab, only the silence of the water and the hideous monsters that lurk beneath its endless depths. The light grows dimmer, his struggles for naught. His limbs don’t respond to his commands like he’s been strapped down with lead weights.

Alarms blare in his head. Panic sets in.

Another gasp for air. Another flood of water.

It *burns*.

Mydei falls.

Weak. Why is he so weak? He should be stronger. He needs to be stronger—He needs… He—He…

Then *nothing*.

“It is not your time, my child,” a female voice whispers, gentle and warm. Once again, Mydei is greeted by the silhouette of a woman, the one that guides him towards the light, as she does, time and time again. He hasn’t met her in years, and it’s almost a comfort to see her.

He knows what’s coming next.

His eyes snap open, yet he's still submerged by the tides. Once more, water floods his lungs, and he gasps and flails and struggles. The weight remains tied to his limbs, his movements weak, his body uncooperative, and he continues to sink.

His lungs give out. His heart stops. The cycle repeats.

Eventually, the monsters, jagged, vicious creatures that swarm the abyssal depths, find him, eager to take their meal. He's torn to shreds. Stitched back together again. Then torn to shreds once more. The woman's voice whispers in his ear, dragging him back to the world of the living. He sees her, and she always says the same, her presence familiar in a way that it shouldn't be but is.

He tries to reach for the light, the surface where stars meet the sky, but he's dragged down before he can even hope to break the water.

This shouldn't be happening. Panic burgeons. He's not an infant anymore. He's braved the sea of souls and left victorious. So, how? How is he back here? Even as he sinks, his arm shoots for the surface, pitiful and futile.

Time slows. The fever lessens, then stops. The weight upon his body is removed, and he has control once again. He tears the sea monsters into shreds with his bare hands, crimson blooming like lilies in the water.

He makes it to shore. The fire has long been quenched, and he remains as he had before, unscathed, save for the memories, hazy as they are. There's no telling how long he's been down there, and his body remains pristine, bearing no marks, no scars.

He kneels in the sand, the push of salty water against his knees. Crabs scuttle in the sand, and the crash of waves is loud in his ears.

Stars spot the night sky. Far away and out of reach. In a trance, he reaches out regardless, a cold breeze against his wet skin like a caress of the damned.

Behind him is the crunch of familiar footsteps.

Mydei's eyes snap open.

He gasps for breath, back arching off the bed, fingertips white from how tightly he's gripping the bedsheets. There's a flood of water in his lungs, and he panics. Around him is a blur of whites, crimsons, and golds.

And air. Lots of it.

He's not in the ocean. No. This isn't the Kremnoan district either. There's no familiar sight of the worn cobblestone steps nor the gleam of sharpened gold pillars. He's not faced with King Gorgo, looking down at him as if pitying him, nor is he faced with Nikador, who must be scornful at such a weak display of Kremnoan royalty.

Has the Castrum Kremnos fallen that far? Nikador would roar.

Mydei presses a hand to his cheek, feeling the wetness beneath the pads of his fingers. The tears continue to fall, and he raises his arm to cover his face, his shame. He lets them, doesn't try to hold them back. It's only him in this room anyways.

His nose is tickled by the scent of lavender and vanilla, wafting in from the candles that Castorice likes to light, warm and sweet. With each inhale, the pressure against his chest lessens. There's no sharp scent of salt, no iron tang of blood. He's not floating. He's in his bed, body indenting into the soft mattress from how long he's laid unconscious.

Mydei sits up and winces at the accompanying throbbing between his legs and the swaying of his vision. There's a lightness to his body, the familiar metal plating of his armor gone. Instead, he's been clothed in thin nightrobes, the very ones that Aglaea had gifted him, deep crimson and silken to the touch.

His nest no longer resembles such. His pillows are thrown about, landing in all corners of his room, and his bedsheets, soaked with sweat, have been shredded like a feral animal had torn through them. His favorite quilted comforter lies in a heap on the floor, and his poor plushies are a mess around the room. His Beagle Coconut plushie stares up at him from the floor, as if judging him for this mess, and Mydei reaches down to grab it.

He must have fought in his sleep, lashing out and screaming judging from the dryness of his throat. He feels like he's swallowed a mouthful of sand.

The sea of souls is a time in his life that he doesn't think about. He rather not remember the years spent drowning and reviving, and even the sight of a large body of water has adrenaline lighting up every nerve in his body.

Mydei cradles Beagle Coconut against his chest. "Sorry," he whispers to it, stroking at its soft fur.

It was the summer of his fifteenth year. He remembers it clearly. The heat had sweltered, and he found himself down with a strange case of fever. By then, he had already been under Krateros' care and had been in the midst of training to lead the Kremnoan detachment and avenge his mother. Even as a mere teenager, he was placed upon a pedestal.

He rarely ever got sick, his immune system and metabolism boosted due to his curse of immortality. Initially, he thought nothing of it, too busy ignoring the discomfort until the fragments of an ember became a wildfire.

Everything had hurt. Everything was too hot. The sun seared his vision. His ears rang. His body crumpled in on itself, and he could hardly walk without a stumble.

He told no one, not Krateros, not Hephaestion, not the rest of his closest companions, and left the campgrounds in the middle of the night.

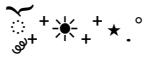
Six years after pulling himself out of the wretched sea of souls, he found himself back in those same cold waters. He kept a wide berth from any bodies of water, but desperation to quench the fire within his body had stripped him of his rational mind and left him scrambling to abate the pain. It felt like he was being burned alive.

The fever. The dizziness. The confusion.

Not a simple illness. Not a strange plague.

It wasn't an illness at all. Mydei’s grip on Beagle Coconut tightens.

So, that’s what it was.



There’s a light but rhythmic knock at his door.

Mydei rouses from his sleep and blinks away the heaviness strapped behind his eyes. He has been teetering on the edge for awhile now, unable to reach the reprieve that is unconsciousness. His body wouldn’t let him, not with the dream still fresh on his mind and the incessant, idiotic whisperings that his chosen mate isn’t here.

“Yes?” he croaks out. He clears his throat, wincing at the astringency in his mouth.

“Lord Mydei,” Castorice says. “Lady Hyacine is with me. We bought some food and tea for you.”

Briefly, Mydei reaches up to pat his locks down, messy as they are from all his tossing and turning, but gives up halfway. There’s little use in attempting to look presentable. His room already looks half-way torn to pieces.

The thought of food has his stomach twisting, empty as it is. He’s not sure how long he’s been out, but his teleslate is out of reach, and he doesn’t have the energy to grab it to check.

“You can come in,” he says.

The door creaks open. Castorice enters with a tray of goodies, her movements slow and cautious as if trying not to scare a frightened animal. Hyacine trails after her, her usual cheery smile nowhere to be seen.

The tray is set on his nightstand. A bowl of porridge, some fresh grapes and figs, and a cup of steaming herbal tea.

Castorice hands him the mug. “Be careful.”

“Thank you,” he whispers. He takes small sips, delighting in the feel of the warm glass beneath his fingertips and the fragrant floral taste. He can’t bring himself to look at either of them. He knows what awaits him.

Hyacine remains silent. Little Ica isn't with her this time. It's a little odd not having the plump pegasus fluttering beside her.

"My apologies for the mess," Mydei says, glancing at the wreckage that was his nest. Even his nightlamp is shattered on the floor. "Please be careful about the glass shards."

Castorice nods. Hyacine's fists clench.

Minutes pass. Mydei continues to sip at his drink. His hands tremble as does the rest of his body, alternating between cycles of chills and blistering heat.

No one speaks a word. Not Mydei who's content to bask in the silence even if his surroundings begin to cave in on him. Not Hyacine who stays deathly still. Not Castorice who gives a nervous, forced smile.

Mydei places his empty mug down, the glass clinking against the metal tray.

Castorice take a deep breath and begins, "We wanted to see if you were—"

"What were you thinking?" Hyacine interrupts. "You snuck out in the middle of your first heat to go to the Kremnoan district of all places!"

Mydei stares at his lap.

Hyacine gives a disbelieving laugh, almost hysterical. "Are you an idiot? It's like you wanted to hurt yourself!"

"Lady Hyacine—"

Hyacine's voice pitches louder. "Had Krateros and Lady Aglaea not been keeping an eye on you, who knows what would have happened… Lord Mydei, you—Why? I never thought of you as the type to do something so needlessly reckless! Do you know how much danger you put yourself in?!"

He doesn't need to be told what he did was stupid, but it does sting a little. Hyacine is never one to raise her voice, never one to lose her cool even in the face of death, but there's no defending his actions. The fire in his body had roared until the only thing on his mind was to quench the flame, release the pent up energy, the need to do something, anything overwhelming all reason. He couldn't just lay there and allow himself to be consumed.

The first time, he had thrown himself out to sea, then vowed to never again lose himself to irrationality. His father had lost himself to the madness. He would not be his father. Only he's remained the same, even if he has grown in years. Both times, Krateros had a front row seat.

"You could have gotten hurt! I understand that you're immortal, Lord Mydei, but that doesn't mean you should be actively throwing yourself into these situations!" Hyacine yells. She trembles, turquoise eyes wide and blazing.

Castorice's gaze flits between the two of them as if debating between stopping Hyacine or allowing her to continue. It's a bad place to be, in between all this.

Mydei can't fault her for hesitating nor can he fault Hyacine for her outburst.

Hyacine looks gaunt. Deepset eyebags decorate her face and her features lack the sparkle that he's used to. Even her cotton candy pigtails have wilted. She looks as if she hasn't had a good night's sleep in weeks.

"I'm sorry," Mydei says. "My decisions led to this outcome, even when you warned me repeatedly to be careful. I was selfish, and I let everyone down. It won't happen again."

His actions weren't only for himself. Both Hyacine and Castorice carry the weight of his actions. They've been by his side, supporting him, but patience has its limits.

What has he done to repay them? If anything, he's only added to their stress. In attempting to deny his omega nature—who he's been this *entire* time—he's only hurt them. As a warrior, it's his duty to protect, but this is a different type of battlefield, and he's done nothing but cower.

"Lord Mydei," Castorice says, reaching out to pat him on the shoulder. "It's not your fault. This is your first heat, and heirs tend to have more violent cycles."

"It's not my first heat," Mydei corrects.

Castorice pauses, her hand suspended mid air. "Huh?"

"I presented at a normal age," Mydei continues. He wraps his robes tighter around himself. "I didn't know what it was at the time, just that I would do anything to stop myself from burning from the inside out. I drowned myself in the sea of souls to escape the feeling. "

"You drowned yourself," Hyacine echoes.

"I didn't mean to," he says, as if it would make the situation any better.

It's a little strange admitting this. He hasn't quite come to terms with it either, considering how fresh the dream is. He can still feel the monsters sinking their talons into him and the delirium from the lack of oxygen.

"How old were you?"

"Fifteen."

Hyacine's anger melts away, leaving her sullen and almost empty. She frowns, "Omegas usually present around that age, yes, but if that's the case then how come you've held no scent or indication of being an omega until recently."

"I think I suppressed it," Mydei says. Spoken aloud, it sounds even more outlandish than when it was a theory floating in his head. "I didn't know that I was presenting. I thought I was sick."

"You didn't tell an adult?" Castorice asks.

“Didn’t have anyone I could tell,” Mydei says. “And besides, I was training to lead an army back home. I couldn’t afford to show any signs of weakness.”

“Being an omega isn’t a weakness,” Hyacine argues.

“To Kremnoan soldiers, it is,” Mydei says.

The soldier’s words burn in his head. A bitch in heat has no place as a Kremnoan warrior. He shouldn’t have gone to the training hall. It was obvious what awaited him.

“I’ve never heard of an omega suppressing their nature,” Hyacine murmurs. “That’s quite the situation… I’ll have to look more into it.”

“What made you present this time?” Castorice asks. It’d be an innocuous, well-meaning question if he didn’t know her so well.

Hyacine mouths a silent, “Are you serious?”

Castorice smiles and continues to play dumb.



Phainon.

All he thinks about is Phainon.

His dumb moonlight hair that frames his face just right. His stupid blue eyes that crinkle at the edges. His idiotic smile and even more idiotic laugh.

Mydei hides beneath his blankets, eyes screwed shut while he tries to force the thoughts out of his head.

Phainon doesn’t want him the way he wants Phainon.

His alpha doesn’t want him. His alpha doesn’t want anything to do with him. His alpha doesn’t even like omegas.

For the love of Nikador, shut up.

Mydei grits his teeth.

He wants to hit something. Punch and lash out. Snarl and growl like an injured, feral animal. There’s so much pent up energy, and his limbs tremble and twitch with the need to release. There’s that part of him that whispers to go back to the Kremnoan district, but he promised he wouldn’t do anything rash, and he’s not sure if he has it in him to face Krateros this early.

There's only him and the freaky looking blue dildo sitting on his nightstand. Hyacine lectured him about the importance of sexual health and how even a fake knot is better than no knot whilst eyeing said object. Castorice agreed, even if her cheeks colored as she looked at the terrifying toy.

He promised them that he would text or call out for them if he needed help or if he desired company. Castorice had been adamant that having a platonic heat partner would aid in the ordeal, but the thought of spending a heat with anyone but Phainon had that wretched side of him crying out in objection.

Besides, he's already caused enough trouble. He won't call for help. He can brave this. Alone. They both have enough to deal with as it is. And he won't cause another scene. He won't leave the confines of his room.

Fingernails dig crescents into his palms. The throbbing between his legs is dizzying. Each movement has him gasping, trembling.

Fuck. He should have listened to Hyacine when he had the chance. He shouldn't have disregarded her advice in favor of whatever it is he has going on with Phainon. Curse the Deliverer and his stupidly strong pheromones. And while he can't smell his own pheromones, he can feel heat surge through his body, radiating out in waves.

Another hour of twisting and turning goes by, and Mydei finally gives in to the ache between his thighs. He scrambles to his feet and locks the door, reminding himself to thank the girls for helping him clean up the shattered glass. Slick drips, thick and warm, down his legs, causing him to wince.

He grabs the dildo and spreads his legs. Maybe he should oil it and open himself up, but he's leaking enough slick as it is. He's never fucked himself on a toy like this before, even if he has fucked himself on his fingers to the thought of Phainon inside him.

The dildo goes in with little resistance. It burns at first, the stretch foreign and overwhelming. Even three of his fingers can't match the thickness. The first inch goes down with a groan, the silicone cold inside him, but the rest is easy. His hole flutters, swallowing the toy without him even trying, even the bulbous knot.

His legs tremble, spread wide to accommodate, and by titans, it feels good. His lips part in a silent moan as he bucks his hips forwards. One hand strokes his cock, the other thrusting the toy in and out in a frantic rhythm.

It's not enough, doesn't reach deep enough. He knows Phainon could reach deeper, could satiate him. Mydei cries out, fucking himself faster and faster until his vision whites, and he sees stars. Still, not enough.

Unsatisfied, he rides the dildo, spearing himself on the knot until he's delirious. He can almost imagine that it's Phainon inside him, whispering how good he feels and how well Mydei takes him. How good of an omega Mydei is for his alpha.

He’d sit on Phainon’s lap and milk his cock until his knot inflates inside him, locking them together. They’d stay nestled together, heartbeats thrumming as one.

“Deliverer, please…” Mydei gasps. “I’ll be good. Please—Please come back…”

Chapter End Notes

the girls looking after mydei while phainon and cipher beef in the background 😭 phainon cipher interactions are so much fun, especially when phainon is trying to keep the peace vs cipher trying to piss him off

i also want to thank danmei for my tendency to inject yearning into everything i write bc i can't stop and this fic has become a monster of yearning. i physically cannot write a fic without a boat load of yearning on both sides and we all know how down bad mydei and phainon are for each other even if they show it in different ways. that's what i love about them, how dedicated they are to each other and they fit each other like pieces of a puzzle (the soulmatism is real!!)

thank you for reading!

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